THE COMPLETE HANDBOOK

OPERATING SYSTEMS MASTERY

From Fundamentals to Advanced Systems, Linux & Interviews

Beginner · Intermediate · Advanced · Interview Mastery

Processes · Threads · Scheduling · Synchronization · Deadlocks
Memory · Virtual Memory · File Systems · I/O · IPC · Storage
Networking · Linux Internals · Virtualization · Containers
100+ Interview Questions · Solved Numericals · 16 Projects

A SELF-CONTAINED LEARNING COURSE IN BOOK FORM

How to Use This Book

This is not a summary and not a list of topics. It is a complete, self-contained course that assumes you know almost nothing about operating systems and takes you all the way to the point where you can explain OS internals, solve numerical problems, write systems code, and answer senior-level interview questions with confidence.

You do not need another textbook alongside this one. Every concept is built from intuition first, then formalized with correct technical detail, then connected to real Linux behavior, real code, and the questions you will actually be asked. Read it front to back the first time — the order is deliberate, and later parts assume the earlier ones.

The Learning Path

Everything is organized along a single rising path. You will feel each part get a little deeper than the last, but never jump a step.



How Each Concept Is Taught

Important concepts are taught with the same repeatable structure so your brain learns how to learn them. You will not see all twelve labels spelled out every time — that would be noise — but every major idea moves through this arc:

Step	What it gives you
1. What is it?	A one-line, jargon-free definition.
2. Why do we need it?	The problem it solves — motivation before mechanism.
3. Simple intuition	An everyday analogy you already understand.
4. Technical explanation	The precise, correct definition with proper terms.
5. How it works internally	What the hardware and kernel actually do.
6. Example	A concrete, worked case — often in C or on the Linux shell.
7. Diagram	A picture that shows the real mechanism, not decoration.
8. Real-world example	Where this shows up in Linux, servers, or your laptop.
9. Related concepts	Links to ideas you have met or will meet.
10. Common mistakes	The traps that cost marks and interview offers.
11. Interview questions	How it is actually asked, with model answers.
12. Quick revision	The compressed version for the night before.

The Boxes — and What They Mean

Throughout the book, colored boxes flag the five things your eye should be able to find in seconds when revising:

> ▣ **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> The core idea, stated precisely. If you remember nothing else from a section, remember what is in these boxes.

> ⚑ **INTERVIEW TIP**
>
> Exactly how to phrase an answer, what the interviewer is really testing, and the follow-up they will ask next.

> ⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**
>
> A misconception almost everyone holds at first. Catching these is what separates a memorized answer from an understood one.

> ⚑ **REAL WORLD**
>
> Where the concept lives in an actual system — Linux, a database, a web server, your own machine.

> ↻ **QUICK REVISION**
>
> The compressed, high-density recap. Read these to warm up, and again the night before an exam or interview.

Other Elements

Code blocks
Real, compilable C/POSIX and real Linux commands in monospace. Type them out — you learn systems by running things, not by reading about them.

Comparison tables
The exact "X vs Y" distinctions interviewers love. Part XX collects them all.

Solved numericals
Scheduling, paging, page replacement, Banker's, and disk problems worked step by step, with every calculation shown.

Check Your Understanding
End-of-part checkpoints: conceptual questions, application questions, interview questions, a practical experiment, and a clear "you have mastered this when…" bar.

> ⓘ **A NOTE ON DEPTH VS. SIMPLICITY**
>
> Where a simple explanation and a fully precise one differ, this book gives you the simple one first so you understand, then the precise one so you are correct. It never trades away technical accuracy for comfort — it just orders them so the accuracy actually lands.

The Fastest Way to Get Value

1. **First pass:** read a part fully, do its checkpoint, run its practical task.
2. **Second pass:** read only the **Key Concept** and **Quick Revision** boxes.
3. **Interview prep:** Part XVIII (question bank) + Part XX (comparison tables) + Part XXIII (final revision).
4. **Exam prep:** Part XIX (numericals) + each part's checkpoint + Part XXIII cheat sheet.

Let's begin.

Table of Contents

FRONT MATTER

How to Use This Book 2

FOUNDATIONS

Part I — OS Fundamentals & Architecture 7
Part II — Processes 20
Part III — Threads & Concurrency 31
Part IV — CPU Scheduling 39

COORDINATION & MEMORY

Part V — Process Synchronization 48
Part VI — Deadlocks 58
Part VII — Memory Management 65
Part VIII — Virtual Memory 72

SYSTEMS & DEVICES

Part IX — File Systems 79
Part X — I/O Systems 86
Part XI — Inter-Process Communication 92
Part XII — Storage Systems 98
Part XIII — Networking from an OS Perspective 104

PRACTICAL & ADVANCED

Part XIV — Linux Practical OS 110
Part XV — Advanced Operating Systems 117
Part XVI — What Happens When... 123
Part XVII — Practical Projects 131

MASTERY & REVISION

Part XVIII — Interview Mastery (100+ Questions) 138
Part XIX — Numerical Practice . . . . .
Part XX — Comparison Tables . . . . .
Part XXI — Visual Learning Index . . . . .
Part XXII — Mastery Checkpoints . . . . .
Part XXIII — Final Revision & Mastery Test . . . . .

PART I

OS Fundamentals & Architecture

Before processes, memory, or scheduling make sense, you need to know what an operating system is, why a computer is almost useless without one, and how a single program is kept from crashing the whole machine.

In this part: What an OS is · Resource manager & extended machine · Kernel and user space · User vs kernel mode · Privileged instructions · System calls · Traps, interrupts, exceptions · OS services · Protection & security · The boot process · Monolithic, micro, hybrid & modular kernels

PART I

OS Fundamentals & Architecture

A modern computer is a pile of extraordinarily fast but extraordinarily literal hardware. The operating system is the layer of software that turns that raw hardware into something a human — and a program — can actually use safely. This part builds the mental model that every later part depends on.

1.1 What Is an Operating System?

What is it? An **operating system (OS)** is the master program that sits between your applications and the physical hardware. It controls the hardware and provides services that every program can use, so that programs never have to talk to the raw metal directly.

Why do we need it? Imagine writing a program that plays a sound. Without an OS you would have to know the exact model of sound card, write the precise byte sequences it expects, manage the electrical timing, and make sure no other program touches the card at the same time. Now do that again for every keyboard, disk, network card, and GPU ever made. It is hopeless. The OS solves this once, for everyone, and hands you a simple request like "play these bytes."

> ▣ **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> An operating system does two big jobs at once: it is a **resource manager** (it decides who gets the CPU, memory, and devices, and when) and an **extended machine / abstraction layer** (it hides ugly hardware details behind clean, uniform interfaces like files and processes).

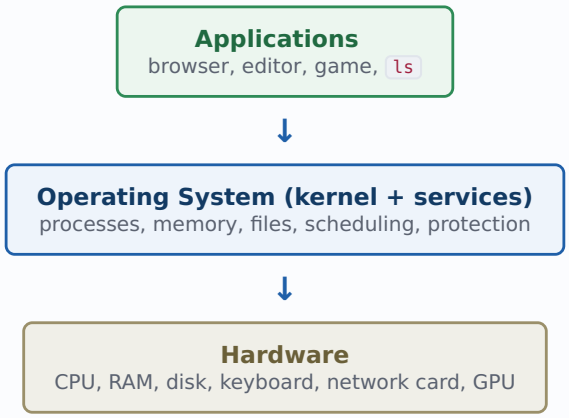
Simple intuition. Think of an OS as the manager of a busy shared workshop. Many workers (programs) want the same tools (CPU, memory, printer). The manager hands out tools fairly, stops two workers from grabbing the same tool at once, cleans up when a worker leaves, and gives everyone the same simple checkout process instead of making each worker learn how every tool is wired internally.

Technical explanation. The OS is a collection of software — centered on the **kernel** — that (1) manages hardware resources (processor time, memory, storage, I/O devices), (2) provides an execution environment for programs called the **process**, (3) exposes services through **system calls**, and (4) enforces **protection** so a fault or attack in one program cannot corrupt another or the OS itself.

How it works internally. The OS is loaded into memory at boot and stays resident. It runs in a privileged CPU mode so it can execute instructions ordinary programs cannot. When a program needs something only the OS can do (read a file, get more memory, send a packet), it makes a controlled request that switches the CPU into the

OS, the OS does the work, and control returns to the program. Between those requests, the OS is mostly idle — it is event-driven, woken by system calls and hardware interrupts.

Example. When you run `ls` in a terminal, the OS finds the program on disk, loads it into memory, gives it CPU time, lets it ask the file system for directory contents, sends its output to your terminal, and reclaims its memory when it exits — all without `ls` knowing anything about your specific SSD or display.



The OS is the mandatory middle layer: applications go through it to reach hardware.

Real-world example. Linux, Windows, macOS, Android, and iOS are operating systems. The same Chrome browser binary logic runs on wildly different laptops because the OS hides those differences. Your phone runs dozens of apps on one CPU because the OS shares it among them.

Related concepts. Kernel (§1.4), system calls (§1.7), processes (Part II), and protection (§1.10) are all facets of these two core jobs.

> ⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**
>
> "The OS is the desktop, windows, and icons." That graphical shell is just one application running on top of the OS. You can run Linux with no graphics at all. The OS is the kernel and its services — the part that manages the hardware — not the wallpaper.

> ⚑ **INTERVIEW TIP**
>
> Asked "What is an operating system?", give the two-job answer in one breath: "It's the software that manages hardware resources and provides an abstraction layer so programs can use the hardware safely and portably through a uniform interface." Then be ready to expand either half.

1.2 Resource Manager & Extended Machine

These are the two classic lenses for understanding everything an OS does. Every feature in this book is one or the other (usually both).

The OS as a Resource Manager

The hardware has finite resources; many programs want them simultaneously. The OS multiplexes them — in **time** (the CPU runs process A for a few milliseconds, then B, then C, so fast it looks simultaneous) and in **space** (RAM is divided so each process gets its own region). It must do this fairly (no program starves), efficiently (little overhead), and safely (one program cannot read or wreck another's resources).

Resource	How the OS manages it	Covered in
CPU time	Scheduling: decides which process/thread runs next and for how long	Part IV
Main memory	Allocation, paging, virtual memory, protection	Parts VII–VIII
Storage	File systems, disk scheduling, free-space management	Parts IX, XII
I/O devices	Drivers, interrupts, DMA, buffering	Part X
Access / identity	Users, permissions, isolation	§1.10

The OS as an Extended (Virtual) Machine

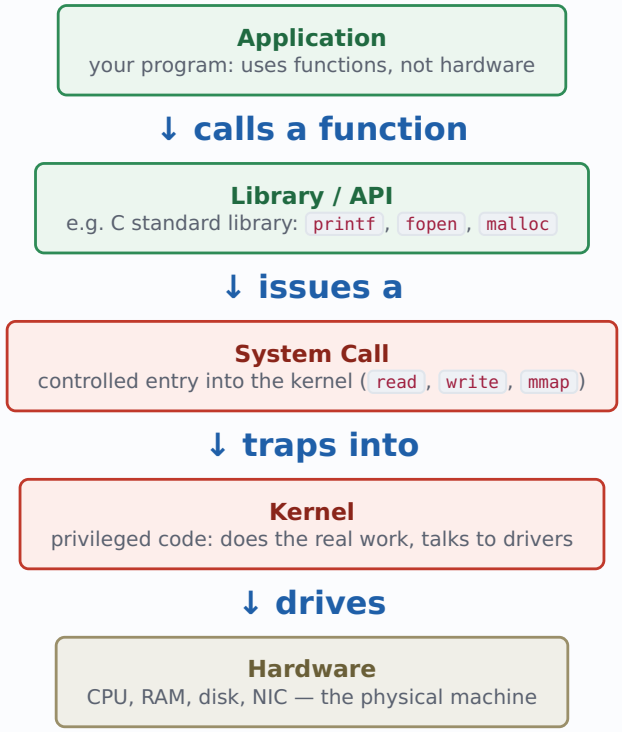
Raw hardware is hostile to program: disks store numbered blocks, not "files"; memory is one flat array shared by all; the CPU has no notion of "a program." The OS presents a friendlier **extended machine** where those hard things become easy abstractions:

Ugly hardware reality	Clean OS abstraction
Numbered disk sectors, no names	**Files** and directories with names
One shared physical RAM	A private **virtual address space** per program
One CPU, one instruction stream	Many concurrent **processes** and **threads**
Device-specific register pokes	Uniform `read()` / `write()` calls

> ▣ **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Abstraction** = hiding complexity behind a simpler interface. **Virtualization** = giving each program the illusion it has the whole machine to itself. The OS does both constantly: a file is an abstraction of disk blocks; a process is a virtualization of the CPU; virtual memory is a virtualization of RAM.

1.3 Hardware, OS, and Application: The Layered View

The single most useful picture in this book. Memorize it — nearly every question about "what happens when…" is really a question about how a request travels down and back up these layers.



The canonical stack. A request flows down; results (and interrupts) flow back up.

The two horizontal lines that matter most are: the **API boundary** (between your app and the library) and the **system-call boundary** (between user space and the kernel). The second is the famous "user/kernel line," and crossing it is not free — see §1.7.

1.4 Kernel, User Space, and Kernel Space

What is the kernel? The **kernel** is the core of the OS — the part that is always in memory, runs with full hardware privilege, and directly manages processes, memory, and devices. When people say "the OS did X," they usually mean the kernel did X.

Memory is conceptually split into two territories:

Kernel space
: The memory region where the kernel's code and data live. Only privileged (kernel-mode) code may access it. Protected from ordinary programs.

User space

Where ordinary programs (and their libraries) run. Each process gets its own user-space view. Code here cannot touch kernel space or other processes' memory directly.

> ▣ **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **User space vs kernel space** is about memory and privilege territory. **User mode vs kernel mode** (next section) is about the CPU's current privilege state. They move together: code in user space runs in user mode; the kernel runs in kernel mode. Do not confuse the two axes — one is "where the memory is," the other is "what the CPU is allowed to do right now."

1.5 Dual-Mode Operation: User Mode and Kernel Mode

Why do we need it? If every program could run any instruction and touch any memory, one buggy or malicious program could halt the CPU, erase the disk, or read your passwords out of another program. To prevent that, the CPU itself supports (at least) two privilege levels.

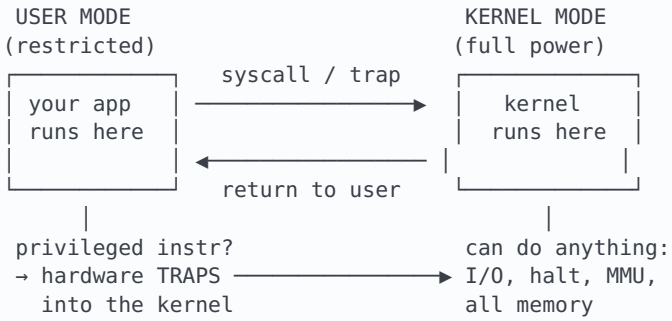
Kernel mode (supervisor / privileged mode)

The CPU can execute every instruction and access all memory and devices. The kernel runs here.

User mode

A restricted state. Privileged instructions are forbidden; memory access is limited to the process's own space. Applications run here.

How it works internally. A bit in a CPU register (the "mode bit," e.g. current privilege level / ring on x86) records the mode. In user mode, if a program attempts a privileged instruction or touches memory it does not own, the hardware immediately raises an **exception (trap)** and jumps into the kernel, which typically kills the offending program (the classic segmentation fault). The only legitimate ways to get from user mode into kernel mode are a **system call**, an **interrupt**, or an **exception** — all of which enter the kernel at fixed, trusted entry points. A program can never simply "switch itself" to kernel mode; that is the whole point.



Dual-mode operation. The mode bit gates what the CPU may do; controlled doorways cross it.

> ⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**
>
> Thinking a program "calls the kernel like a normal function." It does not — a normal call cannot change privilege. A system call executes a special CPU instruction (e.g. `syscall` on x86-64) that atomically switches to kernel mode and jumps to a fixed kernel entry point. That hardware-enforced doorway is what makes the boundary safe.

1.6 Privileged Instructions

A **privileged instruction** is a machine instruction that can only be executed in kernel mode. These are exactly the operations that could compromise the whole system if any program could run them:

- Halting the CPU, disabling/enabling interrupts.
- Loading the page-table base register / switching address spaces (controlling the MMU).
- Direct access to I/O device registers.
- Modifying the mode bit or system control registers.
- Executing `hlt`, setting timers, flushing the TLB.

Attempting any of these in user mode raises a trap. This single mechanism — "some instructions are off-limits unless you are the kernel" — is the hardware foundation of all OS protection.

1.7 System Calls — and API vs System Call

What is it? A **system call** is the controlled mechanism by which a user-mode program requests a service from the kernel. It is the only door through which a program can ask the OS to do something privileged (open a file, allocate memory, create a process, send data on the network).

Simple intuition. You (a program) cannot walk into the bank vault (hardware). You slide a request form through a small, guarded window (the system call). A teller (the kernel) verifies your request, does it on your behalf, and slides the result back. You never touch the vault yourself.

How it works internally (x86-64 Linux, step by step):

1. The program puts the system-call number in a register (e.g. `rax`) and arguments in others (`rdi`, `rsi`, `rdx`…).
2. It executes the `syscall` instruction. The CPU switches to kernel mode and jumps to a fixed kernel entry point (the system-call handler).
3. The kernel looks up the number in the **system-call table**, validates the arguments, and runs the corresponding kernel function.

4. The result is placed in a register; the kernel executes a return-from-kernel instruction that switches back to user mode and resumes the program right after the `syscall`.

A RAW SYSTEM CALL VS. THE LIBRARY WRAPPER (LINUX, C)

```c
/* The C library gives you a friendly wrapper... */
ssize_t n = write(1, "hi\n", 3);   // fd 1 = stdout, 3 bytes

/* ...which internally does roughly this (conceptually): */
//   mov rax, 1        ; syscall number for write on x86-64
//   mov rdi, 1        ; arg1: file descriptor
//   mov rsi, buf      ; arg2: pointer to data
//   mov rdx, 3        ; arg3: byte count
//   syscall           ; <-- traps into the kernel
```

▣ KEY CONCEPT — API VS SYSTEM CALL

An **API** (Application Programming Interface) is the set of functions your code calls, such as the C library's `fopen()`, `printf()`, `malloc()`. A **system call** is the kernel entry underneath, such as `open`, `write`, `mmap`. Many API functions wrap one or more system calls — but not always: `strlen()` makes zero system calls, and one `printf()` may buffer many prints into a single `write`. The API is what you program against; the system call is what actually crosses into the kernel.

Aspect	API (library function)	System call
Lives in	User space (e.g. libc)	Kernel (entered via a trap)
Cost	Cheap — an ordinary function call	Expensive — mode switch + kernel work
Example	`printf`, `fopen`, `malloc`	`write`, `open`, `brk`/`mmap`
Portability	Portable across OSes (same C API)	OS-specific numbers & semantics
Purpose	Convenience, buffering, portability	The actual privileged service

Categories of system calls. Process control (`fork`, `execve`, `exit`, `wait`), file management (`open`, `read`, `write`, `close`), device management (`ioctl`), information (`getpid`, `time`), communication (`pipe`, `socket`, `shmget`), and protection (`chmod`, `setuid`).

⚑ INTERVIEW TIP

"Why are system calls expensive?" Because each one costs a **mode switch** (save user state, switch to kernel mode, run the handler, restore state) plus the kernel's own validation and work, and it can pollute CPU caches and pipelines. That is why libraries buffer — one big `write` beats a thousand tiny ones. This is also why high-performance systems batch I/O (`writev`, `io_uring`) to amortize the crossing.

> ⚑ **REAL WORLD**
>
> Run `strace ls` on Linux. You will see the actual stream of system calls `ls` makes — `openat`, `read`, `write`, `close`, `mmap`. This is the single best way to see the user/kernel boundary in action. We use it throughout Part XIV.

1.8 Traps, Interrupts, and Exceptions

All three are ways the CPU stops what it is doing and jumps into the kernel. Interviewers love the distinction because candidates blur it. Here is the clean version:

Term	Source	Timing	Meaning & example
Interrupt	External hardware (device)	Asynchronous	A device signals it needs attention, unrelated to the current instruction. E.g. keyboard press, packet arrival, disk finished, timer tick.
Exception / Fault	The running instruction (CPU)	Synchronous	The current instruction did something the CPU can't complete. E.g. divide-by-zero, invalid memory access, **page fault**.
Trap	A deliberate instruction	Synchronous	The program intentionally asks to enter the kernel. E.g. a **system call**, a debugger breakpoint. (A "software interrupt.")

> ▣ **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Asynchronous vs synchronous** is the crisp dividing line. An **interrupt** is asynchronous — it comes from the outside world and can arrive between any two instructions. An **exception** and a **trap** are synchronous — they are caused by the instruction currently executing. A trap is the intentional kind of exception ("I meant to do that"); a fault is the unintended kind ("something went wrong").

How the kernel responds. The CPU consults the **interrupt vector table** (a table of handler addresses indexed by interrupt/exception number), saves the current state, switches to kernel mode, and runs the matching **interrupt/exception handler**. When the handler finishes, the CPU restores state and resumes — either the interrupted program (for an interrupt) or, for a fault it fixed (like a page fault), re-runs the faulting instruction.

1.9 OS Services

Everything the OS offers falls into a handful of service categories. You have now met the mechanisms; these are the user-facing results.

- **Program execution** — load, run, and end programs (Part II).
- **I/O operations** — read/write files and devices without touching hardware (Part X).

- **File-system manipulation** — create, delete, search, and protect files (Part IX).
- **Communication** — let processes exchange data locally or over a network (Parts XI, XIII).
- **Error detection** — catch hardware and software faults and respond safely.
- **Resource allocation** — share CPU, memory, and devices among many programs (Parts IV, VII).
- **Accounting & logging** — track who used what.
- **Protection & security** — isolate programs and users (§1.10).

1.10 Protection and Security

These words are related but not identical, and mixing them up is a classic slip.

Protection

Controlling access by programs and users to the resources inside the system — e.g. stopping process A from reading process B's memory, or a user from deleting another user's files. It guards against **accidents and internal misuse**.

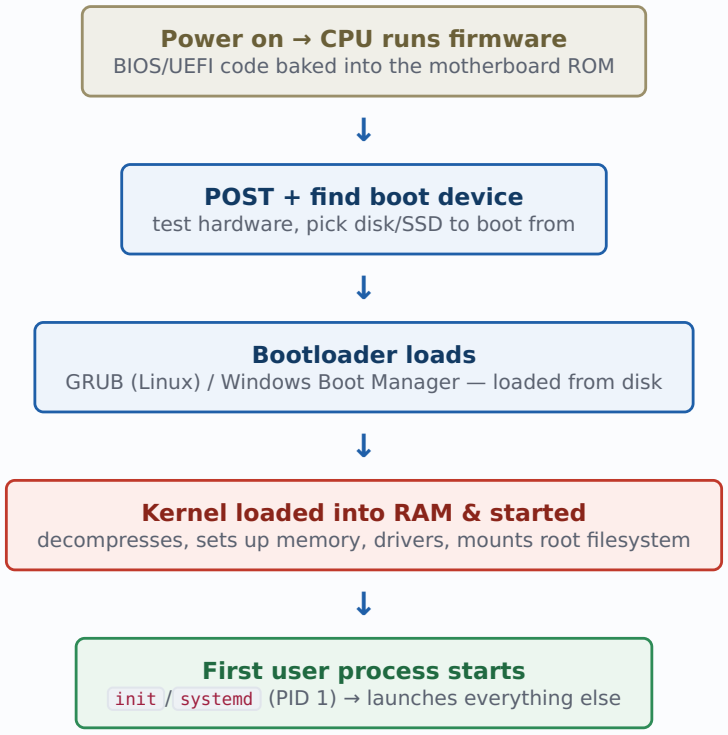
Security

Defending the system against external threats — malware, network attackers, stolen credentials. It guards against **deliberate, often external, attacks**.

Mechanisms include dual-mode operation, memory protection via the MMU (Part VII), user/group permissions (Part IX), and modern additions like ASLR and namespaces (Part XV). Protection is the foundation; security is built on top of it.

1.11 The Boot Process

The chicken-and-egg problem: the OS manages the hardware, but the OS is a program that must itself be loaded and run by the hardware. **Booting** (from "bootstrapping" — pulling yourself up by your bootstraps) is how the machine climbs from bare power-on to a running OS.



Cold boot to login. Each stage loads and hands control to the next, larger stage.

The detail-by-detail version — including what the firmware, bootloader, and PID 1 each do — is in Part XVI, "What happens when I turn on my computer?" For now, the shape is enough: firmware → bootloader → kernel → init → your login.

1.12 OS Architectures: Monolithic, Micro, Hybrid, Modular

Where should all this OS code live — one giant privileged blob, or many small pieces? This design choice defines an OS's **architecture**, and it is a favorite interview and exam topic.

Monolithic Kernel

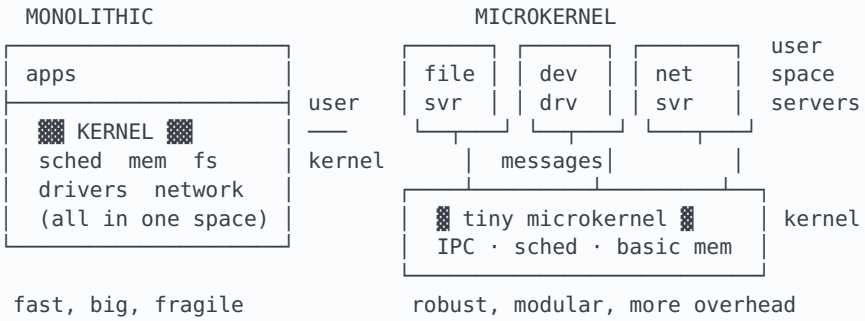
The entire OS — scheduling, memory, file systems, drivers, network stack — runs together in kernel space as one large program. Components call each other directly as fast function calls.

+ Very fast (no crossing between components). **−** Huge, complex; a bug in any driver can crash the whole kernel; hard to maintain in isolation. **Examples:** classic UNIX, Linux (though modular), BSD.

Microkernel

Keep the kernel tiny: only the bare essentials (scheduling, basic memory, and inter-process messaging) run in kernel mode. Everything else — file systems, drivers, networking — runs as ordinary **user-space servers** that talk via message passing.

+ Robust and secure (a crashed driver doesn't take down the kernel; just restart the server); modular; easier to verify. **−** Slower — lots of message passing and mode switches. **Examples:** Minix, QNX, seL4, the Mach core.



Monolithic puts everything in kernel space; microkernel pushes services out to user space.

Hybrid Kernel

A pragmatic middle ground: a mostly-monolithic kernel for speed, but structured with some microkernel ideas and message passing. **Examples:** Windows NT, macOS (XNU = Mach + BSD).

Modular Kernel

A monolithic core that can **load and unload components at runtime** as **modules** — you get monolithic speed with some of the flexibility of a microkernel. **Example:** Linux, via **loadable kernel modules** (a driver you `insmod` / `modprobe` without recompiling the kernel; see Part XV). Modern Linux is best described as a modular monolithic kernel.

Property	Monolithic	Microkernel	Hybrid	Modular
Where services run	Kernel space	User space	Mostly kernel	Kernel (loadable)
Speed	Highest	Lower	High	High
Fault isolation	Poor	Excellent	Medium	Poor–Medium
Extensibility	Hard	Easy	Medium	Easy (modules)
Example	Classic UNIX	QNX, seL4	Windows, macOS	Linux

⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**

Saying "Linux is a pure monolithic kernel." It is monolithic in that services run in kernel space, but it is modular — drivers and features load and unload at runtime as kernel modules. The precise answer is "modular monolithic," and saying so signals real understanding.

✓ Check Your Understanding — Part I

CONCEPTUAL (EXPLAIN IN YOUR OWN WORDS)

1. State the two fundamental jobs of an operating system and give an example of each.
2. What is the difference between user space/kernel space and user mode/kernel mode?
3. Why can't a user program simply switch itself into kernel mode?
4. Distinguish an interrupt, an exception, and a trap by source and timing.
5. Explain the difference between an API and a system call.

APPLICATION

1. You call `printf("hi")` a thousand times in a loop. Explain why this may result in far fewer than a thousand `write` system calls.
2. A driver has a bug that dereferences a bad pointer. Predict the outcome on a monolithic kernel vs. a microkernel, and why.
3. Order these boot stages: init/systemd, bootloader, firmware (UEFI), kernel.

INTERVIEW-LEVEL

1. "Why are system calls expensive, and how do real systems reduce that cost?"
2. "Is Linux monolithic or a microkernel? Defend your answer."

CAN YOU EXPLAIN THIS? (NO NOTES)

The user/kernel boundary and the three ways to cross it · API vs system call · resource manager vs extended machine · monolithic vs microkernel trade-offs.

⚑ **PRACTICAL TASK**

On any Linux machine (or WSL), run `strace -c ls`. Read the summary: which system calls did `ls` make, and how many times? Identify one call that reads directory data and one that writes your terminal. You have just watched the abstraction stack work.

Mastered when... you can draw the Application → Library → System Call → Kernel → Hardware stack from memory, explain what enforces each boundary, and describe exactly what happens (in hardware and software) during a single `write()` call.

PART II

Processes

A program is a dead file on disk. A process is that program brought to life — given memory, a CPU, and an identity. Understanding the process is understanding the single most important object the operating system manages.

In this part: Program vs process · The process address space · The PCB · Five process states & transitions · `fork()`, `exec()`, `wait()` · Parent/child trees · Zombies, orphans & daemons · Context switching · Scheduling queues · CPU vs I/O bursts · Process isolation

PART II

Processes

Everything a computer does for you happens inside a process. When you open a browser, compile code, or run a server, the OS creates processes, feeds them CPU time, gives each its own protected memory, and cleans up after them. Master the process and half of operating systems falls into place.

2.1 Program vs Process

What is it? A **program** is a passive, static file on disk — a sequence of instructions and data (e.g. `/usr/bin/ls`). A **process** is a program in execution: an active entity with its own memory, CPU registers, a program counter, open files, and a unique identity.

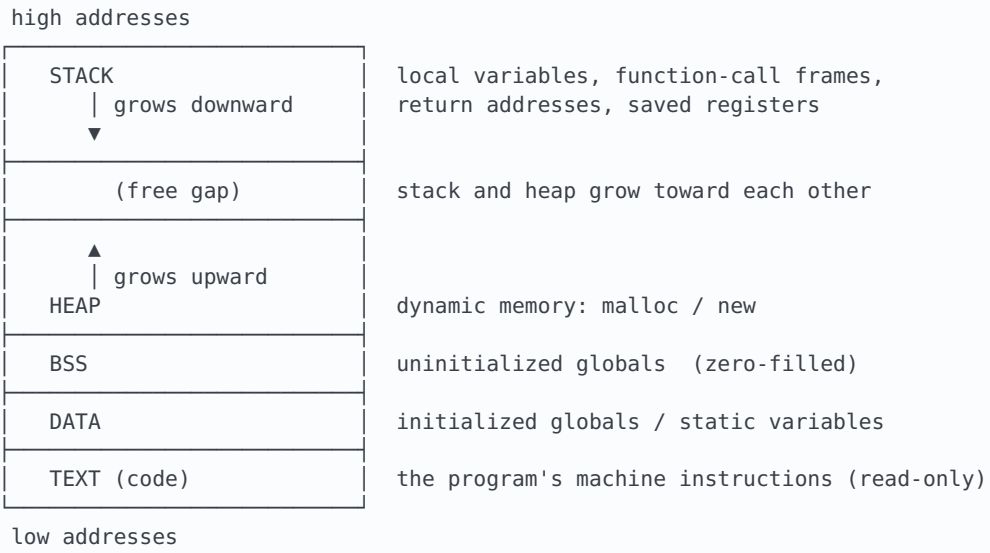
Simple intuition. A program is a recipe in a cookbook. A process is you actually cooking it — using a kitchen (memory), your hands (CPU), and a bookmark showing which step you are on (program counter). The same recipe can be cooked by two people at once in two kitchens: one program, two independent processes.

> ▣ **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Program : Process = Recipe : Cooking.** One program can spawn many processes (open your terminal twice — two `bash` processes from one `bash` program). A process is a program plus its execution state: memory image, registers, PC, kernel bookkeeping.

Aspect	Program	Process
Nature	Passive / static	Active / dynamic
Location	On disk (a file)	In memory (RAM), executing
Lifetime	Exists until deleted	Exists from creation to termination
Resources	None (just bytes)	CPU time, memory, open files, PID
Count	One file	Many processes from the same program

2.2 The Process Address Space

When the OS launches a process, it gives it a private **virtual address space** — a fresh, protected view of memory the process believes is entirely its own. That space is organized into segments. Knowing this layout explains stack overflows, `malloc`, and countless bugs.



A process's virtual address space. Text/data come from the program file; heap and stack grow at run time.

Text

The machine code. Read-only (so it can be shared between processes running the same program) and protected from accidental writes.

Data / BSS

Global and static variables. Data holds initialized ones; BSS holds zero-initialized ones (stored compactly as "reserve N zero bytes").

Heap

Dynamically allocated memory (`malloc` / `new`). Grows upward as you allocate; managed by the allocator on top of the `brk` / `mmap` syscalls.

Stack

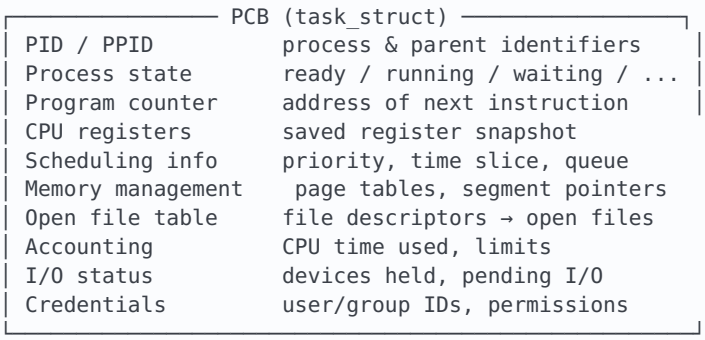
Function call frames: local variables, arguments, return addresses. Grows downward; automatically freed as functions return.

> ⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**
>
> Confusing **stack** and **heap**. Locals live on the stack and vanish when the function returns — returning a pointer to a local is a bug. `malloc`'d memory lives on the heap and survives until you `free` it — forgetting to free is a memory leak.

2.3 The Process Control Block (PCB)

What is it? The **Process Control Block** is the kernel's data structure that stores everything the OS needs to know about a process. One PCB exists per process; it is the process, as far as the kernel is concerned. (In Linux the PCB is `struct task_struct`.)

Why do we need it? The CPU can run only one process at a time per core. To pause process A and later resume it exactly where it left off, the OS must save A's complete state somewhere — that somewhere is the PCB.



The PCB: the kernel's complete record of one process. Saving/restoring it is the essence of a context switch.

> ▣ **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> The PCB is the anchor for three big ideas at once: **context switching** (save/restore its registers & PC), **scheduling** (its state and priority determine what runs next), and **isolation** (its memory-management fields point to a private address space). The kernel keeps all PCBs in lists/queues so it can find and manage every process.

2.4 Process States and Transitions

A process is not always running — most of the time it is waiting for something (the CPU, or an I/O device). The OS models this with a small set of **states**. The five-state model is the one to know cold.

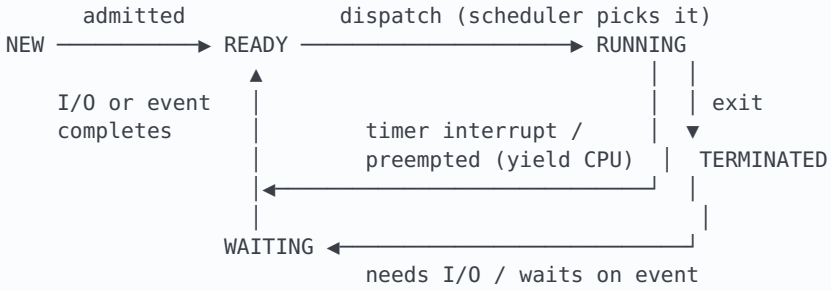
New
: The process is being created (PCB allocated, memory being set up).

Ready
: Loaded and willing to run — just waiting for the CPU. Sits in the **ready queue**.

Running
: Currently executing on a CPU. Only one process per core is here at any instant.

Waiting / Blocked
: Cannot proceed until some event happens (disk read completes, a lock is released, input arrives). Not competing for the CPU.

Terminated
: Finished executing; the OS is reclaiming its resources.



The five-state process model. Transitions are driven by the scheduler, timer interrupts, and I/O events.

The key transitions:

- **Ready → Running** (dispatch): the scheduler selects the process and gives it the CPU.
- **Running → Ready** (preemption): its time slice expired, or a higher-priority process arrived. It is still runnable — just paused.
- **Running → Waiting** (block): it requested I/O or a resource that is not ready. It voluntarily gives up the CPU.
- **Waiting → Ready** (wakeup): the awaited event happened; it rejoins the ready queue (note: it does not go straight to Running).
- **Running → Terminated**: it called `exit()` or was killed.

> ⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**
>
> Thinking a process goes Waiting → Running directly when its I/O finishes. It does not — it goes Waiting → **Ready**, then must be scheduled before it runs. The CPU might be busy with someone else. This distinction matters in scheduling questions.

> ⚑ **INTERVIEW TIP**
>
> Draw the five-state diagram and name every transition and its cause. Then mention that real kernels add states: Linux has `TASK_RUNNING` (covers ready+running), `TASK_INTERRUPTIBLE` / `UNINTERRUPTIBLE` (two flavors of waiting), and `TASK_ZOMBIE`. Naming real kernel states signals depth.

2.5 Process Creation with fork()

What is it? On UNIX/Linux, new processes are born by **cloning**. The `fork()` system call creates a near-exact copy of the calling process. The original is the **parent**; the copy is the **child**. This builds a **process tree** rooted at PID 1 (`init` / `systemd`).

The famous trick — one call, two returns. `fork()` is called once but returns twice: once in the parent (returning the child's PID) and once in the child (returning 0). That return value is how each copy knows who it is.

FORK() — ONE CALL, TWO PROCESSES

```c
#include <stdio.h>
#include <unistd.h>
#include <sys/wait.h>

int main(void) {
    pid_t pid = fork();              // clone this process here

    if (pid < 0) {
        perror("fork failed");   // no child was created
    } else if (pid == 0) {
        printf("Child : my PID=%d, parent=%d\n", getpid(), getppid());
    } else {
        printf("Parent: my PID=%d, child=%d\n", getpid(), pid);
        wait(NULL);                 // wait for the child to finish
    }
    return 0;
}
```

How it works internally. The kernel allocates a new PCB, copies the parent's state (open files, credentials, and a logical copy of its address space), assigns a new PID, and marks the child Ready. Copying all of memory would be wasteful, so modern kernels use **copy-on-write (COW)**: parent and child share the same physical pages, marked read-only; only when one writes does the kernel duplicate that page. This makes `fork()` cheap. (COW returns in Part VIII.)

⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**

Assuming the parent runs before the child (or vice versa). After `fork()`, both are Ready and the scheduler decides the order — it is nondeterministic. Never write code that depends on which runs first; use `wait()` or synchronization if order matters.

2.6 Running a New Program with exec()

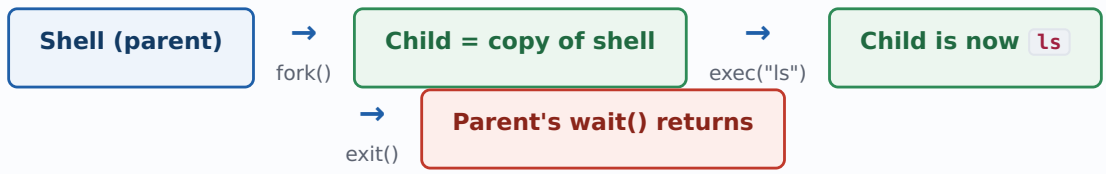
`fork()` gives you a copy of the same program. To run a different program, the child calls a member of the `exec()` family (`execl`, `execvp`, `execve`...). `exec()` **replaces** the current process's memory image with a new program — same PID, brand-new text/data/heap/stack. It does not return on success (there is nothing to return to; the old program is gone).

▣ **KEY CONCEPT — THE FORK/EXEC PATTERN**

This is how every shell launches every command: **fork** to create a child, then **exec** in the child to become the desired program, while the parent **wait**s. Separating "create a process" (`fork`) from "run a program" (`exec`) is a deliberate, powerful UNIX design — between the two, the child can redirect I/O, close files, or set up pipes (Part XI).

FORK + EXEC + WAIT: HOW A SHELL RUNS "LS -L"

```c
pid_t pid = fork();
if (pid == 0) {                         // --- child ---
    execlp("ls", "ls", "-l", NULL);     // become 'ls'; never returns if OK
    perror("exec failed");              // only reached on error
    _exit(1);
} else {                                // --- parent (the shell) ---
    int status;
    waitpid(pid, &status, 0);           // block until child finishes
    printf("child exited with %d\n", WEXITSTATUS(status));
}
```



The universal fork → exec → wait lifecycle behind every shell command.

2.7 Termination and wait()

A process ends by calling `exit(status)` (voluntary) or by receiving a fatal signal like `SIGKILL` (involuntary). On termination the kernel closes the process's files, frees its memory, and keeps a small **exit status** around so the parent can learn how the child fared.

The parent collects that status with `wait()` / `waitpid()`. This is called **reaping**. Until the parent reaps it, the dead child lingers as a **zombie** (next section). `wait()` also lets a parent synchronize with a child — blocking until it finishes.

2.8 Zombies, Orphans, and Daemons

Three special process conditions that interviewers love and beginners confuse. Learn them as a set.

Zombie Process

What: a child that has terminated but whose parent has not yet `wait()`ed for it. It is dead but still occupies a PCB slot (holding its exit status). **Why it exists:** so the parent can still read the exit status after the child is gone. **Danger:** a parent that never reaps its children leaks PCB entries; enough zombies can exhaust the process table. **Fix:** the parent must `wait()`, or handle `SIGCHLD`.

CREATING (AND OBSERVING) A ZOMBIE

```
pid_t pid = fork();
if (pid == 0) {
    _exit(0);              // child dies immediately
} else {
    sleep(30);             // parent naps WITHOUT wait() -> child is a zombie
    // run 'ps aux | grep defunct' now: you'll see it as <defunct>
}
```

Orphan Process

What: a child whose parent terminated first, leaving the child still running. **Who adopts it:** the kernel **reparents** orphans to `init`/`systemd` (PID 1), which dutifully reaps them when they finish. So orphans are harmless — they always get a responsible foster parent.

Daemon Process

What: a long-running background service with no controlling terminal — web servers, `sshd`, `cron`. **How it is made:** a process `fork`s, the parent exits (so the child becomes an orphan adopted by PID 1), and the child calls `setsid()` to start a new session, detaching from any terminal. The trailing **d** in names like `sshd`, `httpd`, `systemd` means "daemon."

Type	State	Parent	Problem?
Zombie	Dead, not yet reaped	Alive but hasn't waited	Yes — leaks PCB slots
Orphan	Still running	Dead; adopted by PID 1	No — PID 1 reaps it
Daemon	Running (background)	PID 1 (intentionally)	No — by design

⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**

"You kill a zombie with `kill -9`." You cannot — it is already dead; there is nothing to kill. A zombie disappears when its parent reaps it. If the parent won't, kill the parent; the zombie is then reparented to PID 1, which reaps it instantly.

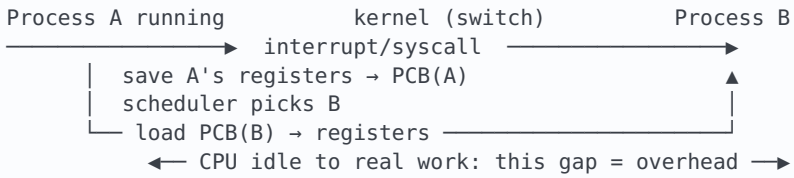
2.9 Context Switching

What is it? A **context switch** is the act of saving the state of the currently running process and restoring the state of another, so the CPU can switch from running process A to process B. It is the mechanism that makes one CPU appear to run many processes at once.

Simple intuition. A single receptionist (CPU) serving many customers (processes). To switch customers, the receptionist writes down exactly where they left off with customer A (save context), pulls out customer B's file (restore context), and continues. The note-taking itself takes time and serves no customer — that is **overhead**.

How it works internally. Triggered by a timer interrupt (preemption), a blocking system call, or a higher-priority wakeup, the kernel:

1. Saves the CPU registers and program counter of A into A's PCB.
2. Updates A's state (Running → Ready or Waiting) and picks B via the scheduler.
3. Loads B's registers, PC, and memory context (switches page tables / address space) from B's PCB.
4. Returns to user mode; B resumes exactly where it last stopped.



A context switch. The shaded gap does no useful application work — pure overhead.

> ⚑ **INTERVIEW TIP**
>
> "Why does context switching have overhead?" Two reasons: (1) the direct cost of saving/restoring registers and switching address spaces, and (2) the indirect cost — the new process starts with cold CPU caches and TLB (which may be flushed), so it runs slower until they warm up. This is why excessive switching (e.g. too many threads) hurts performance. Switching between threads of one process is cheaper: same address space, so no page-table switch or full TLB flush.

2.10 Scheduling Queues, CPU Bursts, and I/O Bursts

The OS keeps processes organized in queues as they move between states:

- **Job queue** — all processes in the system.
- **Ready queue** — processes in memory, Ready, waiting for the CPU.
- **Device / wait queues** — one per device; processes blocked on that device's I/O.

A process's life alternates between two kinds of activity:

CPU burst
: A stretch of computation using the CPU.

I/O burst
: A stretch of waiting for input/output (disk, network, user).

This **CPU–I/O burst cycle** is fundamental to scheduling (Part IV). **CPU-bound** processes (e.g. video encoding) have long CPU bursts; **I/O-bound** processes (e.g. a text editor) have short CPU bursts and lots of waiting. Good schedulers favor I/O-bound processes to keep devices busy.

2.11 Process Isolation

What & why. Each process gets its own virtual address space, so process A literally cannot see or corrupt process B's memory — a wild pointer in A crashes only A. This **isolation** is enforced by the hardware MMU (Part VII) under the kernel's control, and it is the reason one misbehaving app doesn't take down your whole machine.

Isolation is a double-edged sword: it keeps processes safe from each other, but it also means they cannot casually share data. To communicate, they need explicit, kernel-mediated mechanisms — which is exactly what **inter-process communication** provides.

2.12 Inter-Process Communication (Overview)

Because processes are isolated, the OS offers controlled channels for them to exchange data. There are two broad families:

- **Shared memory** — two processes map the same region of physical memory; fastest, but they must synchronize access themselves.
- **Message passing** — processes send/receive discrete messages via the kernel (pipes, message queues, sockets); safer and simpler, but involves copying and system calls.

The full toolkit — pipes, named pipes, message queues, shared memory, signals, sockets, and RPC — with working C examples is **Part XI**. For now, just hold the idea: isolation is the default; IPC is how you deliberately poke holes in it.

✓ Check Your Understanding — Part II

CONCEPTUAL

1. Give the recipe/cooking analogy for program vs process and state what a process has that a program lacks.
2. Name the four main segments of a process address space and what each holds.
3. List the five process states and the cause of every transition between them.
4. What is stored in a PCB, and why is it central to context switching?
5. Define zombie, orphan, and daemon in one sentence each.

APPLICATION

1. A `fork()`'d program prints a line before and after the fork. If the line before says "start" and the line after says "hi", how many total lines are printed and why?
2. Your server spawns worker children but never calls `wait()`. After a day it can't create new processes. Diagnose the bug and give two fixes.
3. Explain why switching between two threads of one process is cheaper than switching between two processes.

INTERVIEW-LEVEL

1. "Why does `fork()` return twice, and how does copy-on-write make it cheap?"
2. "Walk me through exactly what happens, step by step, when a shell runs `grep foo file`."

CAN YOU EXPLAIN THIS? (NO NOTES)

The five-state diagram with every transition · the fork/exec/wait pattern · what a context switch saves and restores (and why it has overhead) · zombie vs orphan.

⚑ PRACTICAL TASK

Compile the `fork()` example. Then write a version where the child `_exit`s and the parent `sleep`s for 20 s without `wait()`. While it sleeps, run `ps -el | grep defunct` in another terminal and find your zombie. Then add `wait(NULL)` and confirm the zombie is gone.

Mastered when... you can write a fork/exec/wait program from scratch, predict its output, explain the process tree it creates, and describe what the kernel does to its PCBs at each step.

PART III

Threads & Concurrency

A process gives you isolation. A thread gives you a way to do several things at once inside one process, sharing its memory. That sharing is the source of both a thread's power and every concurrency bug you will ever chase.

In this part: What a thread is · Process vs thread · What's shared vs private · Why threads · User-level vs kernel-level threads · Many-to-one, one-to-one, many-to-many · The TCB · Concurrency vs parallelism · Multi-core · Race conditions · Critical sections · Thread safety

PART III

Threads & Concurrency

If a process is a running program with its own memory, a thread is a single flow of execution within that memory. Threads let one program keep a UI responsive while it downloads a file, or serve thousands of users at once — but because they share memory, they force us to confront concurrency head-on.

3.1 What Is a Thread?

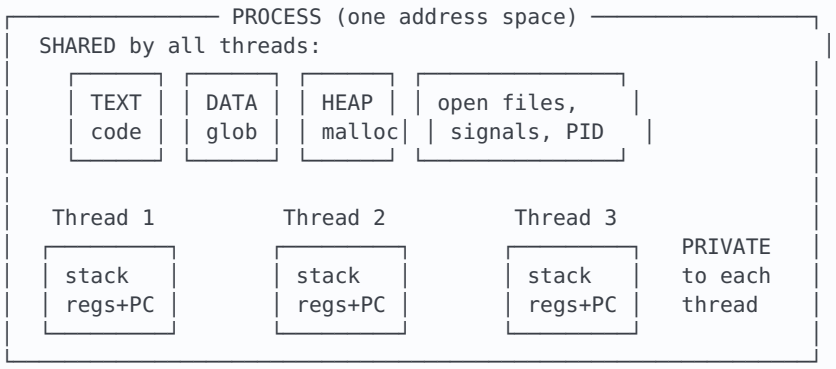
What is it? A **thread** (short for "thread of execution") is the smallest unit the CPU schedules — a single sequential flow of instructions with its own program counter, registers, and stack, running inside a process and sharing that process's memory and resources with its sibling threads.

Simple intuition. A process is a kitchen; a thread is a cook. One cook (single-threaded) does everything in sequence. Add more cooks (threads) in the same kitchen and they work simultaneously, sharing the same ingredients, counters, and fridge (memory). They get more done — but if two cooks grab the same knife at once, you have a problem (a race condition).

Why do we need it? Before threads, doing two things at once meant two processes, which are expensive to create and cannot easily share data. Threads are lightweight and share memory by default, so a single program can naturally overlap work — compute while waiting on I/O, or spread computation across CPU cores.

3.2 Process vs Thread — What's Shared, What's Private

This is the most-asked threading question. The answer hinges on one picture: threads of a process share almost everything, but each keeps its own execution state.



Threads share the process's code, globals, heap, and OS resources; each has its own stack, registers, and program counter.

SHARED across threads of a process	PRIVATE to each thread
Code (text segment)	Stack (local variables, call frames)
Global & static data	CPU registers
Heap (`malloc`'d memory)	Program counter (PC)
Open file descriptors, sockets	Thread ID (TID)
Process ID, signal handlers, working dir	Errno, thread-local storage (TLS)

▣ **KEY CONCEPT**

Threads share **memory** (so they can cooperate cheaply — no copying) but keep their own **stack + registers + PC** (so each can be at a different point in the code). Sharing memory is why threads are fast and why they need synchronization: two threads writing the same global with no lock is a data race.

Aspect	Process	Thread
Memory	Own private address space	Shares the process's address space
Creation cost	Heavy (new address space, COW)	Light (just a stack + PCB-like TCB)
Context switch	Expensive (switch page tables, flush TLB)	Cheaper (same address space)
Communication	Needs IPC (pipes, shared mem)	Shared variables (direct)
Isolation / safety	Strong — a crash stays contained	Weak — one thread's bad write can corrupt all
One crashes	Others unaffected	Can take down the whole process

⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**

"Threads have their own heap." No — the **heap is shared**. If thread A `malloc`s and passes the pointer to thread B, B can use it. Only the **stack** is per-thread. This is precisely why passing a pointer to a local (stack) variable of one thread to another thread is dangerous.

3.3 Why Threads? (And When Not To)

- **Responsiveness** — one thread handles the UI while another does slow work; the app never freezes.
- **Resource sharing** — threads share memory for free; no IPC plumbing needed.
- **Economy** — creating and switching threads is far cheaper than processes.
- **Scalability / parallelism** — on a multi-core CPU, threads run truly simultaneously, one per core, cutting wall-clock time.

The cost: shared memory means shared bugs. Race conditions, deadlocks, and hard-to-reproduce "Heisenbugs" are the price. And more threads is not always faster — see the tip below.

> ⚑ **INTERVIEW TIP**
>
> "Why can too many threads reduce performance?" Because (1) each thread adds context-switching and scheduling overhead; (2) beyond the core count, threads compete for the same cores, so you pay switching cost without gaining parallelism; (3) more threads means more lock contention (they serialize on shared locks) and more cache thrashing. The sweet spot for CPU-bound work is roughly one thread per core; for I/O-bound work you can use more, since threads spend time blocked.

3.4 User-Level vs Kernel-Level Threads

Who manages the threads — a user-space library, or the kernel? This choice has real consequences.

User-level threads (ULT)
: Managed entirely by a library in user space; the kernel sees only one process and knows nothing of the threads. **+** Very fast to create/switch (no system call); portable. **−** If one thread makes a blocking system call, the whole process blocks (the kernel blocks the one process it can see); cannot use multiple cores.

Kernel-level threads (KLT)
: Managed by the kernel, which schedules each thread individually. **+** One thread blocking doesn't stop the others; real parallelism across cores. **−** Creation and switching involve the kernel, so they're slower than ULTs.

Modern systems (Linux, Windows) use kernel-level threads — every `pthread` maps to a kernel-scheduled thread — because true multi-core parallelism and non-blocking behavior matter more than the last drop of switch speed.

3.5 Multithreading Models

These describe how user threads map onto kernel threads.

Many-to-One

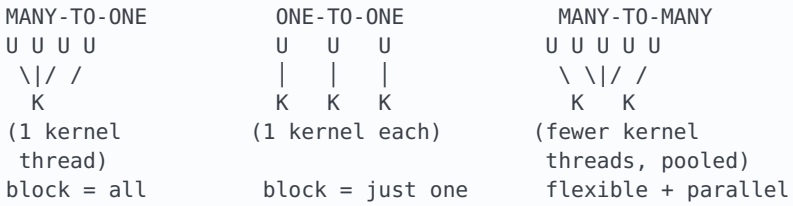
Many user threads map to a single kernel thread. Thread management is cheap and in user space, but one blocking call blocks everyone, and no multi-core parallelism. (Old "green threads.")

One-to-One

Each user thread maps to its own kernel thread. True concurrency and parallelism; a block affects only that thread. Cost: creating many threads creates many kernel threads. This is what **Linux and Windows use today**.

Many-to-Many

Many user threads multiplexed onto a smaller-or-equal pool of kernel threads. Combines flexibility (create as many user threads as you like) with parallelism (multiple kernel threads). Complex to implement; used by some runtimes (e.g. Go's goroutine scheduler is a modern many-to-many-style design).



U = user thread, K = kernel thread. The mapping decides blocking behavior and parallelism.

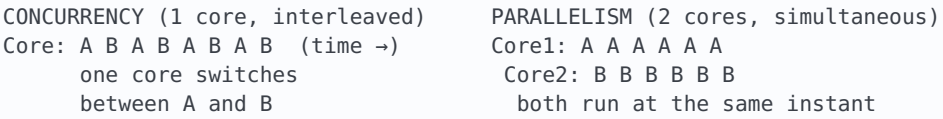
Thread Control Block (TCB). Just as a process has a PCB, each thread has a lighter **TCB** holding its thread ID, register set, program counter, stack pointer, and scheduling state. Threads of one process share the PCB's memory and resource fields but each have their own TCB.

3.6 Concurrency vs Parallelism

These two words are used interchangeably in casual speech and must be distinguished precisely in an interview.

▣ **KEY CONCEPT**

Concurrency = dealing with many things at once (structure): tasks are in progress over overlapping time periods, possibly interleaved on one core. **Parallelism** = doing many things at the exact same instant (execution): tasks literally run simultaneously on multiple cores. Concurrency is about how you structure work; parallelism is about how it executes. You can have concurrency on a single core (via interleaving); you need multiple cores for parallelism.



Concurrency interleaves; parallelism overlaps in real time. Parallel work is concurrent, but concurrent work need not be parallel.

Analogy. A single barista taking one order while steaming milk for another, alternating between them, is concurrent. Two baristas each making a full drink at the same time is parallel.

3.7 Multi-Core Systems

A modern CPU packs several **cores**, each a full processing unit able to run a thread independently. The OS scheduler spreads runnable threads across cores, achieving real parallelism. Some cores support **simultaneous multithreading** (Intel's Hyper-Threading), presenting two logical CPUs per physical core to better utilize execution units. To software, each logical CPU is just another place to run a thread — which is why one-to-one threading maps so naturally onto modern hardware.

3.8 Race Conditions and Critical Sections

The moment two threads share mutable data, correctness is at risk. This section introduces the problem; Part V solves it in full.

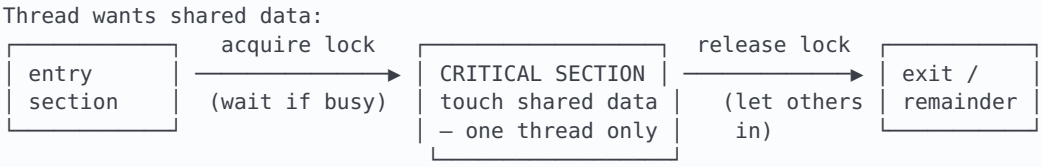
Race condition. A **race condition** occurs when the outcome of a program depends on the timing or interleaving of threads accessing shared data — and at least one is writing. The result is nondeterministic: it might work a thousand times and corrupt data on the thousand-and-first.

THE CLASSIC RACE: TWO THREADS INCREMENTING A SHARED COUNTER

```
// counter++ is NOT atomic. The CPU actually does three steps:
//   1) read  counter  into a register
//   2) add   1
//   3) write register back to counter

// If two threads interleave those steps on counter = 5:
//   T1 reads 5 ─┐                    T2 reads 5 ─┐
//   T1 adds → 6 │                    T2 adds → 6 │
//   T1 writes 6 ┘                    T2 writes 6 ┘
// Two increments happened, but counter is 6, not 7. One update was LOST.
```

Critical section. A **critical section** is a piece of code that accesses shared data and must not be executed by more than one thread at a time. The fix for a race is to enforce **mutual exclusion** over the critical section — only one thread inside at once — using a lock, mutex, or semaphore (Part V).



Guarding a critical section with a lock: enter one at a time, do the shared work, then release.

3.9 Thread Safety

Code is **thread-safe** if it behaves correctly when called from multiple threads at once, regardless of interleaving. You achieve it by (a) avoiding shared mutable state (use locals/immutable data), (b) protecting shared state with locks, or (c) using atomic operations. A function that keeps hidden shared state (like the classic `strtok`) is not thread-safe; reentrant variants (`strtok_r`) are provided precisely for threaded use.

A MINIMAL POSIX THREADS (PTHREADS) PROGRAM

```c
#include <pthread.h>
#include <stdio.h>

void *worker(void *arg) {
    long id = (long)arg;
    printf("thread %ld running\n", id);
    return NULL;
}

int main(void) {
    pthread_t t[4];
    for (long i = 0; i < 4; i++)
        pthread_create(&t[i], NULL, worker, (void *)i);  // spawn
    for (int i = 0; i < 4; i++)
        pthread_join(t[i], NULL);                        // wait for each
    return 0;                 // compile with: gcc prog.c -lpthread
}
```

✓ Check Your Understanding — Part III

CONCEPTUAL

1. List exactly what threads of a process share and what each keeps private.
2. Give the precise difference between concurrency and parallelism, with an example of concurrency without parallelism.
3. Contrast user-level and kernel-level threads, especially blocking behavior.
4. Describe the three multithreading models and which one Linux uses.
5. Define a race condition and a critical section.

APPLICATION

1. Two threads each run `counter++` 1,000,000 times on a shared `counter` starting at 0, with no lock. What is the range of possible final values, and why?
2. You move a CPU-bound program from 4 threads to 40 threads on a 4-core machine and it gets slower. Explain.
3. Why can passing a pointer to a thread's local variable to another thread cause corruption?

INTERVIEW-LEVEL

1. "When would you choose multiple processes over multiple threads?"
2. "Is a single-core machine capable of concurrency? Of parallelism? Explain."

CAN YOU EXPLAIN THIS? (NO NOTES)

The shared-vs-private thread memory picture · concurrency vs parallelism · why `counter++` races · one-to-one vs many-to-one threading.

⚑ PRACTICAL TASK

Write a pthreads program where N threads each increment a shared global counter one million times with no lock. Print the final value. Run it several times — watch it come out different and wrong. Keep this program; in Part V you will fix it with a mutex and see it print the correct value every time.

Mastered when... you can draw the thread memory model, explain why shared mutable state races, and predict when adding threads helps versus hurts.

PART IV

CPU Scheduling

Many processes are Ready; only one CPU is free. Which one runs next? The scheduler answers that question thousands of times a second, and its policy decides whether your system feels snappy or sluggish, fair or starving.

In this part: Why scheduling · The metrics (turnaround, waiting, response, throughput) · Preemptive vs non-preemptive · FCFS · SJF · SRTF · Priority · Round Robin · Multilevel & multilevel-feedback queues · Starvation, aging, the convoy effect · Fully solved numerical problems

PART IV

CPU Scheduling

CPU scheduling is where operating-systems theory becomes arithmetic you can be tested on. This part teaches every classic algorithm the way an interviewer or examiner wants it: the intuition, the mechanism, a Gantt chart, and the full turnaround/waiting-time calculation worked to the last number.

4.1 Why CPU Scheduling? The Metrics

A process alternates CPU bursts with I/O bursts (Part II). While one process waits on I/O, the CPU would sit idle — a waste. The **scheduler** keeps the CPU busy by picking another Ready process to run. The **dispatcher** is the component that actually performs the context switch to hand the CPU over. The rules the scheduler follows are the **scheduling algorithm**, and we judge algorithms by these metrics:

Metric	Definition	Goal
Arrival Time (AT)	When the process enters the ready queue	— (given)
Burst Time (BT)	CPU time the process needs	— (given)
Completion Time (CT)	When the process finishes	— (computed)
Turnaround Time	TAT = CT − AT (total time in system)	Minimize
Waiting Time	WT = TAT − BT (time spent waiting in ready queue)	Minimize
Response Time	RT = (first time on CPU) − AT	Minimize
Throughput	Processes completed per unit time	Maximize
CPU Utilization	Fraction of time the CPU is busy	Maximize
Fairness	No process is unduly denied the CPU	Maximize

▣ **KEY CONCEPT — THE THREE FORMULAS THAT SOLVE EVERY PROBLEM**

Turnaround Time = Completion Time − Arrival Time

Waiting Time = Turnaround Time − Burst Time

Response Time = First-CPU Time − Arrival Time

Build the Gantt chart first, read off each Completion Time, then apply these. Every numerical in this part — and in your exam — is just these three lines applied carefully.

Two problems to watch for

Starvation

A process waits indefinitely because others keep being preferred (common with priority and SJF, where a low-priority or long job may never get picked).

Convoy effect

Short processes stuck waiting behind one long process (classic FCFS problem), tanking average waiting time — like a line of cars stuck behind one slow truck.

4.2 Preemptive vs Non-Preemptive

Aspect	Non-Preemptive	Preemptive
CPU taken away?	No — a process runs until it finishes or blocks	Yes — the OS can forcibly pause a running process
Triggered by	Process exits or requests I/O	Timer interrupt, higher-priority arrival
Responsiveness	Poorer (long job blocks others)	Better (can react to new/urgent work)
Overhead	Lower (fewer switches)	Higher (more context switches)
Examples	FCFS, SJF, non-preemptive Priority	SRTF, Round Robin, preemptive Priority

Modern general-purpose OSes are **preemptive** — essential for interactivity and to stop any one process from hogging the CPU.

4.3 FCFS — First-Come, First-Served

Intuition. A queue at a shop: serve whoever arrives first, to completion. **Working.** Non-preemptive; the ready queue is a simple FIFO. Simplest possible policy.

Worked example. Four processes:

Process	Arrival	Burst
P1	0	5
P2	1	3
P3	2	8
P4	3	6

Order of service = order of arrival: P1, P2, P3, P4.



Boundaries: P1 0→5, P2 5→8, P3 8→16, P4 16→22.

Process	AT	BT	CT	TAT = CT−AT	WT = TAT−BT
P1	0	5	5	5	0
P2	1	3	8	7	4
P3	2	8	16	14	6
P4	3	6	22	19	13

Average TAT = (5+7+14+19)/4 = **11.25** Average WT = (0+4+6+13)/4 = **5.75**

+ Simple, fair in arrival order, no starvation. **−** The **convoy effect**: put a long job first and every short job waits behind it, ballooning average waiting time. Non-preemptive, so bad for interactivity.

> ⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**
>
> Forgetting idle time. If no process has arrived yet, the CPU sits idle and the timeline still advances. E.g. if P1 arrives at t=3 with nothing before it, the Gantt starts with idle [0→3], and P1's completion is 3+BT, not BT.

4.4 SJF — Shortest Job First (Non-Preemptive)

Intuition. Always run the Ready process with the smallest CPU burst next. Clearing the quick jobs first drags the average waiting time down. **SJF is provably optimal** for minimum average waiting time — among non-preemptive algorithms, no policy beats it.

Worked example (all arrive at t=0 for clarity): P1 BT=6, P2 BT=8, P3 BT=7, P4 BT=3. Pick shortest first: P4(3), P1(6), P3(7), P2(8).



Boundaries: P4 0→3, P1 3→9, P3 9→16, P2 16→24.

Process	BT	CT	TAT	WT
P4	3	3	3	0
P1	6	9	9	3
P3	7	16	16	9
P2	8	24	24	16

Average WT = (0+3+9+16)/4 = **7.0** (FCFS on the same set gives 10.25 — SJF wins)

+ Optimal average waiting time. **−** Requires knowing burst times in advance (impossible in general — the OS must estimate them, e.g. exponential averaging of past bursts); risks **starvation** of long jobs if short jobs keep arriving.

4.5 SRTF — Shortest Remaining Time First (Preemptive SJF)

Intuition. The preemptive version of SJF: whenever a new process arrives, compare its burst against the remaining time of the running process; if the newcomer is shorter, preempt. Decisions are re-made at every arrival.

Worked example: P1(AT=0,BT=8), P2(AT=1,BT=4), P3(AT=2,BT=9), P4(AT=3,BT=5).

- t=0: only P1 → run P1.
- t=1: P2(4) arrives; P1 remaining=7. 4<7 → preempt, run P2.
- t=2,3: P3(9), P4(5) arrive; P2 remaining (3, then 2) still smallest → keep P2.
- t=5: P2 done. Remaining P1=7, P3=9, P4=5 → run P4 (5).
- t=10: P4 done. Remaining P1=7, P3=9 → run P1 (7).
- t=17: P1 done. Run P3 (9) → done at 26.



Boundaries: P1 0→1, P2 1→5, P4 5→10, P1 10→17, P3 17→26.

Process	AT	BT	CT	TAT	WT
P1	0	8	17	17	9
P2	1	4	5	4	0
P3	2	9	26	24	15
P4	3	5	10	7	2

Average WT = (9+0+15+2)/4 = **6.5** Average TAT = (17+4+24+7)/4 = **13.0**

+ Lowest possible average waiting time of all these algorithms. **−** Heavy preemption overhead; still needs burst estimates; worst starvation risk for long jobs.

4.6 Priority Scheduling

Intuition. Each process has a priority number; the CPU always goes to the highest-priority Ready process. (Convention here: smaller number = higher priority.) Can be preemptive or non-preemptive. SJF is actually priority scheduling with priority = 1/burst.

Worked example (non-preemptive, all AT=0): P1(BT=4,pri=3), P2(BT=3,pri=1), P3(BT=1,pri=4), P4(BT=5,pri=2). Order by priority: P2, P4, P1, P3.



Boundaries: P2 0→3, P4 3→8, P1 8→12, P3 12→13.

WT: P2=0, P4=3, P1=8, P3=12 → Average WT = 23/4 = **5.75**

▣ **KEY CONCEPT — STARVATION & AGING**

Priority scheduling can **starve** low-priority processes forever if high-priority ones keep arriving. The standard cure is **aging**: gradually raise the priority of a process the longer it waits, so every process eventually becomes high-priority enough to run. (Legend: when MIT's IBM 7094 was shut down in 1973, a low-priority job submitted in 1967 was found still waiting.)

4.7 Round Robin (RR)

Intuition. FCFS with a stopwatch. Each process gets a fixed **time quantum** (time slice); if it doesn't finish, it's preempted and sent to the back of the ready queue. Designed for fairness and good response time — the heart of interactive time-sharing.

Worked example (quantum q=2, all AT=0): P1 BT=5, P2 BT=4, P3 BT=2, P4 BT=1.



Boundaries: P1 0→2, P2 2→4, P3 4→6, P4 6→7, P1 7→9, P2 9→11, P1 11→12.

Process	BT	CT	TAT	WT	RT
P1	5	12	12	7	0
P2	4	11	11	7	2
P3	2	6	6	4	4
P4	1	7	7	6	6

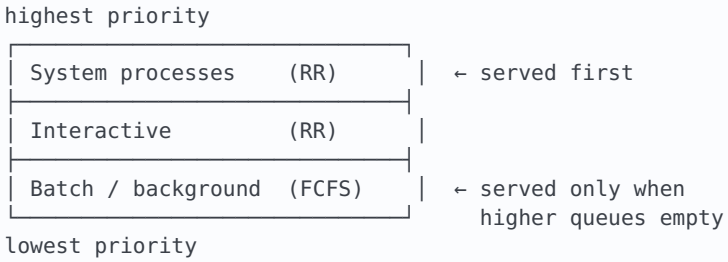
Average WT = 24/4 = **6.0** Average TAT = 36/4 = **9.0** Average RT = 12/4 = **3.0**

⚑ INTERVIEW TIP — CHOOSING THE QUANTUM

The time quantum is a knob. **Too large** → RR degenerates into FCFS (each job finishes in one slice), hurting response time. **Too small** → excessive context-switch overhead eats the CPU. Rule of thumb: the quantum should be large enough that ~80% of CPU bursts finish within it, typically 10–100 ms. RR optimizes response time and fairness, not average waiting time.

4.8 Multilevel Queue (MLQ)

Real systems have different classes of process (interactive, batch, system). MLQ splits the ready queue into several separate queues, each with its own scheduling algorithm, and processes are permanently assigned to one queue by type.



Multilevel queue: fixed classes, each with its own policy; higher queues preferred.

− Rigid — a process is stuck in its queue, and low queues can starve. That rigidity motivates the next algorithm.

4.9 Multilevel Feedback Queue (MLFQ)

The most sophisticated classic scheduler, and the closest to what real OSes use. Like MLQ, but processes can **move between queues** based on observed behavior:

- New processes enter the top (highest-priority, short-quantum) queue.
- A process that uses its whole quantum (CPU-bound) is **demoted** to a lower, longer-quantum queue.
- A process that yields early for I/O (interactive) stays high or is **promoted**.
- Periodic **aging** boosts long-waiting processes to prevent starvation.

▣ KEY CONCEPT

MLFQ learns each process's nature without being told its burst time: interactive jobs (short bursts) naturally float to the top for great responsiveness, while CPU hogs sink to the bottom where they run efficiently in long slices. It approximates SJF's benefits without needing to know burst times in advance. This is why it's the design basis for Windows, macOS, and older Linux schedulers.

4.10 Comparison & How to Choose

Algorithm	Preempt?	Optimizes	Starvation	Key weakness
FCFS	No	Simplicity	No	Convoy effect
SJF	No	Avg waiting time	Yes	Needs burst times
SRTF	Yes	Avg waiting time (best)	Yes	Overhead + estimates
Priority	Either	Importance	Yes	Starvation (use aging)
Round Robin	Yes	Response time, fairness	No	Quantum tuning
MLFQ	Yes	Balanced, adaptive	No (aging)	Complex to tune

Real-world: Linux's modern **CFS** (Completely Fair Scheduler) doesn't use fixed slices at all — it tracks each task's "virtual runtime" and always runs the one that has had the least CPU, approximating perfect fairness. The classic algorithms above remain the vocabulary for reasoning about and interviewing on scheduling.

✓ Check Your Understanding — Part IV

CONCEPTUAL

1. Write the formulas for turnaround, waiting, and response time.
2. What is the convoy effect and which algorithm suffers from it?
3. Why is SJF optimal for average waiting time, and why can't we use it directly?
4. Explain starvation and how aging fixes it.
5. How does MLFQ approximate SJF without knowing burst times?

APPLICATION (SOLVE FULLY — GANTT + TABLE)

1. P1(AT0,BT4), P2(AT1,BT3), P3(AT2,BT1), P4(AT3,BT2): compute average WT and TAT under **FCFS**, then under **SRTF**. Which is better?
2. Same four processes under **Round Robin, q=2**: give the Gantt chart and average response time.
3. Show that increasing RR's quantum toward infinity turns it into FCFS.

INTERVIEW-LEVEL

1. "Which scheduler would you pick for a real-time system vs. a batch server vs. a desktop, and why?"
2. "Design a scheduler that gives interactive apps good response time and batch jobs good throughput." (Hint: MLFQ.)

CAN YOU EXPLAIN THIS? (NO NOTES)

Build a Gantt chart and compute WT/TAT for any algorithm · convoy effect · the quantum trade-off in RR · why MLFQ adapts to process behavior.

⚑ **PRACTICAL TASK**

On Linux, run `nice -n 19 yes > /dev/null &` and `nice -n -5 yes > /dev/null &` (the second may need `sudo`), then watch them in `top`. Observe how the scheduler splits CPU by priority. Kill them with `kill %1 %2`. You've just driven the scheduler by hand (more in Part XIV).

Mastered when... given any process table you can produce the correct Gantt chart and average waiting/turnaround/response times for FCFS, SJF, SRTF, Priority, and Round Robin — and explain which metric each algorithm optimizes.

PART V

Process Synchronization

Concurrency without coordination is corruption. This part gives you the tools — mutexes, semaphores, monitors — and drills them on the three classic problems every OS course and systems interview returns to.

In this part: The critical-section problem · Mutual exclusion, progress, bounded waiting · Atomic operations · Locks & mutexes · Spinlocks · Busy waiting vs blocking · Semaphores (binary & counting) · Monitors & condition variables · Producer–Consumer · Readers–Writers · Dining Philosophers

PART V

Process Synchronization

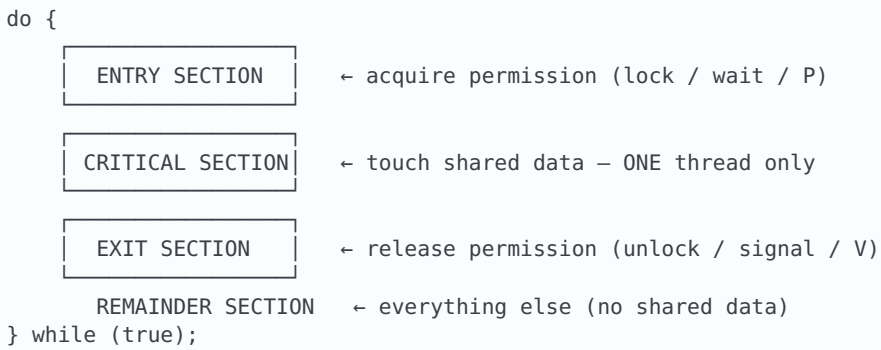
In Part III you saw `counter++` lose updates when two threads race. Here you learn to stop that — precisely, correctly, and without creating new problems like deadlock. These primitives are the vocabulary of every concurrent program you will ever write.

5.1 The Critical-Section Problem

Recall the race: shared data touched by concurrent threads, at least one writing, with a non-atomic operation in the middle. The region of code that touches the shared data is the **critical section**. The goal is to allow only one thread inside it at a time — **mutual exclusion** — without breaking two other guarantees.

> ▣ **KEY CONCEPT — THE THREE REQUIREMENTS OF A CORRECT SOLUTION**
>
> **1. Mutual Exclusion.** At most one thread executes in the critical section at a time.
> **2. Progress.** If no thread is in the critical section and some want in, the choice of who enters cannot be postponed indefinitely — a thread not interested must not block others.
> **3. Bounded Waiting.** There is a limit on how many times other threads enter before a waiting thread gets its turn — no starvation.

Every lock, semaphore, and monitor exists to satisfy these three at once. A "solution" that provides mutual exclusion but allows starvation (violates bounded waiting) is wrong.



The structure of any thread using a shared resource. The synchronization lives in the entry and exit sections.

5.2 Atomic Operations

What & why. An **atomic operation** executes as a single, indivisible step — it cannot be interrupted halfway, so no other thread can see a partial result. Atomicity is the bedrock: if `counter++` were atomic, there would be no race. Since it isn't, the hardware provides atomic primitives that locks are built from:

- **Test-and-Set** — atomically read a flag and set it to 1, returning the old value.
- **Compare-and-Swap (CAS)** — atomically: "if memory == expected, set it to new; return success." The workhorse of modern lock-free programming.
- **Fetch-and-Add** — atomically add to a memory location and return the old value.

A SPINLOCK BUILT FROM ATOMIC TEST-AND-SET (CONCEPT)

```
int lock = 0;                       // 0 = free, 1 = held

void acquire() {
    while (test_and_set(&lock) == 1)  // atomically: old=lock; lock=1; return old
        ;                             // spin: keep trying until we saw 0
}
void release() { lock = 0; }          // hand it back
```

5.3 Locks and Mutexes

A **mutex** (MUTual EXclusion lock) is the simplest synchronization object: it is either **locked** or **unlocked**, and it has an **owner**. A thread `lock()`s it before the critical section and `unlock()`s it after. Only the thread that locked it may unlock it. If another thread tries to lock a held mutex, it **blocks** (sleeps) until the owner releases.

FIXING THE PART III RACE WITH A PTHREAD MUTEX

```
#include <pthread.h>

long counter = 0;
pthread_mutex_t m = PTHREAD_MUTEX_INITIALIZER;

void *worker(void *arg) {
    for (int i = 0; i < 1000000; i++) {
        pthread_mutex_lock(&m);       // ENTRY: only one thread past here
        counter++;                    // CRITICAL SECTION (now safe)
        pthread_mutex_unlock(&m);     // EXIT: let the next thread in
    }
    return NULL;
}
// Now the final counter is EXACTLY N * 1000000, every single run.
```

> ⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**
>
> Locking too much or too little. Lock too little (leave a shared write unprotected) and the race persists. Lock too much (hold the mutex across slow I/O) and you serialize everything, killing concurrency. Hold locks for the shortest correct span — protect the shared data, nothing more.

5.4 Spinlocks: Busy Waiting vs Blocking

When a lock is held, a waiting thread can do one of two things:

Busy waiting (spinlock)
: Loop, repeatedly checking the lock ("spinning"), burning CPU while it waits. No context switch, so it's fast if the wait is very short.

Blocking (mutex)
: Give up the CPU and sleep; the OS wakes the thread when the lock frees. Wastes no CPU, but pays two context switches (sleep + wake).

	Spinlock (busy wait)	Mutex (blocking)
While waiting	Spins, consuming CPU	Sleeps, frees the CPU
Cost to wait	Wasted cycles	Two context switches
Best when	Very short critical sections, multi-core	Long or unpredictable waits
On 1 core	Terrible (spins while holder can't run)	Correct choice
Used in	Kernel, low-level, brief locks	Application code, general use

> ⚑ **INTERVIEW TIP**
>
> "Spinlock vs mutex?" A spinlock busy-waits; a mutex sleeps. Spinlocks win only when the critical section is shorter than the cost of two context switches and you have multiple cores (so the holder can run on another core while you spin). On a single core, spinning is pointless — the thread holding the lock can't make progress while you monopolize the CPU spinning. Real kernels use hybrid "adaptive" locks that spin briefly, then sleep.

5.5 Semaphores

What is it? A **semaphore** is an integer counter with two atomic operations, invented by Dijkstra. `wait()` (also **P**, or `down`) decrements it, blocking if it would go negative; `signal()` (also **V**, or `up`) increments it, waking a waiter. The counter tracks "how many units of a resource are available."

SEMAPHORE SEMANTICS (ATOMIC)

```
wait(S):   // P — acquire
    while (S <= 0) ;   // block until a unit is available
    S = S - 1;

signal(S): // V — release
    S = S + 1;         // wake a blocked waiter if any
```

Binary semaphore

Counter is only 0 or 1. Acts like a lock (mutual exclusion). But unlike a mutex, it has no owner — any thread may signal it.

Counting semaphore

Counter ranges over 0..N, representing N identical resource units (e.g. "5 database connections available"). Threads `wait()` to take one, `signal()` to return one.

▣ **KEY CONCEPT — TWO DISTINCT USES OF SEMAPHORES**

(1) Mutual exclusion: a binary semaphore initialized to 1 guards a critical section. **(2) Signaling / ordering:** a semaphore initialized to 0 makes one thread wait for another to reach a point (thread A does `signal`, thread B's `wait` unblocks). This second use — enforcing an order between threads — is something a plain mutex cannot do, and it's the key to producer–consumer.

5.6 Mutex vs Semaphore — the Comparisons

	Mutex	Binary Semaphore	Counting Semaphore
Value	Locked / unlocked	0 or 1	0 .. N
Ownership	**Yes** — locker must unlock	No — anyone can signal	No
Purpose	Mutual exclusion	Mutual exclusion / signaling	Manage N resources / signaling
Can signal from another thread?	No	Yes	Yes
Analogy	One key, you took it, you return it	One key on a hook, anyone can hang it	N keys on a hook

▣ **KEY CONCEPT — MUTEX VS SEMAPHORE IN ONE LINE**

A **mutex is a locking mechanism** (ownership; used for mutual exclusion). A **semaphore is a signaling mechanism** (a counter; used to coordinate/count). Every mutex can be built from a binary semaphore, but a mutex adds ownership. Use a **mutex** to protect data; use a **semaphore** to count resources or to make one thread wait for an event in another.

> ⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**
>
> "A binary semaphore is just a mutex." Not quite — the difference is **ownership**. A mutex can only be unlocked by the thread that locked it; a binary semaphore can be signaled by any thread. That makes the semaphore usable for signaling between threads, but also makes it easier to misuse (e.g. accidentally signal twice). This exact distinction is a favorite trap question.

5.7 Monitors and Condition Variables

Semaphores are powerful but error-prone: forget a `signal`, or order two `wait`s wrongly, and you deadlock — with no compiler help. A **monitor** is a higher-level construct that bundles shared data and the operations on it, guaranteeing that only one thread is active inside the monitor at a time (automatic mutual exclusion). Languages provide them directly: Java's `synchronized`, C#'s `lock`.

Inside a monitor, **condition variables** let a thread wait for a condition without busy-waiting:

- `wait(cv)` — atomically release the monitor lock and sleep until signaled.
- `signal(cv)` — wake one thread waiting on `cv`.
- `broadcast(cv)` — wake all of them.

> ⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**
>
> Checking a condition with `if` instead of `while` before `wait()`. After waking, a thread must recheck the condition in a loop, because (a) another thread may have changed it first (spurious/ stolen wakeups). Always: `while (!ready) cond_wait(&cv,&m);`

5.8 Classic Problem 1 — Producer–Consumer (Bounded Buffer)

Problem. A producer thread creates items and puts them in a fixed-size buffer; a consumer takes them out. **Why it's hard:** the producer must wait if the buffer is full; the consumer must wait if it's empty; and both mutate the buffer, so access must be mutually exclusive.

Naive (broken) approach: a single mutex around the buffer. It prevents corruption but doesn't handle full/empty — the producer would spin-fail on a full buffer, wasting CPU, and there's no clean way to wait for space. **Correct approach:** two counting semaphores to track space and items, plus a mutex for exclusion.

PRODUCER-CONSUMER WITH SEMAPHORES (THE CANONICAL SOLUTION)

```
sem_t empty;   // counts free slots; init to N (buffer size)
sem_t full;    // counts filled slots; init to 0
pthread_mutex_t mutex;  // protects the buffer; init unlocked
```

```
void producer() {
    while (1) {
        item = produce_item();
        sem_wait(&empty);          // wait for a free slot  (blocks if full)
        pthread_mutex_lock(&mutex);
        buffer_put(item);          // CRITICAL SECTION
        pthread_mutex_unlock(&mutex);
        sem_post(&full);           // announce one more item
    }
}
void consumer() {
    while (1) {
        sem_wait(&full);           // wait for an item  (blocks if empty)
        pthread_mutex_lock(&mutex);
        item = buffer_get();       // CRITICAL SECTION
        pthread_mutex_unlock(&mutex);
        sem_post(&empty);          // announce one more free slot
        consume_item(item);
    }
}
```

⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE — DEADLY ORDERING BUG**

Never lock the mutex before the semaphore wait. If the producer does `lock(mutex)` then `wait(empty)` on a full buffer, it sleeps holding the mutex; the consumer can never lock the mutex to remove an item → **deadlock**. Order is always: `wait(counting semaphore)` first, then `lock(mutex)`.

5.9 Classic Problem 2 — Readers–Writers

Problem. A shared resource (e.g. a database) may be read by many threads simultaneously (reads don't conflict), but a writer needs exclusive access (writes conflict with everything). Maximize concurrency: allow concurrent readers, but a writer must be alone.

Correct approach (reader-preference): a mutex for the resource, a counter of active readers, and a mutex protecting that counter. The first reader in "locks out" writers; the last reader out releases them.

READERS-WRITERS (READER PREFERENCE)

```
int readers = 0;
pthread_mutex_t rc;          // protects the readers counter
sem_t rw;                    // exclusive access to the resource; init 1

void reader() {
    pthread_mutex_lock(&rc);
    if (++readers == 1) sem_wait(&rw); // FIRST reader blocks writers
    pthread_mutex_unlock(&rc);

    read_resource();                   // many readers here at once

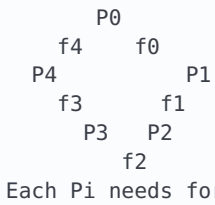
    pthread_mutex_lock(&rc);
```

```
    if (--readers == 0) sem_post(&rw); // LAST reader frees writers
    pthread_mutex_unlock(&rc);
}
void writer() {
    sem_wait(&rw);            // exclusive: wait for zero readers AND no writer
    write_resource();
    sem_post(&rw);
}
```

Trade-off / common mistake: this reader-preference version can **starve writers** — a steady stream of readers never lets `readers` hit 0. Production solutions use writer-preference or a fair queue to guarantee bounded waiting for writers.

5.10 Classic Problem 3 — Dining Philosophers

Problem. Five philosophers sit around a table; one fork between each pair (five forks). To eat, a philosopher needs both adjacent forks. This models processes competing for multiple shared resources — and it's the canonical way to produce (and study) **deadlock**.



Each Pi needs fork[i] (left) and fork[(i+1)%5] (right).

Five philosophers, five forks. Everyone grabbing their left fork at once = deadlock.

Naive (deadlocking) approach: everyone picks up their left fork, then their right. If all five grab their left fork simultaneously, each holds one and waits forever for the right — a perfect **circular wait** (Part VI). **Correct approaches** that break the circular wait:

- **Resource ordering:** number the forks; always pick up the lower-numbered fork first. One philosopher then reaches for forks in the opposite order, breaking the cycle. (Breaks circular wait.)
- **Asymmetry:** odd philosophers grab left-then-right, even ones right-then-left.
- **Limit diners:** allow at most 4 philosophers to sit at once (a counting semaphore init to 4), guaranteeing at least one can get both forks.
- **Waiter/monitor:** a central arbiter grants forks only when both are free (pick up both or neither).

DINING PHILOSOPHERS — DEADLOCK-FREE VIA RESOURCE ORDERING

```
void philosopher(int i) {
    int left = i, right = (i + 1) % 5;
    int first = (left < right) ? left : right;   // always lower-numbered fork first
    int second = (left < right) ? right : left;
    while (1) {
```

```
        think();
        sem_wait(&fork[first]);      // consistent global order → no cycle → no
deadlock
        sem_wait(&fork[second]);
        eat();
        sem_post(&fork[second]);
        sem_post(&fork[first]);
    }
}
```

⚑ INTERVIEW TIP

Dining Philosophers is really a deadlock question in disguise. Name the four Coffman conditions (Part VI) and show which your solution breaks: resource ordering and asymmetry break **circular wait**; "pick up both or neither" breaks **hold-and-wait**; the ≤4-diners rule ensures at least one philosopher can always proceed. Mentioning the Coffman connection is what earns the senior-level nod.

✓ Check Your Understanding — Part V

CONCEPTUAL

1. State the three requirements a correct critical-section solution must satisfy.
2. What is the difference between a mutex and a semaphore? Between a binary semaphore and a mutex?
3. When is a spinlock the right choice, and when is it disastrous?
4. Why must a condition-variable wait be inside a `while` loop, not an `if`?
5. How do the two counting semaphores in producer–consumer differ in purpose?

APPLICATION

1. In producer–consumer, show exactly how swapping `wait(empty)` and `lock(mutex)` causes deadlock.
2. Explain how the reader-preference readers–writers solution can starve a writer, and propose a fix.
3. For dining philosophers, prove that the resource-ordering solution cannot deadlock.

INTERVIEW-LEVEL

1. "Implement a thread-safe bounded queue. Which primitives, and why?"
2. "You have a lock-free counter requirement. How would compare-and-swap help?"

CAN YOU EXPLAIN THIS? (NO NOTES)

Mutex vs semaphore vs binary semaphore · the producer–consumer semaphore solution and its deadly ordering bug · how each dining-philosophers fix breaks a Coffman condition.

⚑ PRACTICAL TASK

Take your racing counter from Part III. Add a `pthread_mutex_t` around the increment and confirm the result is now always exactly correct. Then time both versions — measure how much the lock costs. You've now felt both correctness and the price of synchronization.

Mastered when... you can implement producer–consumer, readers–writers, and a deadlock-free dining philosophers from memory, and explain the purpose of every `wait`/`signal` and lock in each.

PART VI

Deadlocks

Give two threads two locks and let them grab in opposite orders, and your program freezes forever — no crash, no error, just silence. Deadlock is the dark side of the synchronization you just learned. This part shows how it arises and the four ways to handle it.

In this part: What deadlock is · The four Coffman conditions · Resource allocation graphs · Prevention · Avoidance & safe states · Banker's Algorithm (fully worked) · Detection & recovery · Deadlock vs starvation vs livelock

PART VI

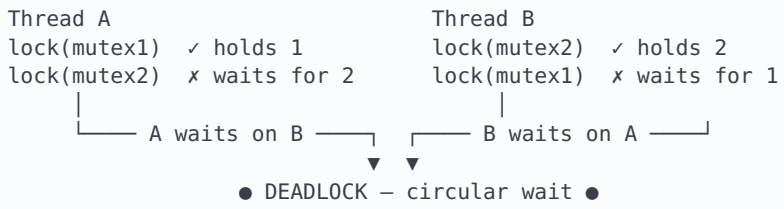
Deadlocks

A deadlock is a standstill: a set of processes each holding a resource the next one needs, in a circle, so none can ever proceed. Understanding the exact conditions that make it possible tells you precisely how to prevent it — and the Banker's Algorithm shows how to sidestep it entirely.

6.1 What Is a Deadlock?

What is it? A **deadlock** is a situation where a set of processes are each blocked, waiting for a resource that another process in the set is holding, so that none of them can ever make progress. The system is stuck — permanently, without intervention.

Simple intuition. A narrow bridge with one lane. Two cars enter from opposite ends and meet in the middle. Neither can pass, and neither will back up. Both wait forever. Each car holds "its half of the bridge" and needs "the other half" — held by the other car.



The textbook two-lock deadlock: two threads acquire the same two locks in opposite orders.

6.2 The Four Coffman Conditions

Deadlock is possible only if all four of these hold simultaneously. This is the single most important fact in the topic: break **any one** and deadlock cannot occur.

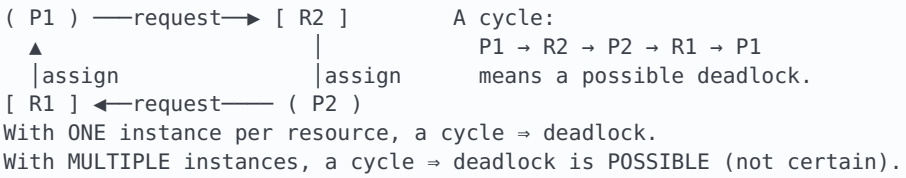
Condition	Meaning	Bridge analogy
1. Mutual Exclusion	At least one resource is non-shareable — only one process can hold it at a time.	The lane fits one car.
2. Hold and Wait	A process holds at least one resource while waiting to acquire others.	A car sits on its half while waiting for the other half.
3. No Preemption	Resources cannot be forcibly taken; they're released only voluntarily.	No one can make a car reverse.
4. Circular Wait	A closed chain of processes exists, each waiting for a resource held by the next.	Car A waits on B, B waits on A.

▣ KEY CONCEPT

All four Coffman conditions are **necessary**; together they are **sufficient** (given a single instance of each resource). Every deadlock prevention strategy works by making one of the four impossible. Circular wait is usually the easiest to attack (via resource ordering), which is why "lock ordering" is the number-one practical deadlock defense.

6.3 Resource Allocation Graph (RAG)

A **resource-allocation graph** pictures who holds and who wants what. Processes are circles, resources are squares. An edge **R → P** (assignment) means the resource is allocated to the process; an edge **P → R** (request) means the process is waiting for it.



A cycle in the RAG signals deadlock (certain for single-instance resources, possible otherwise).

⚠ COMMON MISTAKE

"A cycle in the resource-allocation graph always means deadlock." Only if every resource type has a single instance. With multiple instances of a resource, a cycle is necessary but not sufficient — another process outside the cycle might release an instance and break it.

6.4 Four Ways to Handle Deadlock

1. **Prevention** — structurally ensure one Coffman condition can never hold. (Conservative.)
2. **Avoidance** — allow the conditions but never enter a state that could lead to deadlock; the OS checks each request (Banker's Algorithm). (Needs future knowledge.)
3. **Detection & Recovery** — allow deadlocks, detect them with an algorithm, then recover (kill/rollback). (Reactive.)
4. **Ignore it** — the "ostrich algorithm": pretend deadlocks never happen. Used by most general-purpose OSes (Linux, Windows) because deadlocks are rare and prevention is costly; reboot if one occurs.

6.5 Deadlock Prevention

Attack each condition:

Break this	How	Cost
Mutual Exclusion	Make resources shareable (e.g. read-only files); use spooling	Not always possible (some resources are inherently exclusive)
Hold and Wait	Require a process to request all resources up front, or hold none while requesting	Low utilization; possible starvation
No Preemption	If a process must wait, forcibly release the resources it holds	Only works for state-saveable resources (CPU, memory — not a printer mid-print)
Circular Wait	Impose a global ordering on resources; always acquire in increasing order	Practical & popular — but you must define and honor the order everywhere

> ⚑ **INTERVIEW TIP**
>
> "How do you prevent deadlock in real code?" Answer: **lock ordering** — establish a fixed global order for acquiring locks and always take them in that order. This breaks circular wait and is what real codebases actually do. The two-lock example deadlocks precisely because A and B take `mutex1` / `mutex2` in opposite orders; force both to take `mutex1` first and it's impossible.

6.6 Deadlock Avoidance and Safe States

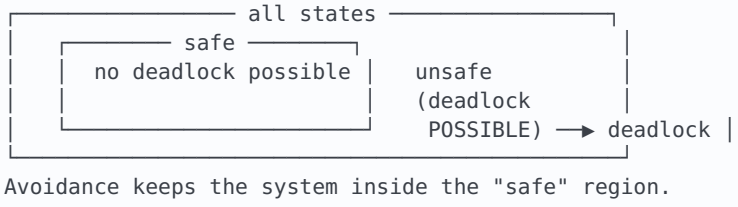
Avoidance is less restrictive than prevention: it permits the four conditions but, before granting any resource request, checks whether doing so keeps the system in a **safe state**.

Safe state

There exists at least one ordering of all processes (a **safe sequence**) in which each can obtain its maximum needed resources, run, and finish — even if every process demands its maximum. A safe state guarantees no deadlock.

Unsafe state

No such sequence is guaranteed to exist. Unsafe does not mean deadlock — it means deadlock is possible. Avoidance simply refuses to ever step into unsafe territory.



Avoidance keeps the system inside the "safe" region.

Safe ⊂ unsafe ⊃ deadlock. Avoidance never lets the system leave the safe region.

6.7 Banker's Algorithm (Worked Numerical)

The classic avoidance algorithm (Dijkstra). Like a banker who never lends so much that they can't satisfy every client's credit line, the OS grants a request only if the resulting state is safe.

Data structures (for n processes, m resource types): **Available[m]** (free units), **Max[n][m]** (each process's maximum claim), **Allocation[n][m]** (currently held), and **Need[n][m] = Max − Allocation**.

Example. Total resources: A=10, B=5, C=7. Snapshot of five processes:

Process	Allocation			Max			Need = Max−Alloc		
	A	B	C	A	B	C	A	B	C
P0	0	1	0	7	5	3	7	4	3
P1	2	0	0	3	2	2	1	2	2
P2	3	0	2	9	0	2	6	0	0
P3	2	1	1	2	2	2	0	1	1
P4	0	0	2	4	3	3	4	3	1

Allocated totals: A=7, B=2, C=5, so **Available = (10,5,7) − (7,2,5) = (3, 3, 2)**.

Safety check. Start with Work = Available = (3,3,2) and all processes unfinished. Repeatedly find a process whose Need ≤ Work; "run" it and add its Allocation back to Work.

Step	Pick (Need ≤ Work?)	Need	Work before	Work after (+Alloc)
1	P1: (1,2,2) ≤ (3,3,2) ✓	1 2 2	3 3 2	5 3 2
2	P3: (0,1,1) ≤ (5,3,2) ✓	0 1 1	5 3 2	7 4 3
3	P0: (7,4,3) ≤ (7,4,3) ✓	7 4 3	7 4 3	7 5 3
4	P2: (6,0,0) ≤ (7,5,3) ✓	6 0 0	7 5 3	10 5 5
5	P4: (4,3,1) ≤ (10,5,5) ✓	4 3 1	10 5 5	10 5 7

All five processes finished ⇒ state is **SAFE**. Safe sequence = ⟨ P1, P3, P0, P2, P4 ⟩

A resource request. Suppose P1 now requests **(1, 0, 2)**. Banker's checks: (i) Request ≤ Need P1 (1,2,2)? ✓ (ii) Request ≤ Available (3,3,2)? ✓. Tentatively grant: Available → (2,3,0), Alloc(P1) → (3,0,2), Need(P1) → (0,2,0). Re-run the safety check — it still finds the sequence ⟨ P1, P3, P0, P2, P4 ⟩, so the state is safe and the request is **granted**. (Had it been unsafe, the request would be denied and P1 made to wait.)

> ⚑ **INTERVIEW TIP**
>
> The mechanical recipe: (1) compute **Need = Max − Allocation**; (2) **Available = Total − sum of Allocation**; (3) run the safety loop with `Work` and `Finish[]`. If you can find any order that finishes everyone, it's safe. For a request, check `Request ≤ Need` and `Request ≤ Available`, pretend-allocate, then re-run safety. Practice this until it's automatic — it's a guaranteed exam question (see Part XIX for more).

6.8 Deadlock Detection and Recovery

If you neither prevent nor avoid, you must **detect**. For single-instance resources, detection = finding a cycle in the (wait-for) graph. For multiple instances, an algorithm similar to the Banker's safety check runs periodically: if some processes can never finish, they're deadlocked.

Recovery options once a deadlock is found:

- **Process termination** — kill all deadlocked processes, or kill them one at a time (least-cost first) until the cycle breaks.
- **Resource preemption** — forcibly take a resource from one process and give it to another, **rolling back** the victim to a safe checkpoint. Must avoid starving the same victim repeatedly.

6.9 Deadlock vs Starvation vs Livelock

	Deadlock	Starvation	Livelock
What happens	Processes blocked forever in a circular wait	A process waits indefinitely while others proceed	Processes actively change state but make no progress
Are they running?	No — all blocked	Others run; the victim doesn't	Yes — busy, but uselessly
Cause	All four Coffman conditions	Unfair scheduling / resource policy	Overly polite retry logic (both keep yielding)
Analogy	Gridlocked intersection	Always skipped in line	Two people stepping aside in a hallway, repeatedly
Fix	Break a Coffman condition	Aging / fair scheduling	Add randomness / backoff

> ▣ **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Deadlock:** everyone stuck, no one moving. **Livelock:** everyone moving, no one progressing (they keep reacting to each other). **Starvation:** the system progresses, but one unlucky process never gets its turn. All three are "no progress" failures, but the mechanism differs — and so does the fix.

✓ Check Your Understanding — Part VI

CONCEPTUAL

1. Name the four Coffman conditions and give the bridge analogy for each.
2. Why must all four hold for deadlock, and what does that imply for prevention?
3. When does a cycle in a resource-allocation graph guarantee deadlock?
4. Define safe and unsafe states. Does unsafe mean deadlock?
5. Distinguish deadlock, livelock, and starvation.

APPLICATION

1. Given Available=(3,3,2) and the table in §6.7, is a request of (3,3,0) by P4 grantable? Show the safety check.
2. Rewrite the two-lock deadlock example so it cannot deadlock, and name the condition you broke.
3. A printer deadlock can't be fixed by preemption — why? Which resources can be preempted?

INTERVIEW-LEVEL

1. "Why do most real operating systems 'ignore' deadlock (ostrich algorithm)?"
2. "Walk me through the Banker's Algorithm and its main practical drawback." (Hint: needs max claims in advance.)

CAN YOU EXPLAIN THIS? (NO NOTES)

The four Coffman conditions and how to break each · safe vs unsafe vs deadlocked · the full Banker's safety check · deadlock vs livelock vs starvation.

⚑ **PRACTICAL TASK**

Write a two-thread C program that deadlocks: thread A locks `m1` then `m2`; thread B locks `m2` then `m1`; put a `sleep(1)` between the two locks so it deadlocks reliably. Run it — it hangs. Then fix it by making both threads lock in the same order, and watch it complete.

Mastered when... you can run the Banker's Algorithm on any snapshot to decide safety and grant/deny a request, and you can look at concurrent code and spot the lock-ordering bug that would deadlock it.

PART VII

Memory Management

RAM is a single shared array of bytes, yet every process believes it owns a private, contiguous memory from address zero. Memory management is the machinery — addresses, page tables, and the MMU — that makes that comfortable illusion real and safe.

In this part: Logical vs physical vs virtual addresses · Address binding · Contiguous allocation · Fixed & variable partitioning · Internal & external fragmentation · Compaction · Paging (pages, frames, page tables) · Address translation · TLB · Multi-level & inverted page tables · Segmentation

PART VII

Memory Management

Every process you met in Part II runs in its own address space. Here is how that address space is actually mapped onto physical RAM — the addresses, the page tables, and the hardware that translates one into the other billions of times per second.

7.1 Why Memory Management?

Main memory (RAM) is a large array of bytes, each with an address. The CPU fetches instructions and data from it directly. The OS's memory-management job is to (1) give each process the memory it needs, (2) keep processes from reading or writing each other's memory (protection), (3) let more processes run than would fit if each needed all its memory at once, and (4) do all this fast, since every instruction touches memory. The central trick is a level of **indirection** between the addresses a program uses and the physical locations they end up at.

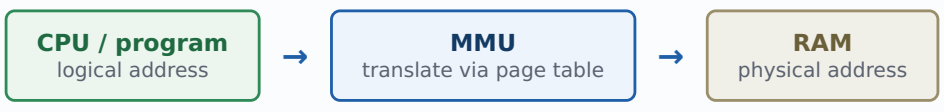
7.2 Logical, Physical, and Virtual Addresses

Logical (virtual) address
: The address a program generates and sees — e.g. the value of a pointer. It's relative to the process's own address space, starting conceptually at 0.

Physical address
: The real address of a byte in the RAM chips. What the memory hardware actually uses.

Virtual address
: Modern synonym for logical address in a system with virtual memory (Part VIII). The full set a process can name is its **virtual address space**.

The **Memory Management Unit (MMU)** — hardware in the CPU — translates every logical address to a physical address on the fly, using tables the OS sets up. The program never sees physical addresses; this is what enables both protection and virtual memory.



The MMU sits between the CPU and RAM, translating every memory reference.

Address Binding

"Binding" is fixing a program's addresses to real locations. It can happen at three times:

- **Compile time** — if you know where the program will load, generate absolute addresses. Rigid (must recompile to move).
- **Load time** — the compiler emits relocatable code; addresses are fixed when the program loads.
- **Execution time** — binding is deferred until run time and can change as the process moves; this needs hardware (the MMU) and is what modern systems use. It's what makes paging and swapping possible.

7.3 Contiguous Allocation

The oldest scheme: give each process a single contiguous block of physical memory.

Fixed (static) partitioning

Divide memory into a fixed number of partitions of preset size. Simple, but a process smaller than its partition wastes the rest (internal fragmentation), and a process larger than any partition can't run.

Variable (dynamic) partitioning

Partitions are created to fit each process exactly. No internal waste, but as processes come and go they leave holes, producing external fragmentation.

Placement strategies for variable partitioning — where to put a new process among the holes:

- **First fit** — first hole big enough. Fast.
- **Best fit** — smallest hole that fits. Minimizes leftover, but leaves many tiny unusable holes.
- **Worst fit** — largest hole. Leaves big usable leftovers (usually performs poorly in practice).

7.4 Fragmentation and Compaction

	Internal Fragmentation	External Fragmentation
What	Wasted space inside an allocated block (allocated but unused)	Free memory exists but is split into scattered small holes, none big enough
Cause	Fixed-size allocation larger than needed	Variable allocation over time
Example	Process needs 18 KB, gets a 20 KB partition → 2 KB wasted	3 free holes of 10 KB each, but a 25 KB process can't use them
Cure	Smaller/variable partitions; paging	Compaction; paging

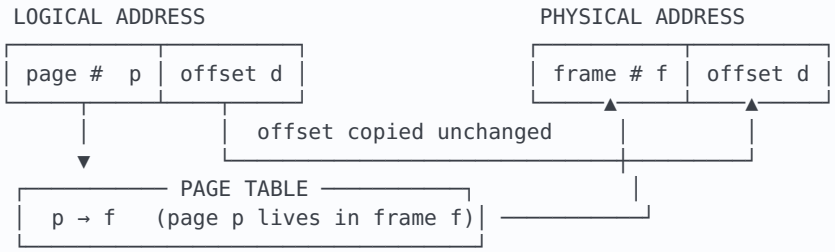
Compaction shuffles processes together to merge scattered holes into one big free block. It works only with execution-time binding (addresses can change), and it's expensive (lots of copying). The real cure for external fragmentation is **paging**, which drops the "contiguous" requirement entirely.

> ⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**
>
> Swapping the two fragmentations. Mnemonic: **In**ternal = wasted space **in**side a block you were given. **Ex**ternal = usable space **ex**iled into scattered holes **ex**ternal to any allocation. Paging eliminates external fragmentation but introduces a little internal fragmentation (the last partial page).

7.5 Paging

The big idea. Stop requiring memory to be contiguous. Chop the process's virtual address space into fixed-size **pages** and physical memory into equal-size **frames** (a page and a frame are the same size, typically 4 KB). Any page can go in any free frame; a per-process **page table** records which frame holds each page. External fragmentation vanishes because any frame fits any page.

> ▣ **KEY CONCEPT — HOW AN ADDRESS IS SPLIT**
>
> A logical address is divided into two parts: a **page number** (high bits) and an **offset** (low bits) within the page. The page table maps the page number → a frame number; the offset is copied unchanged. With page size 2^k, the low **k** bits are the offset.
>
> physical address = frame_number × page_size + offset



Paged address translation: the page number indexes the page table to get a frame number; the offset passes through.

Worked example. Page size = 4 KB = 2^{12} bytes (so offset = 12 bits). Consider logical address **8196**:

- page number = 8196 ÷ 4096 = **2**; offset = 8196 mod 4096 = **4**.
- Suppose the page table says page 2 → frame **8**.
- physical address = 8 × 4096 + 4 = **32772**.

> ⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**
>
> Thinking paging needs no translation cost. Naive paging doubles memory latency: one access to read the page table (in RAM) plus one to reach the actual data. That's exactly the problem the TLB solves.

7.6 The TLB (Translation Lookaside Buffer)

What & why. Since the page table lives in RAM, every memory reference would need an extra RAM access just to translate — halving performance. The **TLB** is a small, very fast associative cache inside the MMU that remembers the most recent page→frame translations.

- **TLB hit** — translation found in the TLB; frame number returned in ~1 cycle. Fast path.
- **TLB miss** — not cached; the MMU walks the page table in RAM (slow), then loads the result into the TLB for next time.

$$\text{Effective Access Time} = P_{\text{hit}}(\text{TLB} + \text{mem}) + P_{\text{miss}}(\text{TLB} + 2\times\text{mem})$$

Numerical: TLB access 10 ns, memory access 100 ns, hit ratio 90%. EAT = 0.9×(10+100) + 0.1×(10+200) = 99 + 21 = **120 ns** — versus 200 ns with no TLB. Real TLB hit rates exceed 99%, thanks to **locality** (Part VIII).

> ▣ **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> The TLB is why paging is practical. It exploits **locality of reference**: programs keep touching the same few pages, so a tiny cache of recent translations catches almost every access. On a context switch the TLB may be flushed (translations belong to the old process's page table) — one of the hidden costs of switching processes.

7.7 Multi-Level and Inverted Page Tables

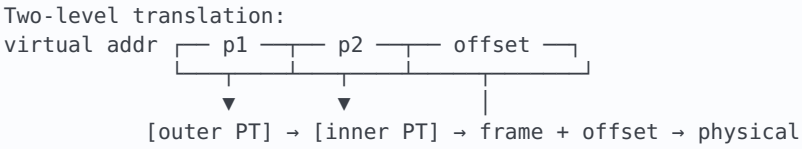
The problem: a single flat page table for a 32-bit address space with 4 KB pages needs $2^{20} \approx 1$ million entries per process — megabytes of table, mostly unused. Two solutions:

Multi-level (hierarchical) page tables

Page the page table itself. An outer table points to inner tables, which point to frames. Unused regions simply have no inner table, saving space. x86-64 uses **four levels**. Cost: a TLB miss now walks several levels (more memory accesses) — mitigated by the TLB.

Inverted page table

One table for the whole system, with one entry per physical frame (not per virtual page). Saves enormous space, but looking up "which frame holds page p of process X" requires searching — so it's paired with a hash table.



A hierarchical page table: the outer table indexes inner tables; empty regions cost nothing.

7.8 Segmentation

What. Instead of fixed-size pages, divide a program by its logical parts — **segments** like code, data, stack, heap — each a variable-length unit meaningful to the programmer. A logical address is <segment number, offset>; a **segment table** stores each segment's base and limit. This matches how programmers think and eases protection/sharing per segment (e.g. code read-only, shared between processes).

Downside: variable-size segments bring back **external fragmentation** (like variable partitioning). Pure segmentation is largely historical; modern systems use paging, sometimes **segmentation with paging** (segments divided into pages) to get both worlds.

7.9 Paging vs Segmentation

Aspect	Paging	Segmentation
Unit	Fixed-size page	Variable-size logical segment
Divided by	Hardware, arbitrary boundaries	Programmer's logical structure
Address	(page #, offset)	(segment #, offset)
Fragmentation	Internal (last page)	External (variable holes)
Table	Page table	Segment table (base + limit)
Visible to programmer?	No (transparent)	Yes (logical units)
Sharing/protection	Per page	Per segment (natural)

✓ Check Your Understanding — Part VII

CONCEPTUAL

1. Distinguish logical, physical, and virtual addresses, and say what the MMU does.
2. Contrast internal and external fragmentation, with the "in/ex" mnemonic.
3. How does paging eliminate external fragmentation? What does it introduce instead?
4. Why does naive paging halve memory performance, and how does the TLB fix it?
5. Why are multi-level page tables more space-efficient than a flat one?

APPLICATION

1. Page size 1 KB. Translate logical address 3500 given page 3 → frame 7. (Find page #, offset, physical address.)
2. TLB access 20 ns, memory 100 ns, hit ratio 80%. Compute the effective access time.
3. A 32-bit address space with 4 KB pages: how many entries in a single-level page table? Why is that a problem?

INTERVIEW-LEVEL

1. "Walk me through translating a virtual address to physical, including a TLB miss."
2. "Why do modern CPUs use paging instead of segmentation?"

CAN YOU EXPLAIN THIS? (NO NOTES)

Logical→physical translation via page table · page/offset splitting math · the role and payoff of the TLB · internal vs external fragmentation.

⚑ PRACTICAL TASK

On Linux, run `getconf PAGE_SIZE` (usually 4096). Then `cat /proc/self/maps` to see your shell's virtual memory regions — code, heap, stack, shared libraries — each an address range with permissions. You're looking at a real process's virtual address space.

Mastered when... given a page size and page table you can translate any logical address to physical by hand, compute effective access time with a TLB, and explain why paging beats contiguous allocation.

PART VIII

Virtual Memory

Your programs routinely use more memory than your machine physically has, and it just works. Virtual memory is the illusion — backed by the disk, demand paging, and page replacement — that lets a 16 GB machine run 40 GB of programs.

In this part: What & why virtual memory · Demand paging · Page faults & their handling · Page replacement: FIFO, LRU, Optimal, Clock · Belady's anomaly · Thrashing · Working set & locality · Copy-on-write · Memory-mapped files · Solved page-replacement numericals

PART VIII

Virtual Memory

Paging (Part VII) let a process's memory be scattered across frames. Virtual memory takes the next leap: a page need not be in RAM at all. Keep only the pages a process is actively using in memory and park the rest on disk, and suddenly the machine can run far more than fits.

8.1 What Is Virtual Memory, and Why?

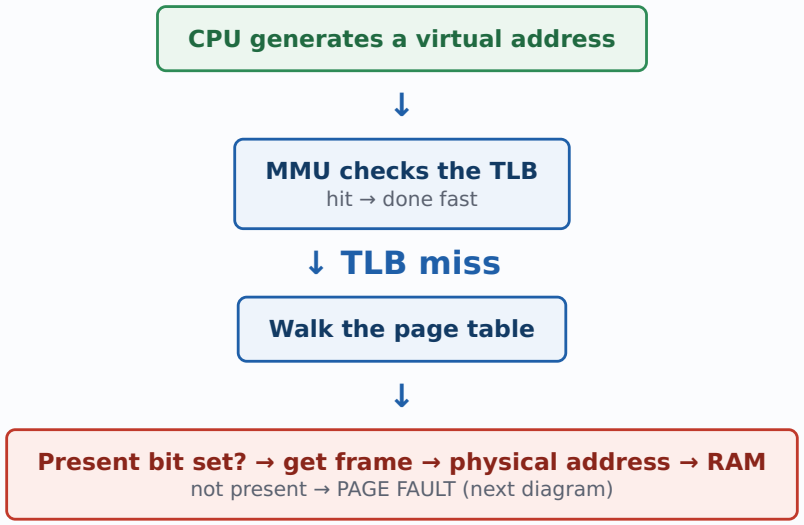
What is it? **Virtual memory** is a technique that lets a process execute even when only part of it is in physical RAM; the rest lives on disk (in the swap area or the program file) and is brought in on demand. Each process gets a large virtual address space independent of how much RAM exists.

Why? (1) Programs can be larger than physical memory. (2) More processes fit in RAM at once (only their active pages are resident), raising CPU utilization and multiprogramming. (3) Less I/O to load a program — start running before it's fully loaded. (4) It cleanly enables per-process isolation and features like copy-on-write and memory-mapped files.

> ▣ **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> Virtual memory works because programs exhibit **locality of reference**: at any moment a process touches only a small subset of its pages (its working set). Keep that hot subset in RAM and almost every access is a fast hit; the cold majority can sit on disk unnoticed.

8.2 Demand Paging

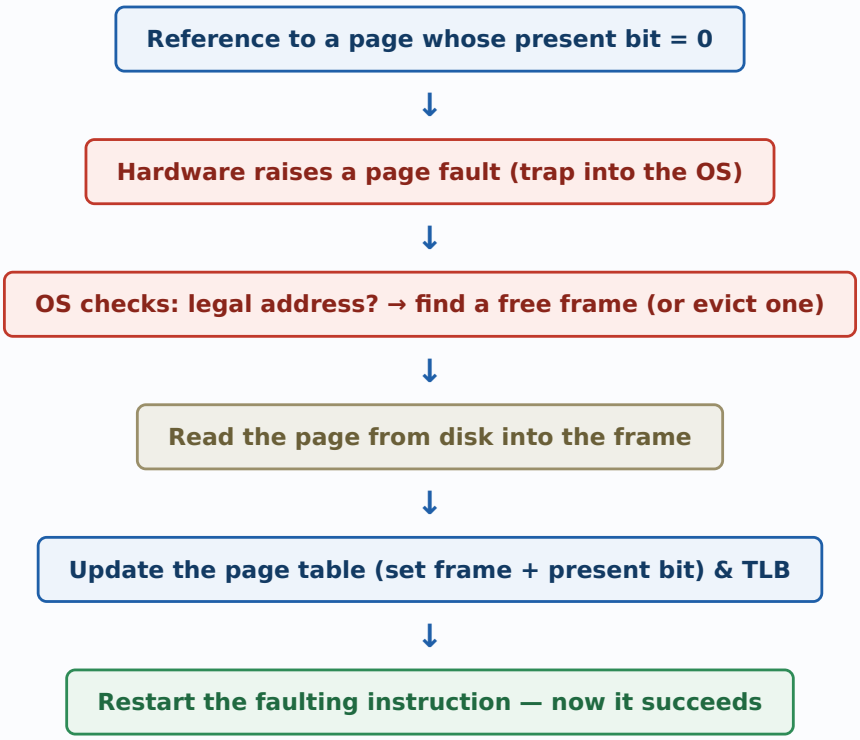
Demand paging is the usual implementation: don't load a page until it's actually referenced ("load on demand"). Each page-table entry has a **valid/invalid (present) bit**. When a page is in RAM the bit says "valid" and translation proceeds normally. When the page is on disk the bit says "invalid," and touching it triggers a **page fault**.



Address translation with virtual memory: TLB → page table → physical address, or a page fault.

8.3 Page Faults and Their Handling

A **page fault** is the exception raised when a process references a page that is not currently in RAM. It is not an error — it's the normal signal that the OS must fetch the page. Handling it:



Page-fault handling. The instruction that faulted is re-executed after the page is loaded.

Cost. A page fault is enormously expensive — a disk read is ~10^5–10^6× slower than a RAM access. So the **effective access time** is dominated by the fault rate:

$$\text{EAT} = (1 - p) \times \text{memory_access} + p \times \text{page_fault_time}$$

With memory access 100 ns and a page fault costing 8 ms (8,000,000 ns), even a fault probability of p = 0.001 gives EAT ≈ 100 + 0.001×8,000,000 = **8100 ns** — 81× slower. This is why keeping the fault rate tiny (via good replacement and enough RAM) is everything.

8.4 Page Replacement Algorithms

When a page fault occurs and no frame is free, the OS must **evict** a resident page to make room. Which one? A good choice minimizes future faults. We measure algorithms by counting page faults on a **reference string** (the sequence of page numbers a process touches).

Shared example. Reference string `1 2 3 4 1 2 5 1 2 3 4 5`, 3 frames.

FIFO — First-In, First-Out

Evict the page that has been in memory longest (oldest arrival). Simple; uses a queue. But "oldest" isn't "least useful," so it can evict a hot page.

Ref	1	2	3	4	1	2	5	1	2	3	4	5
Frame 1	1	1	1	4	4	4	5	5	5	5	5	5
Frame 2	·	2	2	2	1	1	1	1	1	3	3	3
Frame 3	·	·	3	3	3	2	2	2	2	2	4	4
Fault?	F	F	F	F	F	F	F	·	·	F	F	·

FIFO: **9 page faults** (3 hits)

Optimal (OPT / MIN)

Evict the page that will not be used for the longest time in the future. Provably the best possible — the fewest faults of any algorithm. It's unimplementable (needs the future), but it's the gold standard we compare against. On the same string, OPT gives **7 faults**.

LRU — Least Recently Used

Evict the page not used for the longest time in the past. A practical approximation of Optimal, banking on locality (the recent past predicts the near future). Costly to implement exactly (needs a timestamp or ordering per access). On the same string, LRU gives **10 faults** here.

Clock (Second-Chance)

A cheap LRU approximation used in real kernels. Frames sit in a circular list; each has a **reference bit** set on use. A "clock hand" sweeps: if the bit is 1, clear it and give the page a "second chance" (skip it); if 0, evict it. It approximates LRU with just one bit and no per-access bookkeeping.

> ▣ **KEY CONCEPT — BELADY'S ANOMALY**
>
> Intuitively, more frames should mean fewer faults. For **FIFO**, that can fail: on the string 1 2 3 4 1 2 5 1 2 3 4 5, FIFO gives **9 faults with 3 frames** but **10 faults with 4 frames** — more memory, more faults! This is **Belady's anomaly**. It afflicts FIFO but never **stack algorithms** like LRU and Optimal (which guarantee the set of pages with k frames is always a subset of the set with k+1 frames).

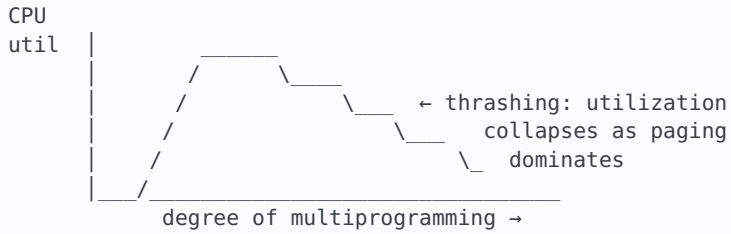
Algorithm (3 frames)	Page faults	Note
Optimal	7	Theoretical best
FIFO	9	Suffers Belady's anomaly
LRU	10	Approximates Optimal; no anomaly
FIFO (4 frames)	10	More frames, more faults!

8.5 Thrashing, Working Set, and Locality

Locality of reference is the empirical fact that processes access a small, slowly-changing set of pages at a time (loops reuse the same code; arrays are walked in order). Two flavors: **temporal** (a byte used now is likely used again soon) and **spatial** (nearby bytes are likely used soon). Locality is why caches and virtual memory work at all.

The **working set** of a process is the set of pages it has referenced in the recent time window — essentially its current locality. If RAM can hold every process's working set, fault rates stay low. If it can't…

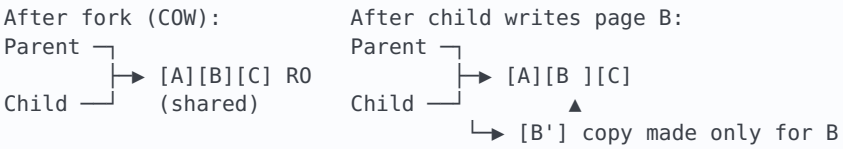
> ▣ **KEY CONCEPT — THRASHING**
>
> **Thrashing** is when a system spends more time paging (swapping pages in and out) than executing. It happens when the combined working sets exceed physical memory: every process constantly faults, evicting a page another process needs immediately, which faults again. CPU utilization collapses even though the CPU looks "busy" — busy doing I/O for paging. The fixes: reduce the multiprogramming level (run fewer processes), add RAM, or use the **working-set model**/page-fault-frequency control to give each process enough frames.



Add processes and CPU utilization rises — until working sets no longer fit and thrashing crashes it.

8.6 Copy-on-Write (COW)

What & why. Recall `fork()` (Part II) logically copies the parent's entire address space — wasteful, since the child often calls `exec()` immediately and discards it. **Copy-on-write** avoids the copy: parent and child share the same physical pages, marked read-only. As long as both only read, they share. The instant either writes a shared page, the MMU traps, and the OS makes a private copy of just that one page for the writer. Copying is deferred until (and only for pages) actually modified.



COW shares pages until a write forces a per-page copy — making *`fork()`* fast and lazy.

COW makes `fork()` nearly free and is used well beyond it — e.g. loading the same shared library into many processes without duplicating it in RAM.

8.7 Memory-Mapped Files

What. Instead of `read()`/`write()` system calls, a process can `mmap()` a file directly into its virtual address space, so the file appears as an array in memory. Accessing address `ptr[i]` reads byte `i` of the file; the OS demand-pages file contents in as you touch them and writes dirty pages back. **Why:** it avoids explicit I/O calls and extra copying, and it lets multiple processes share the same file pages in memory (the basis of shared memory IPC — Part XI, and of how executables/libraries load).

✓ Check Your Understanding — Part VIII

CONCEPTUAL

1. What is virtual memory and which property of programs makes it effective?
2. Describe the full sequence of events in handling a page fault.
3. Why is a page fault so much more expensive than a normal memory access?
4. What is Belady's anomaly, and which algorithms are immune to it?
5. Define thrashing and explain the working-set model's cure.

APPLICATION (SOLVE FULLY)

1. Reference string `7 0 1 2 0 3 0 4 2 3 0 3 2`, 3 frames: count page faults under FIFO, LRU, and Optimal.
2. Memory access 100 ns, page-fault service 5 ms, fault rate 0.0005. Compute the effective access time.
3. Explain, step by step, how copy-on-write handles `fork()` followed by the child writing one global variable.

INTERVIEW-LEVEL

1. "What happens, in hardware and software, on a page fault?"
2. "Your server's throughput suddenly collapses and disk I/O spikes. What's likely happening and how do you fix it?" (Thrashing.)

CAN YOU EXPLAIN THIS? (NO NOTES)

The page-fault handling flow · FIFO vs LRU vs Optimal (and Belady) · thrashing and the working set · how copy-on-write makes `fork()` cheap.

⚑ PRACTICAL TASK

On Linux run `vmstat 1` and watch the `si` / `so` (swap-in/swap-out) columns while opening many heavy apps. Nonzero, sustained values there are thrashing in action. Also try `/usr/bin/time -v ./yourprog` and read "Major (requiring I/O) page faults."

Mastered when... you can trace any reference string through FIFO/LRU/Optimal counting faults, explain and reproduce Belady's anomaly, and diagnose thrashing from system metrics.

PART IX

File Systems

A disk stores numbered blocks; you think in files and folders. The file system is the translation between the two — the abstraction that gives bytes names, directories, permissions, and the promise that your data survives a power cut.

In this part: Files & attributes · File operations · Directories · File descriptors · Inodes · Allocation: contiguous, linked, indexed · Free-space management · Hard vs soft links · Permissions · Mounting · Journaling & consistency · `open` / `read` / `write` / `close`

PART IX

File Systems

The file is the OS's most successful abstraction — so natural you forget it's an illusion. Underneath, the file system maps names to inodes, inodes to disk blocks, and turns a raw array of sectors into the durable, named, permissioned storage every program relies on.

9.1 Files and Their Attributes

A **file** is a named collection of related information stored on secondary storage — the logical unit the OS presents to users. To the OS a file is just a sequence of bytes (in UNIX; other systems impose record structure). Each file carries **metadata** — its attributes:

- **Name** — human-readable identifier (in the directory, not the inode).
- **Type** — regular file, directory, symlink, device, etc.
- **Size**, **location** (which disk blocks), **timestamps** (created, modified, accessed).
- **Owner & permissions** — who may read/write/execute.

File Operations (and the system calls behind them)

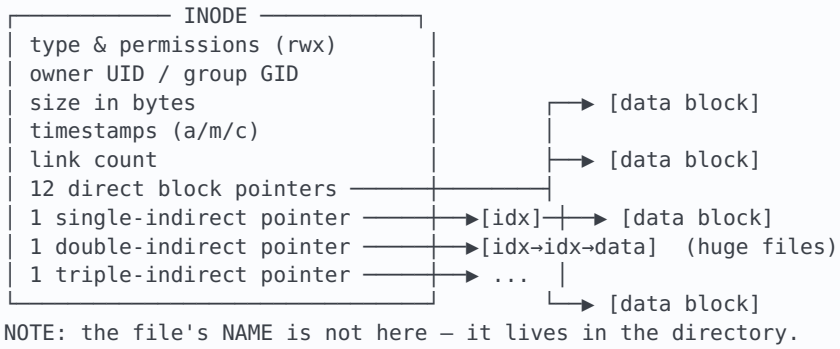
The OS exposes files through a small set of operations, each backed by a system call: `create`, `open`, `read`, `write`, `seek` (move the read/write position), `close`, `delete` (`unlink`). We trace `open`…`close` in detail in §9.7.

9.2 Directories

A **directory** (folder) is itself a special file whose contents are a table mapping **names → inode numbers**. That's the crucial insight: a directory doesn't "contain" files — it contains names that point to inodes. This is exactly why one file can have several names (hard links, §9.6). Directories nest to form the familiar tree, rooted at `/` on UNIX.

9.3 Inodes — the Heart of a UNIX File System

What is it? An **inode** (index node) is the on-disk data structure that stores everything about a file except its name and its data: the file's metadata plus pointers to the disk blocks holding its contents. Every file has exactly one inode, identified by an **inode number**.



A UNIX inode: metadata plus direct and multi-level indirect block pointers. Small files use direct pointers; large files chain through indirect blocks.

▣ KEY CONCEPT

Name and content are decoupled: the **directory** holds the name→inode mapping; the **inode** holds metadata + block pointers; the **data blocks** hold the bytes. This three-way split explains hard links (many names, one inode), why renaming a file is instant (just edit a directory entry), and why "deleting" a file really means dropping a directory entry and decrementing the inode's link count.

9.4 File Allocation Methods

How are a file's data blocks arranged on disk? Three classic strategies, each a trade-off between sequential-access speed, random-access speed, and fragmentation.

Method	How	+ Pros	− Cons
Contiguous	File occupies consecutive blocks; store start + length	Fast sequential & random access; simple	External fragmentation; hard to grow a file
Linked	Each block stores a pointer to the next (a linked list on disk)	No external fragmentation; files grow easily	No random access (must walk); pointer overhead; a bad pointer loses the rest
Indexed	An index block holds all the file's block pointers	Fast random access; no external fragmentation	Index block overhead for small files; max size limited by index size

The inode scheme (§9.3) is **indexed allocation** made scalable: a few direct pointers for small files, plus single/double/triple indirect blocks so a small inode can still address a very large file. This is why UNIX file systems handle both tiny and huge files efficiently.

9.5 Free-Space Management

The FS must track which blocks are free. Two common methods:

- **Bitmap (bit vector)** — one bit per block: 1 = free, 0 = used. Easy to find contiguous runs; compact. Used widely.
- **Free list** — link all free blocks together. Space-efficient but slow to find contiguous space.

9.6 Hard Links vs Symbolic (Soft) Links

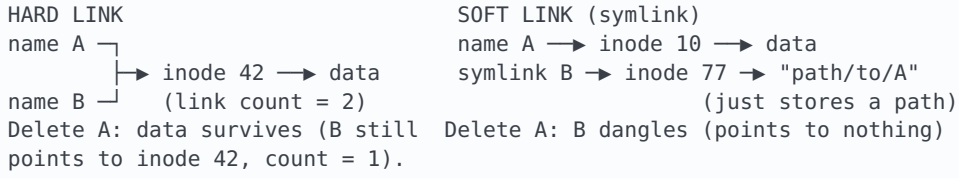
Both give a file more than one name, but very differently — a classic interview distinction.

Hard link

A directory entry pointing to the same inode as the original. The file has two equal names; there's no "original." The inode's **link count** tracks how many names point to it; the data is freed only when the count hits 0. Cannot span file systems (inode numbers are per-FS) and cannot link directories.

Symbolic (soft) link

A tiny special file whose contents are a path to another file — a pointer by name. Like a shortcut. Can cross file systems and link directories, but breaks if the target is moved or deleted (a "dangling" link).



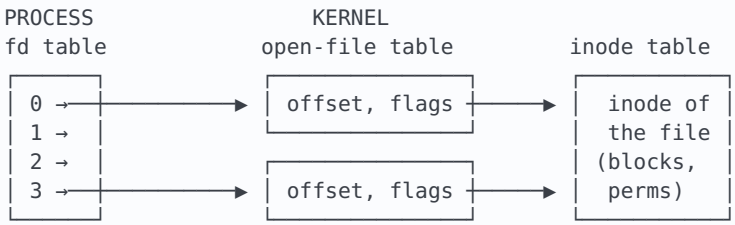
A hard link is a second name for the same inode; a symlink is a file containing a path.

	Hard Link	Soft Link
Points to	The inode (same file)	A pathname (a name)
Own inode?	No — shares the target's	Yes — its own tiny inode
Cross file systems?	No	Yes
Link to a directory?	No	Yes
If target deleted	Data survives (count > 0)	Link dangles (broken)
Create with	`ln A B`	`ln -s A B`

9.7 The Life of open / read / write / close

This is where files and the kernel meet, and it's a favorite "explain what happens" question. Three kernel tables cooperate:

1. **Per-process file descriptor table** — small integer FDs (0=stdin, 1=stdout, 2=stderr, then 3,4…) map to entries in…
2. **System-wide open-file table** — one entry per `open()`, holding the current file **offset** and mode, pointing to…
3. **In-memory inode table** — the actual file (metadata + block pointers).



fd → open-file entry (offset) → inode. Two opens of one file share the inode but have separate offsets.

READING A FILE WITH RAW SYSTEM CALLS

```c
int fd = open("data.txt", O_RDONLY);   // returns smallest free fd, e.g. 3
char buf[256];
ssize_t n = read(fd, buf, sizeof buf);  // copy up to 256 bytes; advance offset by n
// ... use buf ...
close(fd);                              // release the fd and open-file entry
```

What the kernel does on `open`: resolve the path (walk directories to find the inode), check permissions, allocate an open-file-table entry (offset 0), install a descriptor in the process's fd table, and return that integer. `read` uses the offset to find the right blocks (via the inode), copies data from the buffer cache (loading from disk on a miss), and advances the offset. `close` tears down the descriptor.

9.8 Mounting, Journaling, and Consistency

Mounting

Attaching a file system (on a disk/partition/USB) into the existing directory tree at a **mount point** (a directory). After `mount /dev/sdb1 /mnt`, the device's files appear under `/mnt`. This is how UNIX unifies many devices into one tree with no drive letters.

File-system consistency

A crash mid-update can leave the FS inconsistent (e.g. a block marked used in the inode but free in the bitmap). Old systems ran a slow full scan (`fsck`) to repair after a crash.

Journaling

The modern fix. Before modifying the FS, write the intended changes to a **journal** (log); then apply them. After a crash, the OS just **replays** (or discards) the journal — fast and safe, no full scan. ext4, NTFS, and XFS are journaling file systems.

> ▣ **KEY CONCEPT — WHY JOURNALING WORKS**
>
> The danger is a crash between two related updates leaving the FS half-changed. Journaling makes the multi-step update **atomic-ish**: either the journal entry is complete (and gets replayed) or it isn't (and gets ignored), so the FS is never left in a torn state. It's the same write-ahead-log idea databases use for durability.

Linux File System Basics

Everything in UNIX is a file — regular files, directories, devices (`/dev/sda`), even kernel state (`/proc`, `/sys` — Part XIV). The **Virtual File System (VFS)** is a kernel abstraction layer so the same `open`/`read`/`write` calls work across ext4, FAT, NFS, etc. File permissions use three classes (owner, group, other) × three rights (read, write, execute), shown as `rwxr-xr--` and set with `chmod` (Part XIV).

✓ Check Your Understanding — Part IX

CONCEPTUAL

1. What does an inode store, and what does it deliberately not store?
2. How does a directory actually map names to files?
3. Compare contiguous, linked, and indexed allocation on random access and fragmentation.
4. Explain the three-table path from a file descriptor to the file's data.
5. Why does journaling make a file system crash-safe?

APPLICATION

1. You create a hard link `B` to file `A`, then `rm A`. Can you still read the data via `B`? What is the inode's link count now? What if `B` had been a symlink instead?
2. Two processes both `open()` the same file and read. Do they share a read offset? Why or why not?
3. Why can't a hard link cross file systems, while a symlink can?

INTERVIEW-LEVEL

1. "Walk me through exactly what the kernel does from `open("f")` to `read()` returning bytes."
2. "How does the inode structure let a small inode address a multi-gigabyte file?"

CAN YOU EXPLAIN THIS? (NO NOTES)

Inode vs directory vs data block · hard vs soft link · the fd → open-file → inode table chain · why journaling prevents corruption.

⚑ PRACTICAL TASK

Run `echo hi > a.txt; ln a.txt b.txt; ln -s a.txt c.txt; ls -li`. Compare the inode numbers (first column): `a` and `b` share one; `c` has its own. Note the link count. Now `rm a.txt` and try `cat b.txt` (works) vs `cat c.txt` (broken symlink). You've just seen the inode model directly.

Mastered when... you can explain the full name→inode→ block path, predict link-count and dangling-link behavior, and trace an `open/read/close` through the kernel's three tables.

PART X

I/O Systems

The CPU runs in nanoseconds; disks and networks in milliseconds. Bridging that million-fold gap without wasting the CPU is the whole art of I/O — and the reason interrupts and DMA exist.

In this part: I/O devices · Device controllers & drivers · Polling · Interrupt-driven I/O · DMA · Buffering · Caching · Spooling · Blocking vs non-blocking · Synchronous vs asynchronous I/O

PART X

I/O Systems

Computers are only useful because they talk to the outside world — disks, keyboards, screens, networks. But those devices are glacially slow next to the CPU. This part is about the three techniques the OS uses to move data to and from devices without letting the CPU sit idle waiting.

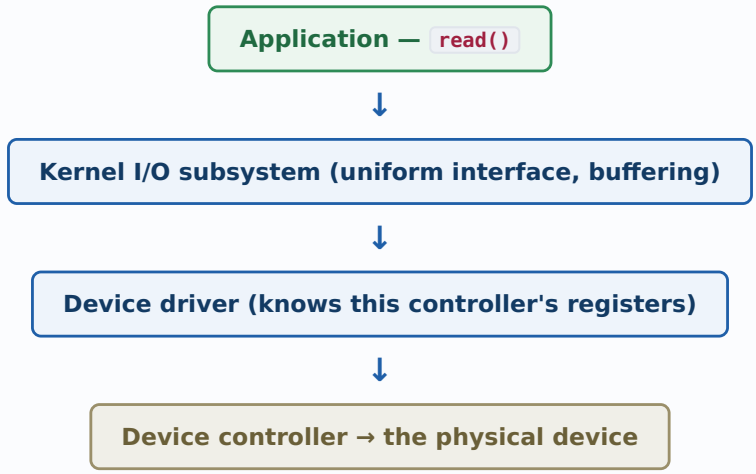
10.1 Devices, Controllers, and Drivers

Three layers separate your program from the physical hardware:

Device
: The physical hardware — disk, NIC, keyboard.

Device controller
: The electronics that operate the device, exposing a set of **registers** (data, status, command) the CPU reads/writes to control it.

Device driver
: Kernel software that knows a specific controller's registers and presents a uniform interface (`read`/`write`/`ioctl`) to the rest of the OS. The driver is how the OS stays device-independent: swap the disk, swap the driver, everything above is unchanged.



The I/O stack. Each layer hides the one below; only the driver knows hardware specifics.

Talking to controller registers happens two ways: **port-mapped I/O** (special `in`/`out` instructions and a separate I/O address space) or, more common today, **memory-mapped I/O** (device registers appear as ordinary memory addresses, so normal loads/stores control the device).

10.2 Three Ways to Do I/O

The central question: when a program requests slow I/O, what does the CPU do while the device works? The three answers are a progression from wasteful to efficient.

1. Polling (Programmed I/O) — Busy Waiting

The CPU repeatedly reads the controller's status register in a loop ("Are you done yet? Are you done yet?") until the device is ready, then transfers a word, and repeats. **Simple**, but the CPU burns 100% of its time spinning and transferring every byte itself. Fine only for very fast devices or the simplest systems.

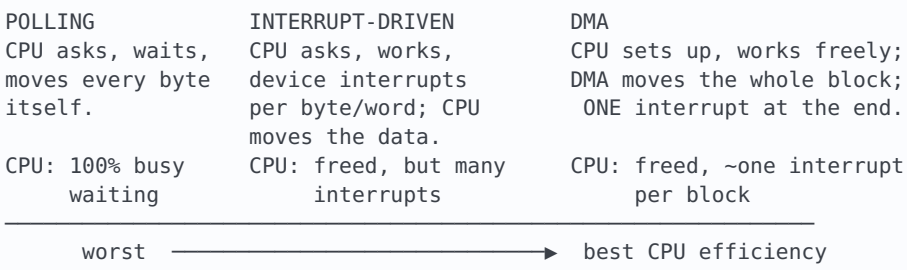
2. Interrupt-Driven I/O

The CPU issues the I/O request and then goes off to do other work. When the device finishes, its controller raises an **interrupt** (Part I); the CPU stops, runs the driver's interrupt handler to transfer the data, then resumes what it was doing. **The CPU no longer waits** — it's interrupted only when there's actually something to do.

The remaining cost: one interrupt per data unit. For a disk block of thousands of bytes transferred a word at a time, that's still a lot of CPU involvement.

3. Direct Memory Access (DMA)

A dedicated **DMA controller** transfers a whole block directly between the device and RAM, without the CPU moving each byte. The CPU sets up the transfer (source, destination, count) and then is completely free; the DMA controller does the bulk move and raises a **single interrupt** when the entire block is done.



From polling to DMA: each step removes CPU work. DMA lets the CPU ignore the transfer entirely until it completes.

> ▣ **KEY CONCEPT — HOW INTERRUPTS AND DMA IMPROVE PERFORMANCE**
>
> **Interrupts** free the CPU from waiting (no busy-poll) — it does useful work and is notified only when the device is ready. **DMA** additionally frees the CPU from doing the transfer — hardware moves the bulk data straight to RAM, and the CPU handles just one interrupt per block instead of one per word. Together they turn slow I/O from a CPU-monopolizing chore into a background activity. This is why your machine stays responsive while copying a large file.

> ⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**
>
> Thinking DMA eliminates interrupts. It doesn't — it eliminates the CPU copying bytes and reduces interrupts to roughly **one per block** (the "transfer complete" signal), instead of one per word. The CPU still gets that final interrupt to know the data has arrived.

10.3 Buffering, Caching, and Spooling

Three techniques the kernel's I/O subsystem uses to smooth the speed mismatch and improve throughput. Don't confuse them:

Technique	What it does	Why
Buffering	Temporarily holds data in memory between producer and consumer (device and app)	Handles speed mismatch, allows different transfer sizes, and lets I/O and computation overlap
Caching	Keeps copies of recently/frequently used data in fast memory	Avoids re-reading from slow storage (e.g. the page/buffer cache serves repeated file reads from RAM)
Spooling	Queues whole jobs to a buffer (usually disk) for a device that can't interleave requests	Serializes access to a device like a printer; lets many jobs be submitted and printed in turn

> ⚑ **INTERVIEW TIP**
>
> "Buffering vs caching?" A **buffer** holds data in transit (the only copy, moving from A to B); a **cache** holds a duplicate of data that lives elsewhere, to serve future requests faster. A buffer smooths a transfer; a cache avoids a repeat. Linux's page cache is a cache; the staging area a driver uses to assemble a disk block is a buffer.

10.4 Blocking, Non-Blocking, Synchronous, Asynchronous

These describe how an I/O call behaves from the program's point of view — endlessly muddled, so here they are precisely.

Blocking I/O

The call doesn't return until the I/O completes; the calling thread sleeps meanwhile. Simple to reason about; the default. (`read()` that waits for data.)

Non-blocking I/O

The call returns immediately — either with whatever data is ready now, or with "nothing available yet" (`EAGAIN`). The program must poll or retry. Useful for handling many connections in one thread.

Synchronous I/O

The program waits for the operation to finish (conceptually) before moving on — result is available when the call/notification completes.

Asynchronous I/O

The program issues the request and continues immediately; the OS performs the I/O in the background and notifies the program later (callback, signal, completion event). True "fire and forget, tell me when done."

> ▣ **KEY CONCEPT**
>
> **Blocking vs non-blocking** is about whether the call returns immediately. **Sync vs async** is about whether the work is done before you proceed. High-performance servers use non-blocking + event notification (`epoll`, `kqueue`) or full async (`io_uring`) to juggle thousands of connections with a handful of threads, instead of one blocked thread per connection (Part XIII).

✓ Check Your Understanding — Part X

CONCEPTUAL

1. Name the three I/O layers (device, controller, driver) and each one's job.
2. Contrast polling, interrupt-driven I/O, and DMA by CPU involvement.
3. Exactly how do interrupts and DMA each reduce CPU waste?
4. Distinguish buffering, caching, and spooling.
5. Separate "blocking vs non-blocking" from "synchronous vs asynchronous."

APPLICATION

1. A driver polls a disk for a 4 KB block one word at a time. Roughly how many status-register reads and data transfers does the CPU perform? How does DMA change that?
2. Why does copying a large file keep your desktop responsive on a modern OS but would freeze a pure-polling system?
3. Design the I/O model for a chat server handling 10,000 idle-mostly connections. Blocking-per-connection or non-blocking + event loop? Why?

INTERVIEW-LEVEL

1. "Why is DMA essential for high-throughput devices like SSDs and NICs?"
2. "What happens, hardware to software, when a disk read you requested finally completes?"

CAN YOU EXPLAIN THIS? (NO NOTES)

Polling vs interrupt vs DMA and their CPU cost · how DMA + interrupts free the CPU · buffering vs caching · blocking/non-blocking vs sync/async.

⚑ PRACTICAL TASK

On Linux, run `cat /proc/interrupts` to see interrupt counts per device (disk, NIC, timer). Copy a big file and re-check — watch the disk controller's interrupt count rise. Then read `iostat -x 1` during the copy to see throughput and device utilization (Part XIV).

Mastered when... you can explain, for any device, why the OS chooses interrupt-driven DMA over polling, and correctly classify an I/O call as blocking/non-blocking and sync/async.

PART XI

Inter-Process Communication

Processes are isolated by design (Part II). IPC is the set of controlled channels the OS provides so isolated processes can cooperate — pipe output into the next command, share a memory region, or signal each other.

In this part: Why IPC · Shared memory vs message passing · Pipes · Named pipes (FIFOs) · Message queues · Shared memory · Signals · Sockets · RPC basics · Comparison of every mechanism · C/POSIX examples

PART XI

Inter-Process Communication

A shell command like `ps aux | grep ssh` quietly relies on IPC: the output of one process becomes the input of another. This part covers every mechanism the OS gives isolated processes to exchange data — from the humble pipe to shared memory — with the trade-offs that decide which to use.

11.1 Why IPC? The Two Families

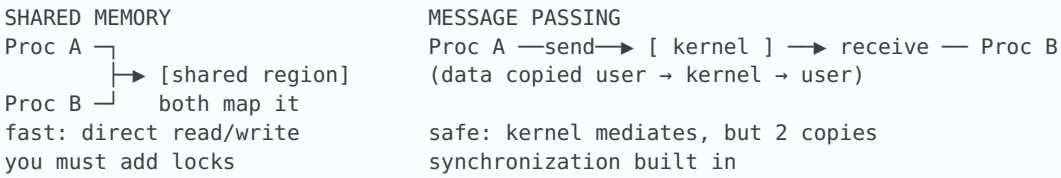
Because each process has a private address space, they cannot simply read each other's variables. IPC provides deliberate, kernel-mediated channels. Every mechanism belongs to one of two families:

Shared memory

Two processes map the same physical memory region into their address spaces; one writes, the other reads — directly. **Fastest** (no kernel copy after setup), but the processes must **synchronize** access themselves (Part V) to avoid races.

Message passing

Processes exchange discrete messages through the kernel (`send` / `receive`). **Simpler and safer** (the kernel handles synchronization and delivery), but slower — each message is copied through the kernel.



The two IPC families: shared memory (fast, you synchronize) vs message passing (safe, kernel copies).

11.2 Pipes and Named Pipes

Pipe. A one-way, in-memory byte stream with two ends: one process writes, another reads. An ordinary (anonymous) pipe is created with `pipe()` and shared with a child via `fork()` — which is exactly how the shell wires `cmd1 | cmd2`. It's a FIFO (first-in-first-out) stream; the kernel buffers it and blocks the writer if it's full or the reader if it's empty.

AN ANONYMOUS PIPE BETWEEN PARENT AND CHILD

```
int fd[2];                  // fd[0] = read end, fd[1] = write end
pipe(fd);
if (fork() == 0) {         // --- child: reader ---
    close(fd[1]);             // close unused write end
    char buf[64];
```

```
    int n = read(fd[0], buf, sizeof buf);
    write(1, buf, n);        // echo to stdout
} else {                  // --- parent: writer ---
    close(fd[0]);            // close unused read end
    write(fd[1], "hello from parent\n", 18);
    close(fd[1]);
}
```

Named pipe (FIFO). A pipe with a name in the file system (created with `mkfifo`), so unrelated processes (not just parent/child) can connect to it by opening the path. Otherwise it behaves like an anonymous pipe.

> ⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**
>
> Leaving both pipe ends open. If the writer never closes its end, the reader's `read()` never sees end-of-file and can hang forever. Always `close()` the ends you don't use in each process — the reader gets EOF only when all write ends are closed.

11.3 Message Queues

A **message queue** is a kernel-maintained linked list of discrete messages. Processes `send` typed/prioritized messages and `receive` them, and messages persist in the kernel until read (even if the sender exits). Unlike a pipe's raw byte stream, a queue preserves **message boundaries** and can support priorities. POSIX (`mq_open`) and older System V (`msgget`) variants exist.

11.4 Shared Memory

The fastest IPC. Both processes attach the same region; after that, communication is just reading and writing memory — no system call per exchange, no copying. The catch: **you** must coordinate access with semaphores or mutexes (Part V), or you'll get races.

POSIX SHARED MEMORY (CREATE, MAP, USE)

```
int fd = shm_open("/myshm", O_CREAT | O_RDWR, 0666);  // a named shm object
ftruncate(fd, 4096);                                   // size it to one page
char *mem = mmap(NULL, 4096, PROT_READ | PROT_WRITE,
                 MAP_SHARED, fd, 0);                   // map into address space

strcpy(mem, "written by process A");   // another process mapping /myshm sees this
// ... coordinate with a semaphore so B reads only after A writes ...
munmap(mem, 4096);                          // detach; shm_unlink("/myshm") to remove
```

11.5 Signals

A **signal** is a lightweight asynchronous notification — a "software interrupt" delivered to a process to tell it an event happened. Signals carry no data payload beyond their number; they interrupt the process, which runs a registered **signal handler** or takes the default action (often terminate). Examples: `SIGINT` (Ctrl-C), `SIGKILL` (force kill, uncatchable), `SIGSEGV` (bad memory access), `SIGCHLD` (a child changed state — used to reap zombies, Part II).

CATCHING CTRL-C WITH A SIGNAL HANDLER

```c
#include <signal.h>
#include <stdio.h>

void handler(int sig) {
    printf("\nCaught signal %d — cleaning up\n", sig);
    _exit(0);
}
int main(void) {
    signal(SIGINT, handler);   // run handler() instead of dying on Ctrl-C
    while (1) pause();          // sleep until a signal arrives
}
```

> ⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**
>
> Doing complex work in a signal handler. A handler can fire at any instant, so calling non-async-signal-safe functions (like `printf` or `malloc`) from it can deadlock or corrupt state. The safe pattern is to set a `volatile sig_atomic_t` flag in the handler and do the real work in the main loop.

11.6 Sockets

A **socket** is a bidirectional communication endpoint. Its superpower: the same API works for processes on the **same machine** (UNIX-domain sockets) and across a **network** (TCP/UDP sockets). Because they generalize to networking, sockets are the backbone of all client-server software — and they get their own treatment in **Part XIII**.

11.7 Remote Procedure Call (RPC)

RPC makes calling a function on a remote machine look like a local call. A client-side **stub** serializes ("marshals") the arguments into a message, sends it over the network, the server unmarshals and runs the real function, then returns the result the same way. It hides the network behind an ordinary function-call syntax — the foundation of distributed systems, gRPC, and microservices. (The catch: unlike a local call, an RPC can fail, time out, or run twice — distributed systems must plan for that.)

11.8 Comparing IPC Mechanisms

Mechanism	Direction	Speed	Related procs?	Best for
Pipe	One-way	Fast	Yes (parent/child)	Streaming output to a related process (shells)
Named pipe	One-way	Fast	No	Simple stream between unrelated processes
Message queue	Two-way	Medium	No	Discrete, prioritized messages; loose coupling
Shared memory	Two-way	**Fastest**	No	High-volume data (needs your own sync)
Signal	One-way (event)	Fast	No	Notifications/control, not data transfer
Socket	Two-way	Medium	No	Network or local client-server; portable

> ⚑ **INTERVIEW TIP**
>
> "Fastest IPC?" **Shared memory** — because after setup there's no kernel involvement and no copying; processes read/write memory directly. The trade-off you must mention: it provides no synchronization, so you pair it with semaphores/mutexes. Message passing is slower (data is copied through the kernel) but safer and simpler. Naming that trade-off is the whole answer.

✓ Check Your Understanding — Part XI

CONCEPTUAL

1. Contrast the shared-memory and message-passing families on speed and synchronization.
2. How does `cmd1 | cmd2` use pipes and `fork()`?
3. What does a named pipe add over an anonymous pipe?
4. Why is shared memory the fastest IPC, and what must you add to use it safely?
5. What is a signal, and why must signal handlers be minimal?

APPLICATION

1. Two unrelated processes on one machine must exchange 1 GB of data with lowest latency. Which IPC, and what extra primitive do you need?
2. Why might a pipe reader hang forever, and how do you prevent it?
3. Explain what marshaling is and one way an RPC can behave differently from a local call.

INTERVIEW-LEVEL

1. "Compare shared memory and message queues — when would you pick each?"
2. "How would you notify a running daemon to reload its config without restarting it?" (Hint: a signal.)

CAN YOU EXPLAIN THIS? (NO NOTES)

Shared memory vs message passing · how pipes wire shell commands · the fastest IPC and its catch · what a signal is and isn't.

⚑ PRACTICAL TASK

Run `mkfifo /tmp/myfifo`. In one terminal: `cat /tmp/myfifo` (it blocks, waiting). In another: `echo "hi over a FIFO" > /tmp/myfifo`. Watch the message appear in the first terminal — two unrelated processes just talked through a named pipe.

Mastered when... you can pick the right IPC mechanism for a given scenario and justify it on speed, direction, safety, and whether the processes are related.

PART XII

Storage Systems

Under the file system lies physical storage — spinning platters or flash chips — each with its own quirks. How the OS orders disk requests, and how RAID combines many disks into one fast or fault-tolerant volume, is the difference between a system that flies and one that crawls or loses data.

In this part: HDD vs SSD · Disk structure & access time · Disk scheduling: FCFS, SSTF, SCAN, C-SCAN, LOOK, C-LOOK · RAID 0, 1, 5, 6, 10 · Performance vs redundancy vs efficiency · Solved disk-scheduling numericals

PART XII

Storage Systems

Storage is where the millisecond world of mechanics meets the nanosecond world of the CPU. Because a disk seek is millions of times slower than a memory access, the order in which the OS serves disk requests matters enormously — and RAID is how we make many imperfect disks into one reliable, fast whole.

12.1 HDD vs SSD

A **Hard Disk Drive (HDD)** stores data magnetically on spinning **platters**. Data sits in concentric **tracks**, divided into **sectors**; the same track across stacked platters forms a **cylinder**. A moving **read/write head** on an arm must physically reach the data. So an HDD access has three time components:

> Access time = **seek time** (move head to track) + **rotational latency** (wait for sector to spin under head) + **transfer time**

Seek time dominates and is mechanical — which is exactly why request ordering (scheduling) can hugely reduce total head movement.

A **Solid-State Drive (SSD)** stores data in flash memory — no moving parts. Any block is reachable in roughly constant time, so there is **no seek or rotational latency**. SSDs are far faster (especially for random access), silent, and shock-resistant, but cost more per GB and have limited write-erase cycles (managed by **wear leveling**).

	HDD	SSD
Mechanism	Spinning magnetic platters + moving head	Flash memory, no moving parts
Random access	Slow (seek + rotation, ~ms)	Very fast (~µs), roughly uniform
Seek time	Yes — dominates latency	None
Durability	Fragile (moving parts)	Shock-resistant; limited write cycles
Cost / GB	Cheap	Higher
Scheduling matters?	**Yes** — reduce head movement	Less so (no seeks)

12.2 Disk Scheduling

When several I/O requests are queued for an HDD, the OS chooses the service order to minimize total head movement (and thus seek time). We evaluate algorithms by **total head movement** across a request queue.

▣ SHARED EXAMPLE FOR EVERY ALGORITHM

Request queue (cylinders): `98, 183, 37, 122, 14, 124, 65, 67`. Head starts at **53**; disk has cylinders 0–199; for directional algorithms the head is moving **toward higher numbers**.

FCFS — First-Come, First-Served

Serve requests in arrival order. Fair, but the head can whipsaw across the disk.

53→98→183→37→122→14→124→65→67. Movement = 45+85+146+85+108+110+59+2 = **640 cylinders**.

SSTF — Shortest Seek Time First

Always serve the closest request to the current head position. Greatly reduces movement, but can **starve** far-away requests (analogous to SJF).

53→65→67→37→14→98→122→124→183. Movement = 12+2+30+23+84+24+2+59 = **236 cylinders**.

SCAN — the Elevator Algorithm

The head sweeps in one direction serving all requests, reaches the **end of the disk**, then reverses. Like an elevator going all the way up, then all the way down. No starvation; fairer than SSTF.

Moving up: 53→65→67→98→122→124→183→**199** (end), then down →37→14. Movement = (199−53) + (199−14) = 146+185 = **331 cylinders**.

C-SCAN — Circular SCAN

Like SCAN, but after reaching the end it **jumps straight back to the start** (0) without servicing on the return, then sweeps up again. This gives more **uniform** wait times (every cylinder is treated the same way), avoiding SCAN's bias toward the middle.

Up: 53→…→183→199, jump to 0, then 0→14→37. Movement = (199−53) + (199) + (37) = 146+199+37 = **382 cylinders** (the 199 is the return sweep).

LOOK and C-LOOK

The practical versions of SCAN/C-SCAN: instead of going all the way to the physical end, the head only goes as far as the **last request** in that direction, then reverses (LOOK) or jumps back (C-LOOK). Saves the wasted travel to the disk edge.

LOOK: up to 183 (last request), then down to 14. Movement = (183−53) + (183−14) = 130+169 = **299**.
C-LOOK: up to 183, jump to 14, up to 37. Movement = 130 + 169 + 23 = **322**.

Algorithm	Head movement	Note
FCFS	640	Fair but inefficient
SSTF	236	Efficient; can starve
SCAN	331	Elevator; to the disk end
LOOK	299	SCAN without the edge trip
C-SCAN	382	Uniform waits
C-LOOK	322	C-SCAN without the edge trip

> ⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**
>
> Forgetting to state the initial **direction** and whether the algorithm goes to the physical end (SCAN/C-SCAN) or only to the last request (LOOK/C-LOOK). The same queue gives different totals depending on both. Always write down the head's starting position and direction before you begin.

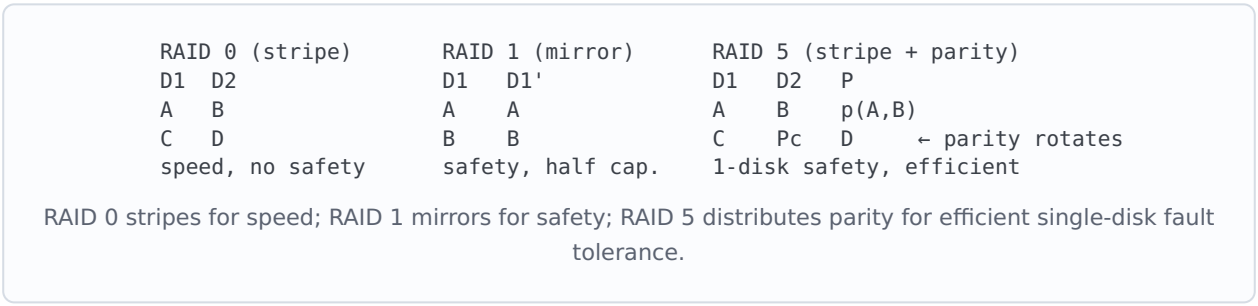
12.3 RAID — Redundant Array of Independent Disks

RAID combines multiple physical disks into one logical unit for **performance** (spread I/O across disks), **redundancy** (survive disk failures), or both. The two building blocks:

Striping
: Split data across disks so reads/writes happen in parallel → speed. No redundancy by itself.

Mirroring / Parity
: Store redundant information (a full copy, or parity bits) so a failed disk's data can be reconstructed → fault tolerance.

Level	Technique	Min disks	Fault tolerance	Usable capacity	Character
RAID 0	Striping, no redundancy	2	None	100%	Max speed & capacity, zero safety
RAID 1	Mirroring (full copy)	2	1 disk	50%	Simple redundancy, fast reads
RAID 5	Striping + distributed parity	3	1 disk	(N−1)/N	Good balance; write penalty (parity)
RAID 6	Striping + double parity	4	2 disks	(N−2)/N	Survives two failures; more write cost
RAID 10	Mirror then stripe (1+0)	4	1 per mirror	50%	Fast and redundant; expensive



RAID 0 stripes for speed; RAID 1 mirrors for safety; RAID 5 distributes parity for efficient single-disk fault tolerance.

▣ KEY CONCEPT — HOW PARITY RECOVERS DATA

RAID 5 stores **parity** = the XOR of the data blocks in a stripe. If one disk dies, its block is recomputed as the XOR of the survivors (X ⊕ parity = the missing block). That's why RAID 5 needs only one extra disk's worth of space to tolerate one failure. RAID 6 adds a second, independent parity so it can lose two disks. The cost is the **write penalty**: every write must also update parity (read-modify-write).

⚑ INTERVIEW TIP

"RAID 0 vs 1 vs 5 vs 10?" Compress it: **0 = speed, no safety**; **1 = safety via a full copy**; **5 = efficient safety via parity (survives 1)**; **6 = survives 2**; **10 = speed + safety, at 50% capacity**. And the trap: **RAID is not a backup** — it protects against disk failure, not against deletion, corruption, ransomware, or fire. You still need real backups.

✓ Check Your Understanding — Part XII

CONCEPTUAL

1. Name the three components of HDD access time and say which dominates.
2. Why does disk scheduling barely matter for SSDs?
3. How does SCAN differ from C-SCAN, and LOOK from SCAN?
4. Explain how RAID 5 parity reconstructs a failed disk.
5. Why is "RAID is not a backup" true?

APPLICATION (SOLVE FULLY)

1. Queue `82, 170, 43, 140, 24, 16, 190`, head at 50, moving up, disk 0–199. Compute total head movement for FCFS, SSTF, and C-LOOK.
2. You have 6 disks of 2 TB. Give the usable capacity and failure tolerance under RAID 0, 5, 6, and 10.
3. A database does mostly small random writes and must survive a disk failure. RAID 5 or RAID 10? Justify.

INTERVIEW-LEVEL

1. "Why does SSTF risk starvation, and how does SCAN avoid it?"
2. "Explain the RAID 5 write penalty and why RAID 10 avoids it."

CAN YOU EXPLAIN THIS? (NO NOTES)

HDD access-time components · SSTF vs SCAN vs C-SCAN vs LOOK · RAID 0/1/5/6/10 on speed, safety, and capacity · parity-based recovery.

⚑ PRACTICAL TASK

On Linux, run `lsblk` to list your storage devices and `cat /sys/block/sda/queue/scheduler` to see (and, as root, change) the kernel's active I/O scheduler (e.g. `mq-deadline`, `none` for SSDs). Note that SSDs often use `none` — confirming scheduling matters less without seeks.

Mastered when... given any request queue you can compute head movement for every disk-scheduling algorithm, and you can choose and justify a RAID level for a given performance/safety requirement.

PART XIII

Networking from an OS Perspective

To an application, sending data across the world looks like writing to a file descriptor. This part opens that abstraction: how a socket becomes a packet, how the kernel network stack and the NIC cooperate, and how servers handle a hundred thousand connections at once.

In this part: The network stack · Sockets & the socket API · Socket file descriptors · TCP vs UDP · Kernel networking · Interrupts & DMA in packet processing · Network buffers · Blocking vs non-blocking sockets · High-performance networking (`epoll`, C10K)

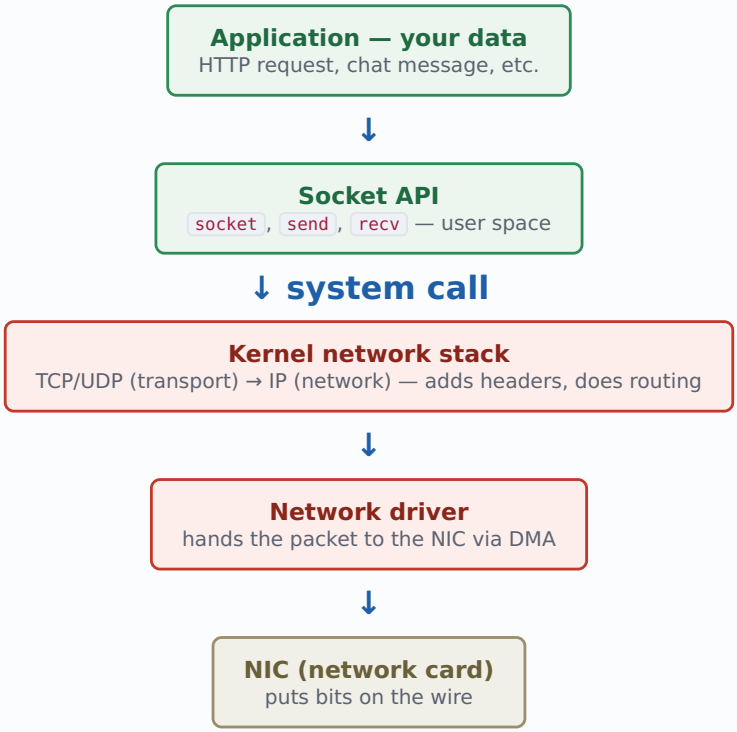
PART XIII

Networking from an OS Perspective

Networking is really just I/O to a very special, very slow device: the network. Everything you learned about system calls, interrupts, DMA, and buffering applies — the socket is the file descriptor, the NIC is the device, and the kernel's network stack is the driver's very elaborate cousin.

13.1 The Network Stack

Networking is built in layers, each adding a header and a job. From an OS standpoint the key point is where the boundary between your program and the kernel falls: your application lives at the top; the kernel implements the transport and network layers; the driver and NIC handle the link.



Sending a packet: data flows down the stack, gaining a TCP, then IP, then Ethernet header. Receiving reverses it.

▣ KEY CONCEPT — ENCAPSULATION

As data descends the stack, each layer wraps it in a header: your bytes become a **TCP segment** (ports, sequence numbers), then an **IP packet** (source/destination IP), then an **Ethernet frame** (MAC addresses). The receiver's stack strips them off in reverse. The OS owns the transport and network layers, which is why sending data requires crossing into the kernel.

13.2 Sockets and the Socket API

A **socket** is the OS's abstraction of a network endpoint — and, crucially, it is a **file descriptor**. Once connected, you `read()`/`write()` (or `recv`/`send`) a socket just like a file. This unification ("everything is a file descriptor") is why the same `select`/`epoll` machinery works for files, pipes, and network connections alike.

A MINIMAL TCP SERVER (THE CLASSIC FIVE CALLS)

```
int s = socket(AF_INET, SOCK_STREAM, 0);   // 1. create a TCP socket (an fd)
bind(s, (struct sockaddr*)&addr, sizeof addr); // 2. attach to a port
listen(s, 128);                            // 3. mark it passive; queue up to 128
pending
while (1) {
    int c = accept(s, NULL, NULL);          // 4. block until a client connects; new
fd
    char buf[1024];
    int n = recv(c, buf, sizeof buf, 0);     // read the client's request
    send(c, buf, n, 0);                     // echo it back
    close(c);                               // 5. done with this client
}
```

The client side is `socket()` then `connect()`, after which it `send`/`recv`s. Each `accept()` returns a new socket fd dedicated to one client, while the listening socket keeps accepting more.

13.3 TCP vs UDP

The two transport protocols the kernel offers through sockets embody a fundamental trade-off: reliability vs speed/overhead.

	TCP (SOCK_STREAM)	UDP (SOCK_DGRAM)
Connection	Connection-oriented (3-way handshake)	Connectionless (just send)
Reliability	Guaranteed, in-order, no duplicates	Best-effort; may lose/reorder
Flow/congestion control	Yes	No
Overhead / latency	Higher (ACKs, retransmits, state)	Lower — minimal
Data model	Byte stream (no message boundaries)	Discrete datagrams (boundaries kept)
Use for	Web, files, email, SSH — correctness matters	Video/voice, gaming, DNS — speed matters

> ⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**
>
> Expecting TCP to preserve message boundaries. TCP is a **byte stream**: two `send()`s of 100 bytes may arrive as one `recv()` of 200, or as 50+150. Your protocol must delimit messages itself (length prefix or delimiter). UDP does keep boundaries — one `sendto` = one `recvfrom` — but may drop or reorder them.

13.4 Kernel Networking: NIC, Interrupts, and DMA

Here Part X's I/O machinery does the heavy lifting. When a packet **arrives**:

1. The **NIC** receives the frame off the wire and, via **DMA**, writes it straight into a kernel **receive buffer** in RAM — no CPU copying.
2. The NIC raises an **interrupt** to tell the CPU "a packet is here."
3. The driver's interrupt handler does minimal work, then defers the heavy processing (a "bottom half" / softirq) so the interrupt returns fast.
4. The kernel network stack processes the packet up through IP and TCP (checksums, reassembly, sequencing), placing the payload in the socket's receive buffer.
5. The waiting process's `recv()` unblocks and copies the data into the app's buffer.

> ▣ **KEY CONCEPT — INTERRUPT STORMS AND NAPI**
>
> At high packet rates, one interrupt per packet can swamp the CPU (an "interrupt storm"). Real kernels use **interrupt coalescing** and Linux's **NAPI**, which switches from interrupts to polling under heavy load — the exact polling-vs-interrupt trade-off from Part X, applied to networking. Each packet is held in a kernel buffer structure (Linux's `sk_buff`) as it moves through the layers, avoiding repeated copies.

13.5 Blocking Sockets, Non-Blocking Sockets, and Scale

A simple server dedicates one thread per connection, each blocked in `recv()`. That's easy but doesn't scale: 100,000 connections would need 100,000 threads — enormous memory and context-switch overhead. This is the historic **C10K problem** (handling 10,000+ concurrent connections).

The solution is **non-blocking sockets** plus an **event-notification** system call. One (or a few) threads ask the kernel "which of these thousands of sockets are ready?" and service only those:

- `select` / `poll` — portable but O(n): scan all fds each call.
- `epoll` (Linux) / `kqueue` (BSD/macOS) — scalable, O(1)-ish: the kernel keeps the interest list and returns only the ready fds.
- `io_uring` (modern Linux) — full asynchronous I/O with shared ring buffers, minimizing system calls entirely.

⚑ INTERVIEW TIP

"How does a server handle 100k connections?" Not with 100k threads. Use **non-blocking sockets + an event loop** (`epoll`): a small thread pool waits on the kernel to report which sockets are readable/writable, then handles just those. This is how nginx, Redis, and Node.js scale. The idea traces straight back to non-blocking + async I/O from Part X — networking is just I/O at scale.

✓ Check Your Understanding — Part XIII

CONCEPTUAL

1. Trace the layers a message passes through from `send()` to the wire.
2. Why is a socket "just a file descriptor," and why does that matter?
3. Give three concrete differences between TCP and UDP and a use case for each.
4. How do interrupts and DMA cooperate when a packet arrives?
5. What is the C10K problem and the modern solution?

APPLICATION

1. You `send()` "AB" then "CD" over TCP. List the ways the receiver's two `recv()` calls might split those four bytes, and how you'd fix it.
2. A game needs low latency and tolerates occasional lost position updates. TCP or UDP? Why?
3. Explain why one-thread-per-connection fails at 100k connections and what replaces it.

INTERVIEW-LEVEL

1. "Walk me through what the kernel does from a packet hitting the NIC to your `recv()` returning."
2. "Why is `epoll` more scalable than `select`?"

CAN YOU EXPLAIN THIS? (NO NOTES)

The send-path layer stack · socket = fd · TCP vs UDP · NIC + DMA + interrupt on receive · blocking vs non-blocking and why `epoll` scales.

⚑ PRACTICAL TASK

Run `ss -tunap` (or `netstat -tunap`) to list sockets and the processes owning them. Then `strace -e trace=network curl -s example.com >/dev/null` to watch the exact `socket` / `connect` / `sendto` / `recvfrom` calls a real HTTP request makes — the socket API from this chapter, live.

Mastered when... you can write the five-call TCP server from memory, explain the packet's journey through kernel and NIC, and describe how an event loop scales a server past the thread-per-connection limit.

PART XIV

Linux Practical OS

Theory becomes intuition when you can see it. This part is a hands-on tour of the Linux commands and virtual file systems that let you watch processes, memory, scheduling, and I/O in a live kernel — every command tied back to the concept it reveals.

In this part: `ps`, `top`, `htop` · `kill`, `nice`, `renice` · jobs, `fg`, `bg` · `lsof` · `df`, `du`, `free` · `vmstat`, `iostat` · `strace`, `dmesg` · `/proc`, `/dev`, `/sys`

PART XIV

Linux Practical OS

You can read about processes and page faults forever, but nothing cements them like watching them happen. Every command here is a window onto a concept from earlier parts. Type them. Break things. The kernel is right there, and Linux lets you look inside it.

14.1 Watching Processes: ps, top, htop

Command	What it does	OS concept it shows
`ps`	Snapshot of current processes (PID, state, CPU, memory, command)	Processes, PCB fields, process states (Part II)
`top`	Live, updating view of processes and system load	Scheduling, CPU/memory sharing, states (Parts II, IV)
`htop`	Friendlier interactive `top` (per-core bars, tree view, scroll)	Multi-core, process tree, priorities (Parts III, IV)

EXAMPLE: SEE EVERY PROCESS WITH FULL DETAIL

```
$ ps aux
USER   PID %CPU %MEM   VSZ   RSS STAT  COMMAND
root     1  0.0  0.1 16942  9120 Ss    /sbin/init      # PID 1 = init/systemd
user  2413 12.0  3.4  ...   ...  R     firefox         # R = Running/Runnable
user  2610  0.0  0.1  ...   ...  S     bash            # S = Sleeping (Waiting)
user  3001  0.0  0.0     0     0 Z     <defunct>       # Z = Zombie! (Part II)
```

The **STAT** column is the process state from Part II made visible: `R` runnable, `S` interruptible sleep (waiting), `D` uninterruptible sleep (usually disk I/O), `Z` zombie, `T` stopped. **VSZ** is virtual memory size, **RSS** is resident (physical) memory — the virtual vs physical distinction from Part VII, right there.

14.2 Controlling Processes: kill, nice, renice

Command	What it does	OS concept it shows
`kill`	Send a signal to a process (default `SIGTERM`)	Signals as IPC (Part XI), process termination
`nice`	Start a process with a given scheduling priority	Priority scheduling (Part IV)
`renice`	Change the priority of a running process	Dynamic priority, dispatcher (Part IV)

SIGNALS AND PRIORITIES IN ACTION

```
$ kill 2413            # polite SIGTERM: "please exit"
$ kill -9 2413         # SIGKILL: force-kill, cannot be caught (Part XI)
$ kill -SIGSTOP 2413   # pause it (→ state T);  kill -SIGCONT resumes

$ nice -n 19 ./batch   # lowest priority (19 = nicest, yields CPU to others)
$ sudo renice -5 -p 2413   # raise firefox's priority (negative = higher)
```

▣ KEY CONCEPT — THE NICE VALUE

Linux "niceness" ranges from **−20** (highest priority, least nice) to **+19** (lowest priority, nicest). A "nicer" process yields the CPU to others. This is your hands-on control over the priority scheduler from Part IV — set a CPU-hungry backup job to `nice 19` and it won't disturb your interactive work.

14.3 Job Control: jobs, fg, bg

The shell manages the processes it launches as **jobs**. This is process control and terminal sessions in miniature.

Command	What it does
`Ctrl-Z`	Suspend the foreground job (sends `SIGTSTP` → state T)
`bg`	Resume the suspended job in the **background** (keeps running, frees your prompt)
`fg`	Bring a background job back to the **foreground**
`jobs`	List the shell's jobs and their states
`&`	Start a command directly in the background: `./server &`

14.4 Open Files: lsof

`lsof` ("list open files") reveals every file descriptor every process holds — and since in UNIX everything is a file, that includes regular files, sockets, pipes, and devices. It makes the fd tables from Part IX tangible.

WHAT HAS THIS FILE/PORT OPEN?

```
$ lsof /var/log/syslog     # which processes hold this file open?
$ lsof -i :8080            # which process is listening on port 8080? (sockets = fds)
$ lsof -p 2413             # every fd process 2413 has open
```

14.5 Memory & Disk: free, df, du

Command	What it does	OS concept
`free -h`	Physical RAM and swap usage, including cache	Virtual memory, page cache, swap (Part VIII)
`df -h`	Free space per mounted file system	Mounting, file systems (Part IX)
`du -sh dir`	Disk usage of a directory tree	File allocation, directory trees (Part IX)

READING `FREE` CORRECTLY

```
$ free -h
               total        used        free      shared  buff/cache   available
Mem:            15Gi       4.2Gi       1.1Gi       210Mi       9.9Gi        10Gi
Swap:          2.0Gi          0B       2.0Gi
```

> ⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**
>
> Panicking that "free" is low. Linux deliberately uses "spare" RAM as **page cache** (Part VIII) to speed up file access — that's the `buff/cache` column. It's instantly reclaimable, so the number that matters is **available**, not **free**. "Unused RAM is wasted RAM" is the kernel's philosophy.

14.6 System Activity: vmstat, iostat

Command	What it shows	Watch for
`vmstat 1`	Per-second processes, memory, swap, I/O, CPU	`si` / `so` (swap in/out) → **thrashing** (Part VIII); `r` (run queue length)
`iostat -x 1`	Per-device I/O throughput and utilization	`%util` near 100% → disk is the bottleneck

VMSTAT: WATCH SWAP COLUMNS TO CATCH THRASHING

```
$ vmstat 1
 r  b   swpd   free  buff  cache   si   so    bi    bo   in   cs us sy id wa
 2  0      0  1.1G  120M  9.9G    0    0    12    30  400  900 15  4 80  1
 8  3      0   90M   40M  2.1G  512  480  9000  200 3000 8000 20 30  5 45  # si/so
high, wa high = THRASHING
```

The last line is a system in trouble: high `si` / `so` (swapping), high `wa` (CPU idle waiting on I/O), long run queue `r`. This is exactly the thrashing collapse from Part VIII, visible in real time.

14.7 Seeing the Kernel Boundary: strace, dmesg

Command	What it does	OS concept
`strace`	Traces every **system call** a program makes	The user/kernel boundary made visible (Part I)
`dmesg`	Prints the kernel's message ring buffer (boot, drivers, hardware, OOM)	Boot process, drivers, kernel events (Parts I, X)

STRACE: LITERALLY WATCH A PROGRAM CROSS INTO THE KERNEL

```
$ strace -f ./a.out
execve("./a.out", ...)          = 0
brk(NULL)                       = 0x55...        # heap setup (malloc, Part VII)
openat(AT_FDCWD, "data.txt", O_RDONLY) = 3       # open → fd 3 (Part IX)
read(3, "hello\n", 4096)        = 6              # the actual read syscall
write(1, "hello\n", 6)          = 6              # write to stdout
close(3)                        = 0
exit_group(0)                   = ?
```

⚑ INTERVIEW TIP

`strace` is the single best learning and debugging tool for OS concepts. When someone asks "what system calls does `X` make?" you can show them. It's also how you debug mysterious failures — a program hanging in `read()`, or getting `EACCES` on a file, is obvious in the trace. Mentioning `strace` in an interview signals you actually work with systems, not just theory.

14.8 The Pseudo File Systems: /proc, /sys, /dev

Linux exposes kernel and hardware state as files you can read — the "everything is a file" philosophy taken to its logical end. No special API needed; just `cat`.

/proc

A virtual file system reflecting **kernel and process state**. It doesn't exist on disk — the kernel generates it on read. This is how `ps`, `top`, and `free` get their data.

/proc/[pid]

One directory per running process, named by PID — a live view of that process's PCB: `/proc/1234/status` (state, memory), `/proc/1234/fd/` (its open file descriptors), `/proc/1234/maps` (its virtual memory layout, Part VII), `cmdline`, `environ`.

/sys

Exposes **devices and kernel subsystems** (the device model) — e.g. `/sys/block/sda/queue/scheduler` shows/sets the disk I/O scheduler (Part XII).

/dev

Holds **device files**: `/dev/sda` (a disk), `/dev/null` (the bit bucket), `/dev/random`, `/dev/tty`. Reading/writing these talks to drivers (Part X).

READING KERNEL AND PROCESS STATE AS PLAIN FILES

```
$ cat /proc/cpuinfo                  # every CPU core and its features
$ cat /proc/meminfo                  # detailed memory stats (source of `free`)
$ cat /proc/self/maps                # THIS shell's virtual address space (Part VII)
$ cat /proc/1234/status              # process 1234's live PCB summary
$ ls /proc/1234/fd                   # its open file descriptors (Part IX)
$ echo hi > /dev/null                # discard output into the void
```

▣ KEY CONCEPT

`/proc` and `/sys` are **the kernel talking to you in file form**. Every monitoring tool in this chapter is, underneath, just reading these virtual files and formatting them. Once you know that, you can get any system fact with `cat` — no special tooling required. This is the deepest expression of the UNIX "everything is a file" design.

✓ Check Your Understanding — Part XIV

CONCEPTUAL

1. In `ps`, what do STAT codes R, S, D, Z, T mean, and to which Part II concept does each map?
2. What's the difference between VSZ and RSS, and which Part VII idea is that?
3. Why should you read **available**, not **free**, from `free -h`?
4. What does `strace` reveal, and which boundary does it make visible?
5. What are `/proc` and `/sys`, and where does their data come from?

APPLICATION

1. A backup job is slowing your machine. Which command lowers its CPU priority, and what value would you use?
2. Using `vmstat`, which columns tell you the system is thrashing?
3. A process holds a file you can't delete. Which command finds it, and how?

INTERVIEW-LEVEL

1. "How would you find which process is listening on port 443 and what files it has open?"
2. "A program hangs. Walk me through diagnosing it with `strace` and `/proc`."

CAN YOU EXPLAIN THIS? (NO NOTES)

Mapping `ps` STAT codes to process states · `nice`/`renice` and the scheduler · reading `free` and `vmstat` for VM/thrashing · what `/proc/[pid]` exposes.

⚑ PRACTICAL TASK

Run `sleep 1000 &`, note its PID, then explore: `cat /proc/<pid>/status`, `ls -l /proc/<pid>/fd`, `cat /proc/<pid>/maps | head`. Suspend and resume a foreground job with `Ctrl-Z`, `bg`, `fg`. Finally `strace -c ls` and read the syscall summary. You've now inspected a live process from the outside — exactly what `top` does.

Mastered when... you can pick the right tool to observe any concept from Parts I–XIII on a running system, and read its output back to the underlying theory.

PART XV

Advanced Operating Systems

The ideas that power the modern cloud: running whole operating systems as programs (virtualization), isolating apps with namespaces and cgroups (containers), and the kernel features — CFS, NUMA, ASLR, the page cache — that make it all fast and safe.

In this part: Virtualization & hypervisors · Containers · Namespaces & cgroups · Docker from an OS view · Kernel modules · System init (systemd) · Modern scheduling (CFS) · NUMA · ASLR · Page cache · Memory-mapped I/O · Kernel/user-space communication

PART XV

Advanced Operating Systems

Everything so far runs one OS on one machine. This part scales that up and locks it down: how one machine runs many operating systems, how thousands of containers share one kernel safely, and the kernel mechanisms — modern scheduling, NUMA, ASLR, the page cache — behind today's servers.

15.1 Virtualization and Hypervisors

What. Virtualization runs a whole "virtual machine" (VM) — a complete guest OS with its own virtual CPU, memory, and devices — as software on a host. A **hypervisor** (Virtual Machine Monitor) is the layer that creates and manages VMs, giving each the illusion of owning the hardware while multiplexing the real hardware among them. It's the OS's "resource manager" and "extended machine" ideas (Part I) applied to entire operating systems.

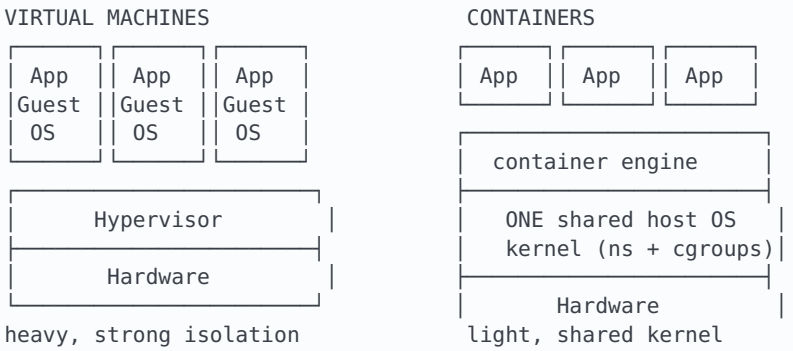
Type 1 (bare-metal)
: Runs directly on the hardware; guests sit on top. Fast, used in data centers. Examples: VMware ESXi, Xen, Microsoft Hyper-V, KVM (turns Linux itself into a Type-1-like hypervisor).

Type 2 (hosted)
: Runs as an application on a normal host OS. Convenient for desktops. Examples: VirtualBox, VMware Workstation.

Hardware assists (Intel VT-x, AMD-V) let guest kernels run privileged instructions safely by trapping into the hypervisor — the same dual-mode idea from Part I, extended with an extra privilege level for the hypervisor beneath the guest kernel.

15.2 Containers: Namespaces and cgroups

The key difference from VMs. A VM virtualizes hardware and runs a full guest kernel. A **container** virtualizes the operating system: containers share the **host's single kernel** but each gets an isolated view of the system. Containers are therefore far lighter (no guest OS to boot, megabytes not gigabytes, start in milliseconds) — at the cost of weaker isolation (a shared kernel is a shared attack surface).



VMs each carry a full guest OS on a hypervisor; containers share one host kernel, isolated by namespaces and cgroups.

Containers are built from two Linux kernel features:

Namespaces — isolation ("what a process can see")

Give a process group its own private view of a system resource. There are namespaces for PIDs (a container sees its own process 1), the mount table (its own filesystem view), the network (its own interfaces/ports), users, hostname (UTS), and IPC. Two containers can each have a "PID 1" because they're in different PID namespaces.

Control groups (cgroups) — limits ("what a process can use")

Meter and cap a process group's CPU, memory, and I/O. A cgroup can say "this container gets at most 2 cores and 512 MB." This is the resource-manager role of the OS (Part I) exposed as a policy knob.

> ▣ **KEY CONCEPT — DOCKER FROM AN OS PERSPECTIVE**
>
> A Docker container is not a lightweight VM. It's an ordinary Linux process (or group of them) running on the host kernel, wrapped in **namespaces** (so it sees only its own PIDs, filesystem, network) and **cgroups** (so its CPU/memory are capped), using a **union filesystem** (layered images) for its root filesystem. Nothing is emulated — it's your kernel's isolation features, packaged. That's why containers start instantly and run at native speed.

15.3 Kernel Modules

A **loadable kernel module** is a piece of kernel code (often a device driver) that can be added to or removed from a running kernel without rebooting or recompiling. This is what makes Linux a **modular** monolithic kernel (Part I): the core is monolithic, but drivers and features plug in on demand.

MANAGING KERNEL MODULES

```
$ lsmod                    # list currently loaded modules
$ sudo modprobe e1000e     # load a network driver (+ dependencies)
$ sudo rmmod e1000e        # unload it
$ modinfo e1000e           # info about a module
```

15.4 System Initialization

After the kernel boots (Part I), it starts exactly one user process: **PID 1**, the **init system**. On modern Linux this is `systemd`. PID 1 is the ancestor of every other process; it launches system services (daemons), mounts filesystems, brings up networking, and adopts orphans (Part II). `systemd` organizes services as **units** with dependencies and starts independent ones in parallel for fast boot.

INTERACTING WITH THE INIT SYSTEM

```
$ systemctl status sshd    # is the SSH daemon running?
$ systemctl start/stop/restart nginx
$ systemctl enable nginx    # start automatically at boot
$ journalctl -u nginx       # view that service's logs
```

15.5 Modern Scheduling and NUMA

CFS. Linux's long-time default scheduler was the **Completely Fair Scheduler**. Instead of fixed time slices, CFS tracks each task's **virtual runtime** (vruntime) — roughly, how much CPU it has consumed, weighted by nice value — and always runs the task with the smallest vruntime, using a red-black tree to pick it in O(log n). The effect: every task gets a fair share of the CPU over time, approximating "infinitely fine" time-slicing. (Newer kernels use EEVDF, a refinement of the same fairness goal.)

NUMA. On multi-socket servers, memory is **Non-Uniform Memory Access**: each CPU has "local" RAM it reaches quickly and "remote" RAM (attached to another CPU) it reaches more slowly. A NUMA-aware OS tries to run a thread on the CPU near the memory it uses, and to allocate a process's memory on its local node — because a remote memory access can be several times slower. It's the memory hierarchy (Part VII) extended across CPU sockets.

15.6 Kernel Memory Features: Page Cache, ASLR, mmap I/O, COW

Page cache

The kernel caches file contents in otherwise-free RAM (Part VIII). A re-read of a file is served from memory, not disk — the `buff/cache` you saw in `free` (Part XIV). Writes are buffered and flushed later. This one feature is why a warm system feels so much faster than a cold one.

Memory-mapped I/O

Via `mmap` (Part VIII), a file or device is mapped into a process's address space so accessing it is just memory access — avoiding `read`/`write` syscalls and extra copies. It's how program executables and shared libraries are loaded (demand-paged directly from disk).

Copy-on-Write

Recap from Part VIII: `fork()` and shared libraries share physical pages read-only and duplicate only on write — the trick that makes process creation and library sharing cheap.

ASLR

Address Space Layout Randomization: the kernel randomizes where a process's stack, heap, libraries, and (with PIE) code are placed in its virtual address space on each run. Because attackers exploiting a buffer overflow need to know target addresses, randomizing them makes many exploits unreliable. A cheap, powerful security-through-uncertainty layer built on virtual memory.

> ⚑ **INTERVIEW TIP**
>
> "How does a container differ from a VM?" One sentence: a VM virtualizes hardware and runs its own guest kernel via a hypervisor; a container shares the host kernel and is isolated by namespaces (visibility) and cgroups (resource limits). Then the trade-off: VMs give stronger isolation and can run different OSes; containers are lighter and faster but share one kernel. That crisp distinction is asked constantly in cloud/DevOps interviews.

15.7 Kernel/User-Space Communication

How does user code exchange information with the kernel, beyond ordinary system calls? A quick map:

- **System calls** — the primary, synchronous request path (Part I).
- **/proc and /sys** — read/write kernel and device state as files (Part XIV).
- **ioctl** — device-specific control operations on a file descriptor.
- **mmap** — share a memory region between kernel and user space (zero-copy).
- **Signals** — kernel → process asynchronous notifications (Part XI).
- **Netlink sockets** — a socket-based channel for configuration/events (used for networking config).

✓ Check Your Understanding — Part XV

CONCEPTUAL

1. Type 1 vs Type 2 hypervisor — define each with examples.
2. How do namespaces and cgroups each contribute to a container?
3. Why is a container not a lightweight VM?
4. What does CFS optimize, and how does vruntime achieve it?
5. What is ASLR and which class of attack does it hinder?

APPLICATION

1. You need to run 500 isolated web apps on one server with fast startup and native speed. Containers or VMs? What isolates them?
2. A thread on a NUMA machine is slow. What memory-placement problem might explain it, and what's the fix?
3. Which Linux features would you use to cap a process to 1 CPU and 256 MB, and give it a private network?

INTERVIEW-LEVEL

1. "Explain, from an OS perspective, exactly what `docker run` sets up."
2. "Why does Linux use free RAM as page cache, and is that a problem?"

CAN YOU EXPLAIN THIS? (NO NOTES)

VM vs container (hypervisor vs namespaces+cgroups) · what makes Linux modular · CFS fairness via vruntime · page cache and ASLR.

⚑ PRACTICAL TASK

If Docker is available: `docker run --rm -it --memory=256m --cpus=1 alpine sh`, then inside run `ps aux` (you're PID 1!) and `hostname`. From the host, find that shell in `ps` — it's a normal host process. You've just seen namespaces (isolated PID/hostname) and cgroups (the limits) in action. Also run `lsmod | head` and `systemctl --type=service`.

Mastered when... you can explain containers and VMs to a non-expert precisely, connect namespaces/cgroups to the OS concepts they implement, and describe how modern kernels schedule and protect memory.

PART XVI

What Happens When…

This is where the whole book comes together. Each of these eighteen everyday events is a guided tour that threads through processes, memory, scheduling, I/O, and the kernel — the exact "walk me through what happens when…" questions interviewers love.

Eighteen end-to-end flows: booting · opening & running a program · `printf`, `malloc`, `fork`, `exec`, `read` · writing a file · a keypress · a mouse move · a packet arriving · RAM full · page fault · context switch · process exit · a thread blocking · two threads racing

PART XVI

What Happens When...

Every concept in this book was a puzzle piece. Here they assemble into complete pictures. Read each flow slowly and notice how many earlier parts it touches — that web of connections is mastery. These are also, almost verbatim, the "explain the whole path" questions asked in senior interviews.

16.1 ...I turn on my computer?

1. Power reaches the CPU, which begins executing **firmware** (UEFI/BIOS) baked into motherboard ROM.
2. Firmware runs **POST** (power-on self-test), initializes hardware, and locates a boot device.
3. It loads the **bootloader** (GRUB) from disk, which loads and decompresses the **kernel** into RAM.
4. The kernel initializes memory management, the scheduler, and drivers, then **mounts the root filesystem**.
5. It starts **PID 1** (`systemd`), the first user process, which launches services, networking, and finally the login prompt.

Touches: firmware/boot (Part I), kernel init, filesystems (IX), init & PID 1 (II, XV).

16.2 ...I open a program (double-click / type its name)?

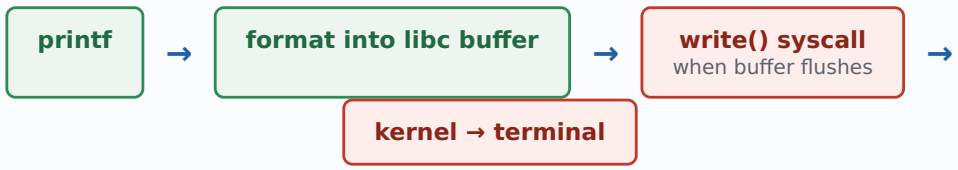
1. The shell/desktop calls `fork()` to create a child process (Part II).
2. The child calls `execve("/path/to/app")`; the kernel replaces its image with the program.
3. The kernel sets up a fresh **virtual address space**, memory-maps the executable and its shared libraries (demand-paged, not fully loaded — Part VIII).
4. The dynamic linker resolves library symbols; the kernel sets the program counter to the entry point.
5. The scheduler marks the process **Ready**; on dispatch it runs. Code and data page in as touched, via page faults.

16.3 ...I execute a C program?

1. `fork` + `exec` load the binary (flow 2). The kernel maps text (code), data, BSS, and sets up the **stack** with `argc` / `argv` /environment.
2. The C runtime startup (`_start` → `__libc_start_main`) initializes the library, then calls your `main()`.

3. `main` runs, using the stack for locals and the heap for `malloc`, crossing into the kernel via system calls for any I/O.
4. `main` returns a status; the runtime calls `exit()`, which flushes buffers and invokes the `exit_group` syscall; the kernel reclaims resources and leaves an exit status for the parent to `wait()` on.

16.4 ...I call printf("hello")?



1. `printf` is a library function: it formats the string ("%d" → digits) into a user-space **buffer**. No kernel involvement yet.
2. The buffer is flushed to **stdout** when it fills, on a newline (if line-buffered to a terminal), or at exit. Flushing calls the `write(1, ...)` **system call** (Part I).
3. The kernel copies the bytes to the terminal device (or file, if redirected) via its driver.

This is why buffering matters: a thousand `printf`s may cause far fewer `write` syscalls (Part I). If output is redirected to a file, it's fully buffered — you may see nothing until `fflush` or exit.

16.5 ...I call malloc(size)?

1. `malloc` is a library allocator, not a syscall. It first tries to satisfy the request from memory it already owns (its **free list** on the heap).
2. If it needs more, it asks the kernel to grow the heap via `brk`/`sbrk`, or maps a fresh region with `mmap` (for large requests).
3. The kernel extends the process's virtual address space but typically **doesn't allocate physical RAM yet** — pages are backed lazily on first access via page faults (flow 14), often via a shared zero page (copy-on-write).
4. `malloc` returns a pointer into that space; the first write to each page triggers the actual physical allocation.

> ⚠ **COMMON MISTAKE**
>
> "`malloc` is a system call." It isn't — it's a user-space library routine that sometimes makes syscalls (`brk`/`mmap`) to get more heap. Most `malloc`s make no syscall at all, reusing already-mapped memory. That's why `malloc` is fast.

16.6 ...I call fork()?

1. The kernel allocates a new **PCB** (`task_struct`) and a new PID for the child.
2. It copies the parent's context — open files, registers, and the address space **logically**, but via **copy-on-write**: parent and child share physical pages marked read-only (Part VIII).
3. The child is placed on the ready queue. `fork` **returns twice**: child's PID to the parent, 0 to the child (Part II).
4. The first time either process writes a shared page, the MMU faults and the kernel copies just that page — so the "copy" cost is paid lazily, only for modified pages.

16.7 ...I call exec()?

1. The kernel **discards** the current process's address space (text, data, heap, stack all gone) — but keeps the same PID and open file descriptors (unless marked close-on-exec).
2. It memory-maps the new program's segments and its shared libraries (demand-paged).
3. It resets the stack, sets registers, and points the program counter at the new program's entry.
4. `exec` **does not return** on success — there's no old code to return to. Execution begins in the new program.

16.8 ...I call read(fd, buf, n)?

1. `read` traps into the kernel (Part I). The kernel uses `fd` to find the open-file entry (and its offset) and the inode (Part IX).
2. If the requested blocks are in the **page cache**, data is copied to `buf` immediately.
3. If not, the kernel issues a disk request, and the process **blocks** (state Waiting) while the disk works via DMA (Part X). The scheduler runs someone else.
4. When the disk completes, it **interrupts**; the kernel copies the data into the cache and `buf`, marks the process Ready, and `read` returns the byte count, advancing the offset.

16.9 ...I write to a file?

1. `write` traps into the kernel, which locates the file via `fd` → inode.
2. The data is copied into the **page cache** and the page marked **dirty**. `write` usually returns immediately — before the data is on disk.
3. The kernel flushes dirty pages to disk **later** (background writeback), or on `fsync`, via the driver and DMA.
4. Metadata changes (size, timestamps) are recorded; on a journaling FS they go through the journal first for crash safety (Part IX).

This "write returns before it hits disk" is why `fsync` exists and why a sudden power loss can lose recent writes still sitting in the cache.

16.10 ...I press a keyboard key?

1. The keyboard controller detects the keypress and raises a hardware **interrupt** (Part I/X).
2. The CPU stops, switches to kernel mode, and runs the keyboard **interrupt handler** in the driver.
3. The driver reads the scancode from the controller, translates it, and places the character in a **buffer** for the terminal/input subsystem.
4. The kernel wakes any process **blocked** on input for that terminal (e.g. your shell in `read`); it becomes Ready and, when scheduled, receives the character.

16.11 ...I move the mouse?

1. The mouse sends movement deltas; the controller raises an **interrupt** for each batch.
2. The driver's handler reads the deltas and posts input events to the kernel's input layer.
3. The windowing system (a user-space process) reads those events, updates the cursor position, and determines which window is under the pointer.
4. It delivers the event to the relevant application, which may redraw — the same interrupt-driven I/O pattern as the keyboard, just higher-frequency.

16.12 ...a network packet arrives?

1. The **NIC** receives the frame and **DMA**s it straight into a kernel receive buffer (Part XIII).
2. The NIC raises an **interrupt**; the driver's handler does minimal work and schedules deferred processing (softirq/NAPI).
3. The kernel network stack processes the packet up through IP and TCP (checksums, ordering, reassembly) and puts the payload in the destination socket's receive buffer.
4. Any process blocked in `recv()` / `epoll` on that socket is marked Ready and gets the data when scheduled.

16.13 ...RAM is full?

1. On the next allocation/page fault needing a frame, the kernel finds **no free frame**.
2. It reclaims memory: drop clean page-cache pages (cheap), and **page out** (swap) chosen pages to disk using a replacement policy (Part VIII).
3. If reclaim keeps up, execution continues (slower). If working sets exceed RAM, the system **thrashes** — constant paging, collapsing throughput (Part VIII).

4. If memory truly runs out (swap full too), the kernel invokes the **OOM killer**, which terminates a chosen memory-hungry process to survive.

16.14 …a page fault occurs?



1. The CPU references a page whose page-table entry is marked not-present; the MMU raises a **page fault** exception (Part I).
2. The kernel's handler checks the address is legal (else `SIGSEGV`), then finds a free frame (evicting one if needed, flow 13).
3. It reads the page from disk (or zero-fills a new page), updates the page table (frame + present bit) and TLB.
4. It **restarts the faulting instruction**, which now succeeds. (A minor fault needs no disk I/O; a major fault does — Part VIII.)

16.15 …a context switch happens?

1. A trigger fires: timer interrupt (time slice up), a blocking syscall, or a higher-priority wakeup.
2. The kernel **saves** the running process's registers and PC into its PCB and updates its state (Running → Ready/Waiting).
3. The scheduler picks the next process; the kernel **restores** its registers/PC and switches the address space (loads its page-table base) — which may flush the TLB (Part II/VII).
4. Execution resumes in the new process. The save/restore + cold caches are pure **overhead**.

16.16 …a process terminates?

1. The process calls `exit(status)` (or receives a fatal signal). The kernel runs it in kernel mode.
2. The kernel **closes** its file descriptors, **frees** its memory (address space, page tables), and releases other resources.
3. It keeps a small **zombie** record (PID + exit status) until the parent `wait()`s (Part II). Any children are **reparented** to PID 1.
4. When the parent reaps it, the PCB is freed and the PID becomes reusable.

16.17 …a thread blocks?

1. The thread performs a blocking operation (I/O, lock acquisition, `wait` on a condition).
2. The kernel changes that thread's state to **Waiting** and puts it on the relevant wait queue.
3. The scheduler picks another **runnable thread** — possibly another thread of the same process (a cheaper switch, no address-space change) or a different process.
4. When the awaited event occurs, the thread is moved to **Ready**; it runs again when scheduled. Note: only that thread blocks — with kernel threads, the process's other threads keep running.

16.18 …two threads modify the same variable?

1. Each thread reads the variable into a register, modifies it, and writes it back — three non-atomic steps (Part III).
2. If their steps **interleave**, one thread's read can predate the other's write, so one update is computed from a stale value and **overwrites** the other — a lost update (a **race condition**).
3. The result depends on timing and is nondeterministic — correct on most runs, wrong occasionally.
4. The fix: make the update **atomic** or wrap it in a **critical section** guarded by a mutex/atomic (Part V), so only one thread modifies it at a time.

> ⚑ **INTERVIEW TIP**
>
> These flows are the highest-value interview preparation in the book. "Walk me through what happens when you run a program / call `malloc` / a page faults" tests whether you truly connect the layers. Practice narrating three or four of these out loud until the cross-references (syscall → kernel → MMU → disk → scheduler) flow naturally. That fluency is exactly what "senior" sounds like.

✓ Check Your Understanding — Part XVI

EXPLAIN EACH END TO END (PICK ANY FIVE AND NARRATE WITHOUT NOTES)

1. Booting from power-on to login.
2. Running a C program from the shell (`fork` + `exec` +runtime+ `main`).
3. A single `printf` — why it may make zero or one `write` syscalls.
4. A page fault, minor vs major.
5. A context switch and where its overhead comes from.

APPLICATION

1. Trace what happens from pressing a key to your shell echoing the character.
2. Trace a network request from your `recv()` back to the NIC.
3. Explain, using flows 13–14, why a memory-starved server slows to a crawl before the OOM killer fires.

CAN YOU EXPLAIN THIS? (NO NOTES)

The `fork` / `exec` program-launch path · `printf` buffering → `write` · the full page-fault path · how a keypress reaches a blocked process.

⚑ PRACTICAL TASK

Pick flow 3 (running a C program) and verify it: write a tiny C program, compile it, and run `strace ./a.out`. Match each syscall in the trace to a step in the flow — `execve`, `brk` / `mmap` (malloc), `openat` / `read`, `write`, `exit_group`. Seeing the flow as real syscalls makes it permanent.

Mastered when... you can narrate any of the eighteen flows smoothly, naming the hardware, the syscalls, the kernel subsystems, and the earlier chapters each step draws on.

PART XVII

Practical Projects

Reading builds recognition; building builds mastery. These sixteen projects rise from a five-line fork demo to a real shell and a custom memory allocator. Each one forces a concept from theory into working code — which is exactly what interviews and real systems work demand.

Beginner: process/fork/zombie/orphan demos · **Intermediate:** mini shell, producer–consumer, thread-safe queue, readers–writers, pipes, shared memory · **Advanced:** memory allocator, scheduler & page-replacement simulators, file-system simulator, thread pool, shell with pipes & redirection

PART XVII

Practical Projects

Do these in order. Each assumes the last, and each turns a chapter you read into a program you wrote. Write them in C on Linux (or WSL/macOS) to feel the real system calls. Keep every project — later ones build on earlier code, and together they make a portfolio that proves you understand operating systems.

17.1 Beginner LEVEL 1

01 Process Creation Demo

OBJECTIVE Create a child process and print both PIDs, proving parent/child identity.

CONCEPTS Processes, PIDs, `fork()`'s double return (Part II).

PLAN Call `fork()`; branch on the return value; print `getpid()`/`getppid()` in each.

MILESTONES (1) fork compiles & runs; (2) both branches print; (3) explain the output order's nondeterminism.

EXPECTED Two lines, one from parent (child's PID) and one from child (0-return path).

EXTENSIONS Fork N children in a loop; build a small process tree and print it.

02 fork / wait Demonstration

OBJECTIVE Have the parent wait for the child and read its exit status.

CONCEPTS Termination, reaping, exit status, synchronization via `wait` (Part II).

PLAN Child does work and `exit(k)`; parent `waitpid()`s and prints `WEXITSTATUS`.

MILESTONES (1) parent blocks until child ends; (2) status decoded; (3) time the child to confirm the wait.

EXPECTED Parent prints the child's exit code after the child finishes.

EXTENSIONS Wait for multiple children; detect a child killed by a signal (`WIFSIGNALED`).

03 Zombie Process Demonstration

OBJECTIVE Deliberately create a zombie and observe it, then eliminate it.

CONCEPTS Zombie processes, the process table, reaping (Part II).

PLAN Child `_exit()`s immediately; parent `sleep(30)` without `wait`.

MILESTONES (1) run `ps -el | grep defunct` and find the `<defunct>` entry; (2) add `wait()`; (3) confirm the zombie is gone.

EXPECTED A visible zombie while the parent naps; none once reaped.

EXTENSIONS Reap asynchronously with a `SIGCHLD` handler instead of a blocking wait.

04 Orphan Process Demonstration

OBJECTIVE Create an orphan and watch it get re-parented to PID 1.

CONCEPTS Orphans, re-parenting, PID 1 (Parts II, XV).

PLAN Parent exits first; child `sleep`s, then prints `getppid()` — now 1.

MILESTONES (1) parent exits before child; (2) child's parent PID becomes 1; (3) explain who reaps it.

EXPECTED The child reports parent PID 1 (systemd) after the original parent dies.

EXTENSIONS Turn the child into a proper daemon with `setsid()`.

17.2 Intermediate LEVEL 2

05 Mini Shell

OBJECTIVE A REPL that runs commands: read a line, run the program, wait, repeat.

CONCEPTS The fork/exec/wait pattern, the shell loop (Part II).

PLAN Loop: print prompt → read line → tokenize → `fork` → child `execvp` → parent `wait`.

MILESTONES (1) run `ls`; (2) handle arguments; (3) built-ins `cd` and `exit`.

EXPECTED A working prompt that runs external commands with arguments.

EXTENSIONS Command history; background `&`; grow this into Project 16.

06 Producer–Consumer

OBJECTIVE Threads producing and consuming through a bounded buffer, correctly.

CONCEPTS Semaphores, mutex, bounded buffer (Part V).

PLAN Two counting semaphores (`empty`, `full`) + a mutex; producer/consumer threads.

MILESTONES (1) single producer/consumer; (2) multiple of each; (3) verify no item lost/duplicated.

EXPECTED Every produced item consumed exactly once, no corruption, no deadlock.

EXTENSIONS Swap semaphores for condition variables; benchmark throughput vs buffer size.

07 Thread-Safe Queue

OBJECTIVE A generic concurrent queue safe for many producers/consumers.

CONCEPTS Mutexes, condition variables, blocking semantics (Part V).

PLAN `enqueue` / `dequeue` guarded by a mutex; `dequeue` waits on a condvar when empty.

MILESTONES (1) correct under 1+1 threads; (2) stress with 8+8; (3) clean shutdown signal.

EXPECTED No races or lost wakeups under heavy concurrent load.

EXTENSIONS Bounded variant (block on full); lock-free version with CAS (Part V).

08 Readers–Writers

OBJECTIVE Allow concurrent readers but exclusive writers on a shared resource.

CONCEPTS Reader/writer coordination, starvation trade-offs (Part V).

PLAN Reader counter + counter mutex + resource semaphore; first-in/last-out reader logic.

MILESTONES (1) many readers overlap; (2) a writer excludes all; (3) demonstrate writer starvation, then fix it.

EXPECTED Readers run in parallel; writers get exclusive access; data stays consistent.

EXTENSIONS Implement writer-preference; compare fairness.

09 IPC Using Pipes

OBJECTIVE Two processes exchanging data through a pipe.

CONCEPTS Pipes, fds, closing unused ends, EOF (Part XI).

PLAN `pipe()` then `fork()`; parent writes, child reads and processes.

MILESTONES (1) send one message; (2) stream many; (3) implement `cmd1 | cmd2` with `dup2`.

EXPECTED Child receives exactly what the parent sent; clean EOF on writer close.

EXTENSIONS Named pipe (FIFO) between two unrelated programs.

10 Shared-Memory Program

OBJECTIVE Two processes communicating via a shared memory segment, synchronized.

CONCEPTS Shared memory, `mmap`, semaphores for sync (Parts VIII, XI).

PLAN `shm_open` + `mmap` a region; a named semaphore orders writer→reader.

MILESTONES (1) both map the same region; (2) writer's data visible to reader; (3) add the semaphore to fix races.

EXPECTED Reader sees exactly what the writer wrote, in order, no tearing.

EXTENSIONS A ring buffer in shared memory; benchmark vs the pipe version.

17.3 Advanced LEVEL 3

11 Custom Memory Allocator

OBJECTIVE Implement your own `malloc` / `free` over a heap you request from the kernel.

CONCEPTS Heap, `sbrk` / `mmap`, free lists, fragmentation (Parts VII, XVI).

PLAN Grab memory with `sbrk` / `mmap`; manage blocks with headers; free-list allocation (first/best fit); coalesce on free.

MILESTONES (1) allocate/free fixed sizes; (2) reuse freed blocks; (3) split & coalesce; (4) handle alignment.

EXPECTED A drop-in allocator that passes a stress test of random alloc/free without leaking or corrupting.

EXTENSIONS Size classes / bins (like a real allocator); measure fragmentation.

12 Mini Scheduler Simulator

OBJECTIVE Simulate FCFS, SJF, SRTF, Priority, and Round Robin on a process table.

CONCEPTS Scheduling algorithms, metrics (Part IV).

PLAN Read (AT, BT[, priority]); simulate the clock; output Gantt order and average WT/TAT/RT.

MILESTONES (1) FCFS correct; (2) add preemptive SRTF & RR with a quantum; (3) verify against the Part IV worked examples.

EXPECTED Matches the hand-computed numbers from Part IV for every algorithm.

EXTENSIONS Add MLFQ; plot average waiting time vs quantum for RR.

13 Page-Replacement Simulator

OBJECTIVE Count page faults for FIFO, LRU, and Optimal on a reference string.

CONCEPTS Demand paging, replacement, Belady's anomaly (Part VIII).

PLAN Input reference string + frame count; simulate each policy; count faults.

MILESTONES (1) FIFO; (2) LRU & Optimal; (3) reproduce Belady's anomaly with FIFO at 3 vs 4 frames.

EXPECTED Reproduces Part VIII's numbers (7/9/10) and demonstrates Belady.

EXTENSIONS Add Clock/second-chance; sweep frame counts and plot the fault curve.

14 File-System Simulator

OBJECTIVE A tiny in-memory (or single-file) file system with inodes and a directory.

CONCEPTS Inodes, block allocation, free-space bitmap, directories (Part IX).

PLAN Model a superblock, inode table, data blocks, and a bitmap; implement `create` / `write` / `read` / `delete` / `ls`.

MILESTONES (1) create & list files; (2) read/write via indexed blocks; (3) delete & reclaim blocks; (4) persist to a file.

EXPECTED A working mini-FS you can format, populate, unmount, and re-mount.

EXTENSIONS Add indirect blocks for large files; add a simple journal.

15 Thread Pool

OBJECTIVE A fixed set of worker threads pulling tasks from a shared queue.

CONCEPTS Threads, thread-safe queue (Project 7), work distribution (Parts III, V).

PLAN Spawn N workers that block on your thread-safe queue; a `submit(task)` enqueues work; graceful shutdown.

MILESTONES (1) workers run submitted tasks; (2) balanced load; (3) clean shutdown drains or cancels tasks.

EXPECTED Tasks execute concurrently across exactly N threads with no races.

EXTENSIONS Return futures/results; dynamically size the pool by load.

16 Mini Unix Shell with Pipes & Redirection

OBJECTIVE Extend Project 5 into a real shell: pipelines and I/O redirection.

CONCEPTS `fork` / `exec`, `pipe`, `dup2`, fds, job control (Parts II, IX, XI).

PLAN Parse `a | b | c` and `< in` / `> out`; wire pipes with `dup2`; fork one child per stage.

MILESTONES (1) single redirection; (2) two-command pipe; (3) N-stage pipeline; (4) background jobs & `SIGINT` handling.

EXPECTED `cat file | grep foo | sort > out.txt` works end to end.

EXTENSIONS `jobs` / `fg` / `bg`; globbing; environment variables.

⚑ INTERVIEW TIP

Projects 5/16 (a shell), 11 (an allocator), and 15 (a thread pool) are gold for interviews: they're common "implement this" prompts and instant credibility on a resume. If you build only three from this list, build those — and be ready to explain every system call and synchronization decision in them.

✓ Milestone Checklist — Part XVII

PROGRESSION GOALS

1. **Level 1 done when** you can create, wait for, and reason about processes and can produce/eliminate a zombie and an orphan on purpose.
2. **Level 2 done when** you have a working shell, a correct producer–consumer and readers–writers, and can move data by both pipe and shared memory.
3. **Level 3 done when** your allocator, scheduler and page-replacement simulators match this book's worked numbers, and your shell runs real pipelines.

PORTFOLIO BAR

A single repository containing your shell (16), allocator (11), thread pool (15), and the two simulators (12, 13), each with a short README explaining the OS concepts it demonstrates, is a genuinely strong systems-programming portfolio.

Mastered when... you can start any of these from a blank file, explain each system call as you type it, and debug it with `strace` / `gdb` when it misbehaves.

PART XVIII

Interview Mastery

Over a hundred real operating-systems interview questions, laddered from warm-ups to senior-level, each with a model answer you could say out loud. The highest-value ones come with the follow-up you'll get next and the trap that catches most candidates.

Four levels: Beginner (fundamentals) · Intermediate (mechanisms & trade-offs) · Advanced (internals & performance) · Deep / Senior (design & "why") — 100+ questions with model answers.

PART XVIII

Interview Mastery

These are the questions, in the words interviewers actually use. Read the model answer, then close the book and say it in your own words — fluency, not recognition, is what's tested. Answers are deliberately compact: enough to be correct and complete, short enough to memorize the shape of.

18.1 Level 1 — Beginner FUNDAMENTALS

Q What is an operating system?

A Software that manages hardware resources and provides an abstraction layer so programs use the hardware safely and portably. Two jobs: resource manager (CPU, memory, devices) and extended machine (files, processes, virtual memory).

Q What is a kernel?

A The core of the OS — always resident, runs in privileged mode, and directly manages processes, memory, and devices. When we say "the OS did X," we usually mean the kernel.

Q Difference between user mode and kernel mode?

A Kernel mode can run any instruction and access all memory/devices; user mode is restricted (no privileged instructions, only its own memory). Applications run in user mode; the kernel in kernel mode. The switch happens via syscall, interrupt, or exception. **Trap:** a program can't switch itself — only those three hardware-mediated doorways cross the line.

Q Program vs process?

A A program is a passive file on disk; a process is a program in execution with its own memory, registers, PC, and PID. One program → many processes.

Q Process vs thread?

A A process has its own address space; threads live inside a process and share its code, data, and heap, keeping only their own stack, registers, and PC. Threads are cheaper to create and switch; a process crash is isolated, a thread crash can take down the whole process.

Q What is a system call?

A The controlled entry point through which a user program requests a kernel service (open, read, fork). It traps into kernel mode, runs the service, and returns. It's the only way to do anything privileged.

Q API vs system call?

A An API is the function set your code calls (libc's `printf`, `fopen`); a system call is the kernel entry beneath (`write`, `open`). APIs may wrap zero, one, or many syscalls.

Q What are the process states?

A New, Ready, Running, Waiting/Blocked, Terminated. Ready→Running is dispatch; Running→Ready is preemption; Running→Waiting is blocking on I/O; Waiting→Ready is wakeup. **Trap:** Waiting goes to Ready, not straight to Running.

Q What is a PCB?

A Process Control Block — the kernel structure holding all state of a process: PID, state, PC, registers, scheduling info, memory maps, open files. It's what a context switch saves and restores.

Q What is context switching?

A Saving the running process's state (registers, PC) into its PCB and restoring another's, so the CPU can switch processes. It's overhead — no application work happens during the switch.

Q What does fork() do?

A Creates a near-exact copy of the calling process (the child). Returns twice: child's PID to the parent, 0 to the child. Uses copy-on-write so it's cheap.

Q What does exec() do?

A Replaces the current process's memory image with a new program (same PID). Doesn't return on success. Combined with fork, it's how shells launch commands.

Q Zombie vs orphan process?

A A zombie has terminated but its parent hasn't reaped it (wasting a PCB slot); an orphan is still running but its parent died (adopted by PID 1). **Trap:** you can't `kill -9` a zombie — it's already dead; kill the parent instead.

Q What is a daemon?

A A long-running background service with no controlling terminal (sshd, cron), created by forking, exiting the parent, and calling `setsid()`.

Q What is a race condition?

A When the result depends on the timing/interleaving of threads accessing shared data with at least one writing. Fix with mutual exclusion over the critical section.

Q What is a critical section?

A Code that accesses shared data and must be executed by only one thread at a time.

Q What is a deadlock?

A A set of processes each blocked waiting for a resource another holds, in a circle, so none can proceed. Needs all four Coffman conditions.

Q What is virtual memory?

A An illusion that each process has a large private memory, with only the actively used pages in RAM and the rest on disk, brought in on demand. Enables running programs larger than RAM and strong isolation.

Q What is a page fault?

A The exception raised when a process references a page not currently in RAM. The OS loads it from disk, updates the page table, and restarts the instruction. Not an error — the normal demand-paging signal.

Q What is thrashing?

A When the system spends more time paging than executing because working sets exceed RAM. CPU utilization collapses. Fix: fewer processes, more RAM, working-set control.

Q What is the TLB?

A A small fast cache in the MMU holding recent virtual→physical translations, so most memory accesses skip the page-table walk. Exploits locality; a hit is ~1 cycle.

Q Paging vs segmentation?

A Paging splits memory into fixed-size pages (hardware, transparent, internal fragmentation); segmentation splits by logical units of variable size (programmer-visible, external fragmentation). Modern systems use paging.

Q What is an inode?

A The on-disk structure holding a file's metadata and data-block pointers — everything except the file's name (which lives in the directory) and its data.

Q Hard link vs soft link?

A A hard link is another name for the same inode (shares data; survives deleting the original; same FS only). A soft link is a small file containing a path (can cross FSs and link dirs; dangles if the target is removed).

Q What is a mutex?

A A lock with an owner used for mutual exclusion: lock before the critical section, unlock after; only the locker may unlock. A blocked thread sleeps.

Q What is a semaphore?

A An integer counter with atomic `wait`/`signal`, used to count resources or signal between threads. Binary (0/1) for mutual exclusion; counting (0..N) for N resources.

Q Concurrency vs parallelism?

A Concurrency is dealing with many tasks over overlapping time (possibly interleaved on one core); parallelism is executing many simultaneously on multiple cores. Concurrency is structure; parallelism is execution.

Q What is a device driver?

A Kernel code that knows a specific device controller's registers and presents a uniform interface to the OS, keeping the rest of the kernel device-independent.

18.2 Level 2 — Intermediate MECHANISMS & TRADE-OFFS

Q Mutex vs semaphore — which for what?

A Mutex = ownership + mutual exclusion (protect data). Semaphore = counter + signaling (count resources or order threads). Use a mutex to guard a critical section; a semaphore to coordinate. **Trap:** a binary semaphore ≠ a mutex — no ownership, so any thread can signal it.

Q Spinlock vs mutex?

A A spinlock busy-waits (burns CPU, no context switch — good for very short critical sections on multicore); a mutex sleeps (frees the CPU, pays two switches — good for longer waits). On a single core, spinning is disastrous.

Q Why are system calls expensive?

A Each costs a mode switch (save/restore state, enter/leave kernel), the kernel's validation and work, and cache/pipeline disruption. That's why libraries buffer and systems batch I/O (writev, io_uring).

Q Why does context switching have overhead?

A Direct cost: saving/restoring registers and switching address spaces. Indirect cost: the new process starts with cold caches and a possibly-flushed TLB, running slower until they warm. Thread switches within a process are cheaper (same address space).

Q Preemptive vs non-preemptive scheduling?

A Preemptive can forcibly pause a running process (timer/priority) — better responsiveness, more switches; non-preemptive runs a process until it finishes or blocks — simpler, but a long job blocks others. Modern OSes are preemptive.

Q Explain FCFS, SJF, and Round Robin trade-offs.

A FCFS: simple, suffers the convoy effect. SJF: optimal average waiting time but needs burst times and can starve long jobs. RR: fair, great response time, but average waiting time depends on quantum tuning.

Q What is the convoy effect?

A Short processes stuck waiting behind one long process (classic FCFS), inflating average waiting time — like cars behind a slow truck.

Q Why does starvation happen and how do you fix it?

A A process is indefinitely denied the CPU/resource because others are always preferred (priority, SJF, SSTF). Fix with aging — raise priority the longer it waits.

Q Name the four Coffman conditions.

A Mutual exclusion, hold-and-wait, no preemption, circular wait. All four must hold for deadlock; breaking any one prevents it. Circular wait is easiest to break (lock ordering).

Q How do you prevent deadlock in real code?

A Lock ordering — always acquire locks in a fixed global order, breaking circular wait. Also: request all resources up front (breaks hold-and-wait), or use try-lock with back-off.

Q What is the Banker's Algorithm?

A A deadlock-avoidance algorithm: grant a resource request only if the resulting state is safe (a sequence exists letting every process finish). Needs max claims declared in advance.

Q Safe state vs unsafe state — does unsafe mean deadlock?

A Safe: a sequence exists where all can finish. Unsafe: no such guarantee — deadlock is possible but not certain. Avoidance simply never enters unsafe states.

Q Deadlock vs livelock vs starvation?

A Deadlock: all blocked, no motion. Livelock: busy but no progress (keep reacting to each other). Starvation: system progresses but one process never gets its turn.

Q Internal vs external fragmentation?

A Internal: wasted space inside an allocated block (fixed partitions/paging's last page). External: free memory scattered in holes too small to use (variable partitions). Paging cures external, adds a little internal.

Q How does address translation work?

A Split the virtual address into page number + offset. The MMU checks the TLB; on a miss it walks the page table to map page→frame; physical address = frame×pagesize + offset.

Q FIFO vs LRU vs Optimal page replacement?

A FIFO evicts oldest (simple, suffers Belady's anomaly). LRU evicts least-recently-used (approximates Optimal via locality, costly to implement exactly). Optimal evicts the page used farthest in the future (best, but unimplementable).

Q What is Belady's anomaly?

A For FIFO, adding frames can increase page faults. Stack algorithms (LRU, Optimal) are immune.

Q What is copy-on-write?

A After fork, parent and child share physical pages read-only; a page is duplicated only when one writes it. Makes fork cheap and defers/avoids copying.

Q Contiguous vs linked vs indexed allocation?

A Contiguous: fast access, external fragmentation, hard to grow. Linked: no fragmentation/easy growth, but no random access. Indexed (inodes): fast random access, no external fragmentation, small overhead — the modern choice.

Q Polling vs interrupt-driven I/O vs DMA?

A Polling: CPU busy-waits and moves every byte (wasteful). Interrupt-driven: CPU works, device interrupts when ready (no waiting, but per-unit interrupts). DMA: hardware moves whole blocks to RAM, one interrupt per block (CPU nearly free).

Q Buffering vs caching?

A A buffer holds data in transit (the only copy, moving A→B); a cache holds a duplicate of data stored elsewhere to speed future access. Buffer smooths a transfer; cache avoids a repeat.

Q Blocking vs non-blocking vs sync vs async I/O?

A Blocking/non-blocking = whether the call returns immediately. Sync/async = whether the work completes before you proceed. High-scale servers use non-blocking + event notification (epoll) or full async (io_uring).

Q TCP vs UDP?

A TCP: connection-oriented, reliable, ordered, flow/congestion control, byte stream — web, files, SSH. UDP: connectionless, best-effort, low overhead, keeps message boundaries — video, games, DNS.

Q Why is a socket "just a file descriptor"?

A The OS models a network endpoint as an fd, so read/write and select/epoll work uniformly across files, pipes, and sockets — the "everything is a file" design.

Q Fastest IPC mechanism and its catch?

A Shared memory — no kernel copy after setup. Catch: it provides no synchronization, so you must add semaphores/mutexes. Message passing is slower (kernel-copied) but safer.

Q SSTF vs SCAN disk scheduling?

A SSTF serves the nearest request (efficient, can starve far requests). SCAN (elevator) sweeps to the end and back, serving all — no starvation, fairer. LOOK is SCAN without traveling to the physical edge.

Q RAID 0 vs 1 vs 5 vs 10?

A 0 = striping (speed, no safety). 1 = mirroring (safety, 50% capacity). 5 = striping + distributed parity (survives 1 disk, efficient). 10 = mirror+stripe (fast and safe, 50% capacity). **Trap:** RAID isn't a backup.

Q What is journaling and why does it help?

A The FS writes intended changes to a journal before applying them, so a crash mid-update is recovered by replaying/discarding the journal — no full scan, no torn state.

Q User-level vs kernel-level threads?

A User-level: managed by a library, fast, but one blocking call blocks all and no multicore. Kernel-level: scheduled by the kernel, true parallelism, blocking affects only that thread. Modern OSes use kernel threads (1:1).

Q Why can too many threads reduce performance?

A Beyond core count you gain no parallelism but pay more context switches, lock contention, and cache thrashing. Sweet spot ≈ one thread per core for CPU-bound work.

Q What is a monitor?

A A high-level construct bundling shared data with operations under automatic mutual exclusion, plus condition variables for waiting. Java's `synchronized` is a monitor.

Q Why must condition-variable waits use a while loop?

A After waking, the condition may no longer hold (another thread changed it, or a spurious wakeup). Rechecking in a `while` guarantees correctness.

18.3 Level 3 — Advanced INTERNALS & PERFORMANCE

Q Walk me through exactly what happens when I run a program.

A Shell forks; child execve's the binary; kernel builds a fresh address space and memory-maps the executable + libraries (demand-paged); dynamic linker resolves symbols; PC set to entry; scheduler marks it Ready; pages fault in as touched; C runtime calls main.

Q What happens during malloc()?

A malloc (a user-space allocator) serves from its free list if possible; else grows the heap via `brk` or `mmap`. The kernel extends the virtual space but backs pages lazily on first write (often via a COW zero page). Most mallocs make no syscall.

Q What happens during read()?

A Traps to kernel; resolves fd→open-file→inode; if data is in the page cache, copies it out; else issues a disk request and blocks the process (DMA does the transfer); on completion interrupt, data lands in cache + buffer, process becomes Ready, read returns and advances the offset.

Q What happens on a page fault, in hardware and software?

A MMU raises the fault (present bit 0); kernel validates the address, gets a free frame (evicting one if needed), reads the page from disk (or zero-fills), updates page table + TLB, and restarts the faulting instruction. Minor faults skip disk; major faults don't.

Q What happens when you type a command in a terminal?

A Keypresses interrupt the CPU; the driver buffers characters and wakes the shell blocked in read; the shell parses the line, forks, the child execs the command (wiring pipes/redirection with dup2), the parent waits; output is written back to the terminal.

Q How does a server handle 100k concurrent connections?

A Not one thread per connection. Non-blocking sockets + an event loop (epoll/kqueue): a few threads ask the kernel which sockets are ready and service only those. This is how nginx/Redis/Node scale (the C10K solution).

Q Explain the effective access time with a TLB.

A EAT = hit_ratio×(TLB + mem) + miss_ratio×(TLB + 2×mem). High hit rates (>99%, thanks to locality) keep it near a single memory access despite the extra page-table read on misses.

Q Why does the OS keep free RAM as page cache?

A Idle RAM is wasted RAM. Caching file data in free memory turns repeat reads into memory hits and buffers writes. It's instantly reclaimable, so "low free" isn't a problem — watch "available."

Q Difference between the buffer cache and the page cache?

A Historically the buffer cache held disk blocks and the page cache held file pages; modern Linux unified them — file data is cached as pages, keyed by (inode, offset), serving both reads and mmap.

Q How does copy-on-write interact with fork+exec?

A fork shares pages COW; if the child immediately execs, the shared pages are discarded before most are ever written — so almost no copying happens. COW makes the common fork-then-exec path nearly free.

Q What is a major vs minor page fault?

A Minor: the page is in memory (e.g. page cache or shared) and just needs a page-table mapping — no disk I/O. Major: the page must be read from disk/swap — expensive. `/usr/bin/time -v` reports both.

Q How do multi-level page tables save space?

A They page the page table itself: unused regions of the address space simply have no lower-level tables, so a sparse address space costs little. Trade-off: a TLB miss walks several levels.

Q What is an inverted page table?

A One system-wide table with an entry per physical frame (not per virtual page), saving space on huge address spaces; needs a hash to look up (process, page)→frame.

Q Monolithic vs microkernel — trade-offs?

A Monolithic: services in kernel space, fast, but a driver bug can crash the kernel. Microkernel: services in user space, robust and modular, but slower (message passing). Linux is modular monolithic; QNX/seL4 are microkernels.

Q How does the CFS scheduler work?

A It tracks each task's virtual runtime (CPU consumed, weighted by nice) and always runs the task with the smallest vruntime, picked from a red-black tree in O(log n) — approximating perfectly fair time-slicing.

Q Container vs VM?

A A VM virtualizes hardware and runs its own guest kernel on a hypervisor (strong isolation, heavy). A container shares the host kernel, isolated by namespaces (visibility) and cgroups (limits) — light, fast, weaker isolation.

Q What are namespaces and cgroups?

A Namespaces isolate what a process sees (PIDs, mounts, network, users); cgroups limit what it can use (CPU, memory, I/O). Together they implement containers.

Q What is ASLR and what does it defend against?

A Address Space Layout Randomization randomizes the placement of stack, heap, libraries, and (with PIE) code each run, so attackers can't predict addresses for buffer-overflow exploits.

Q Explain the producer-consumer deadlock ordering bug.

A If the producer locks the mutex before `wait(empty)` on a full buffer, it sleeps holding the mutex; the consumer can never lock the mutex to make space → deadlock. Always `wait(semaphore)` before `lock(mutex)`.

Q How does TCP preserve reliability the OS must implement?

A Sequence numbers, acknowledgments, retransmission on loss/timeout, reordering, checksums, and flow/congestion control — all in the kernel's TCP stack, so the app just reads a clean byte stream.

Q Why does write() often return before data hits disk?

A The kernel copies data into the page cache, marks it dirty, and returns; background writeback flushes later. Use `fsync` for durability. This is why sudden power loss can lose recent writes.

Q What is priority inversion and how is it solved?

A A high-priority task waits on a lock held by a low-priority task that a medium task keeps preempting — so the high task is effectively blocked by the medium one. Fix: priority inheritance (the holder temporarily inherits the waiter's priority).

Q How does mmap differ from read/write?

A mmap maps a file into the address space so access is plain memory access (demand-paged), avoiding syscalls per access and extra copies, and enabling shared file pages. read/write copy through the kernel each call.

Q What is the dispatcher vs the scheduler?

A The scheduler decides which process runs next (policy); the dispatcher performs the actual context switch and hands the CPU over (mechanism). Dispatch latency is the time for that switch.

Q How does the OS choose a victim page under memory pressure?

A A replacement policy (approximating LRU via the clock/second-chance algorithm using reference bits) plus reclaiming clean cache pages first; dirty pages must be written back before eviction.

Q What is an interrupt storm and how do NICs mitigate it?

A At high packet rates, one interrupt per packet overwhelms the CPU. Interrupt coalescing and NAPI switch to polling under load — the polling-vs-interrupt trade-off applied to networking.

Q Why can't you always preempt to break a deadlock?

A Preemption only works for resources whose state can be saved/restored (CPU, memory). You can't preempt a printer mid-page or a lock protecting a half-updated structure without corruption.

Q What happens when RAM fills up completely?

A The kernel reclaims cache and swaps pages to disk; if working sets exceed RAM it thrashes; if swap is also exhausted, the OOM killer terminates a chosen process to survive.

18.4 Level 4 — Deep / Senior DESIGN & WHY

Q Why separate fork and exec instead of one "spawn" call?

A The gap between them lets the child customize its environment — redirect stdin/stdout, set up pipes, change uid, close fds — before becoming the new program. That flexibility (how shells build pipelines) is why UNIX split them. (Windows' single CreateProcess trades that flexibility for fewer steps.)

Q How would you design a scheduler for a mixed interactive + batch workload?

A A multilevel feedback queue: new/interactive tasks start high with short quanta for responsiveness; CPU-bound tasks sink to lower, longer-quantum queues for throughput; aging prevents starvation. It self-classifies without knowing burst times.

Q Design a thread-safe, high-throughput bounded queue.

A Mutex + two condition variables (not-full, not-empty), predicate loops on both; or a lock-free ring buffer with CAS and memory barriers for the highest throughput. Discuss the trade-off: simplicity/correctness vs contention.

Q When would you choose processes over threads?

A When isolation/fault-tolerance matters (a crash mustn't take down siblings — e.g. browser tab-per-process), for security boundaries, or to sidestep a shared-memory bug surface / a GIL. Threads when you need cheap shared-memory concurrency.

Q Why is shared mutable state the root of concurrency bugs?

A Because non-atomic read-modify-write on shared data can interleave, producing lost updates and inconsistent views. Remedies in order of preference: don't share (immutability/locals), share immutable data, or synchronize (locks/atomics). "Share nothing" scales best.

Q Explain memory ordering and why locks aren't only about mutual exclusion.

A CPUs and compilers reorder memory operations; without barriers, one thread may see another's writes out of order. Locks (and atomics with the right memory order) also impose happens-before ordering, making writes visible — not just excluding concurrent access.

Q How do modern kernels reduce system-call and I/O overhead?

A Batching (writev/readv), vDSO (serving cheap calls like `gettimeofday` without a real trap), zero-copy (`sendfile`, mmap), and io_uring (shared submission/completion rings that amortize or eliminate per-op syscalls).

Q Why is measuring "CPU utilization" misleading during I/O waits?

A A process blocked on I/O isn't using the CPU, so utilization can look low while the system is I/O-bound (high iowait). Conversely, thrashing shows the CPU "busy" doing paging I/O. Look at run-queue length, iowait, and per-device utilization together.

Q How does virtual memory enable features beyond "more RAM"?

A Isolation (per-process spaces), copy-on-write, memory-mapped files and shared libraries, demand loading, guard pages, mmap-based IPC, and ASLR — all fall out of the indirection between virtual and physical addresses.

Q Design the memory system for a database that must not lose committed data.

A Write-ahead logging (log the change durably with `fsync` before acknowledging commit), a buffer pool it manages itself (often bypassing the page cache with O_DIRECT for control), checkpointing, and careful fsync/barrier ordering — the same journaling idea as filesystems.

Q Why do microkernels persist despite being "slower"?

A For high-assurance/safety-critical systems (avionics, cars — QNX; formally verified seL4), fault isolation and verifiability outweigh raw speed. A driver crash restarts a server instead of panicking the kernel.

Q What are the trade-offs of larger page sizes (huge pages)?

A Larger pages mean fewer TLB entries cover more memory (fewer TLB misses — great for big-memory apps like databases), but more internal fragmentation and coarser granularity for paging. Hence transparent/explicit huge pages as an option, not a default.

Q How does an OS provide isolation and still allow fast IPC?

A Default isolation via per-process address spaces (MMU-enforced), with explicit, kernel-mediated holes: shared memory (fast, you synchronize), pipes/sockets (safe, kernel-copied), and zero-copy paths (mmap, splice) for volume. The kernel is the trusted mediator.

Q Explain the trade-off between throughput and latency in scheduling and I/O.

A Batching and large quanta raise throughput (amortize overhead) but hurt latency/responsiveness; small quanta and preemption improve latency but add overhead. The right point depends on workload — interactive systems favor latency, batch/HPC favor throughput.

Q Why is "everything is a file" a powerful design?

A One uniform interface (open/read/write/close + select/epoll) works across files, devices, pipes, and sockets, so tools compose and the same syscalls/multiplexing serve every resource. It minimizes special cases — the essence of good abstraction (Part I).

Q How would you debug a rare production deadlock?

A Capture stacks of all threads (`gdb`/core, `/proc/[pid]/task/*/stack`, `py-spy`-style tools); identify the lock cycle (who holds what, who waits on what); confirm inconsistent lock ordering; fix by imposing a global order or using try-lock with backoff. Add lock-order assertions to catch regressions.

Q Why might adding CPU cores not speed up a program (Amdahl's Law)?

A Speedup is capped by the serial fraction: if 20% must run serially, max speedup is 5× no matter how many cores. Lock contention, memory bandwidth, and coordination add further limits. Scaling requires reducing the serial/contended portion, not just adding cores.

Q How do you choose between blocking threads and an async event loop?

A Blocking-per-task is simplest and fine at modest concurrency (thousands). Async/event loops win at very high concurrency or I/O-bound fan-out (tens of thousands of mostly-idle connections) by avoiding per-task thread cost — at the price of more complex, callback/await-structured code.

Q What consistency guarantees does the OS give for concurrent file writes?

A A single `write` up to PIPE_BUF (pipes) or within one syscall is often atomic, but interleaved writes from multiple processes can mix without external coordination; ordering/durability need `O_APPEND`, locks (`flock`/`fcntl`), and `fsync`. Don't assume more atomicity than POSIX promises.

Q If you could add one hardware feature to simplify the OS, what and why?

A A strong answer names a real tension — e.g. richer atomic primitives (transactional memory) to simplify synchronization, tagged/ capability memory for isolation, or better TLB/ASID management to cut context-switch cost — and explains which OS pain it removes. The point is showing you know where the OS fights the hardware.

> ⚑ **HOW TO USE THIS BANK**
>
> Don't memorize wording — memorize the shape: lead with a one-sentence answer, then the mechanism, then the trade-off, then a real example if asked. Interviewers probe with "why?" and "what if?" — the follow-ups here rehearse exactly that. Pair this with Part XX's comparison tables and Part XVI's flows for complete coverage.